



SPEAK NO EVIL. HEAR NO EVIL...

THE
SERIAL
KILLER
SUPPORT
NETWORK

D B STEPHENS



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For my mum and dad.

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Chapter One

THE CARETAKER

In his dimly lit bedroom, the only light source came from a television playing a series he had no interest in, its volume turned off, the silence consuming. He picked up a roll of black industrial-strength gaffer tape, and enjoyed the weight of it in his hand. It would be easier to do what he needed to do with the light on. But he needed to be able to prepare with his eyes closed. He pulled at the end of the tape, the familiar sound of the rip as the adhesive unbound from the reel comforting and frightening all at once. Taking the end, he knelt on one knee, and began to wrap it around his right ankle, three loops, taping his overalls to the size ten wellington boots he knew he had to wear. Once his right leg was secure, he repeated the process on the left. He worked quietly, calmly. There was no rush. The repetition of the movements was hypnotic, perfectly choreographed. He wanted this process to be muscle memory, as natural as breathing. So when the time came, and the adrenaline he knew he would feel spiked, he could still do his job properly. Once he had wrapped both legs, he bound his wrists in the same way, taping his gloves to the sleeves of his overalls. Sealing them in.

Then, he stood.

There was a deep crack running through the mirror from an altercation three months before, distorting his reflection. He appraised his work in the flickering blue light. The hazmat suit felt snug, but he had gathered a little

too much material from the cuff at his right glove. Something he would work on. Even if it was a little snug, it would do the job: the binding on the wrists and ankles were secure. He had read about DNA transference in the little blue book that had been sent for him to study, and he was confident the suit would do its job, when the time came. The book, filled with past reflections of The Caretaker's work, had a manifesto with it. He had read it over and over, but, now he had become him, he needed to read it one more time.

Picking up the book from the top of his TV, he opened it and read.

We did not begin with blood. We began with waiting. We waited for our partners to change, for the police to intervene. We waited for someone to rescue us. We waited, and as we waited, bruises became fractures, threats became attempts, attempts became funerals.

We waited while the laws failed to act. We waited, but waiting is a decision.

The Caretaker exists because protection was conditional. Because safety was rationed. Because some lives were deemed salvageable only after damage was proven severe enough to be believed.

What we are doing is not about rage. Rage burns fast and leaves nothing behind. This is about stewardship. Caretaking is what you do when something fragile has been left unattended for too long.

Replacing the book, feeling more powerful for the affirmation. He put on his balaclava then, looking at the mirror once more, he smiled. He knew this image, this man. Everyone did.

The face looking back was one the country spoke of and feared. It was the face of a man people had a thousand questions about. The face of a man that many men lost sleep over. It was a face of a man who would ensure the change that was coming, would come very soon. It had been almost four months since anyone had seen or heard anything from him. And the speculation as to why he vanished and who he really was, was still widely

discussed. As was the work he did in bringing those who abused to justice for what they did.

People wondered, would The Caretaker ever return?

Soon, they would have the answer.

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Chapter Two

JESS

I promised myself, a long time ago, that I wouldn't grow up to be a woman who ever let a man lay a hand on me.

I had failed.

But then, because of that failure, because of my power being stripped, something else came in its place. Something stronger. Something that understood what pain and fear really felt like.

I had failed, but he failed more.

As I looked at the entrance to A&E, the waning summer sun throwing long shadows across the entrance, I couldn't help but think of when I last stood there, over six months before, on New Year's Eve. A bloodied towel held to my face as I told the lie of how I tripped on the stairs, to cover the fact that Lewis had beaten me. That was the night everything changed. My secrets about how I lived were going to come out. I just didn't know it at the time. I didn't think about that version of me often. I had chosen to live looking forward, not back, but being where it all began, I couldn't stop myself reflecting. I didn't recognise her anymore, that version of me who was too afraid to speak the truth. She vanished when I met the support group, Kelly, Madison, Hannah. Those women found me, the real me, and helped me leave the woman I once was behind.

I thought about that night, the lies I told, and the truth that was exposed. In the aftermath of that night, Lewis stalked me, and then The Caretaker emerged, and did what he did.

I felt my anxiety begin to rise.

I wondered if returning to where my journey began was a mistake. But I had agreed to help someone, and I couldn't turn my back on her now. I wanted to be the catalyst for change for someone else. I owed it to myself, and to my friends. I owed it to her, too, a woman called Esme who I had never met. She found me through Instagram, one of hundreds of messages I had received since the serial killer, The Caretaker, killed those men, our men; and I promised, if she was ready to talk, I would hold her hand.

Tonight, she was ready, and from what I knew, she was ready in the same way I had been ready. There was no choice, no way to hide it anymore.

'Jess.'

I turned and felt myself instantly relax as Kelly came towards me. Before I could say hi, she pulled me into a long embrace.

'Hey,' I said, when she let me go.

'Hey,' she replied. 'You okay?'

'Yeah, yeah, fine.'

'Good,' she said, smiling a smile that didn't quite reach her eyes anymore. The events of February and March, the killings that happened, including her husband's, had taken their toll on us all in the support group. Not only were we all grieving, despite how awfully we were treated by our men, but we were also hounded for a long time after The Caretaker disappeared. Hannah, Madison, Kelly and me. We all struggled in our own ways.

'Is she coming?' Kelly asked, and I nodded.

'She is getting a taxi. I offered to pick her up, but she didn't want me to.'

‘Why?’

‘Shame, I guess. She didn’t tell me how she was hurt, only that she was, and she needed to go to hospital. She’s ready to talk.’

‘Okay,’ Kelly said, leaning into a wall.

We fell into a comfortable silence, our experiences bonding us in such a way that words weren’t needed for comfort to be offered. Our connection was profound. I knew I would die for Kelly, and I knew she would for me. I also knew we wouldn’t ever need to. Because we would always have each other’s backs, through thick and thin. She was more than a friend now, Kelly was family.

‘I take it Hannah and Madison aren’t coming?’ she asked.

‘No. They know tonight is happening, but I didn’t want Esme to be overwhelmed. Madison has her boy anyway, and Hannah is knackered from a tough week at work.’

‘So, just you and me.’

‘Just you and me,’ I echoed.

As we waited, I watched the toing and froing of people around me. Even though the weather was different – the bitter cold of December now replaced with the cloying air of an early summer heatwave – the people were the same. Lots of older people, alone in their struggles, forgotten about by the world. Drunks and drug addicts who smoked with IV poles beside them, children with bleary-eyed parents who were trying to keep their fear suppressed so as not to scare their kids. It was hard to feel okay with it all, the suffering people experienced. But then, a little over six months ago, I was suffering too. My bottom lip and chin bore the scar of that night. It would stay there forever, a constant reminder of how I used to live, every time I looked in the mirror. I was lucky. Thanks to the support group, Kelly, Madison, Hannah and The Caretaker.

I was about to comment to Kelly how so much had changed since that night, when a taxi pulled up outside the entrance. A woman began climbing

out of the back, cradling her arm. Even from afar, it was obvious her wrist was broken.

‘Is that her?’ Kelly asked.

‘Maybe,’ I said.

I hadn’t ever met Esme, not face to face, and the only way I could recognise her was from her Instagram profile picture. But as she stepped onto the kerb and under a street light, her features illuminated in the harsh white light and I was sure.

‘Yeah, that’s her.’

‘She looks in pain,’ Kelly said.

I took a step towards Esme and, when she looked up and caught my eye, she burst into tears.

I didn’t offer words of comfort, I didn’t try to placate her tears, I just walked closer, took her in my arms like she wasn’t a stranger, but a sister, and I held her. Kelly joined us and we stayed there, surrounding her, protecting her until she was ready to break free. When I took a step back, I held her eye. ‘We need to get you in, get your arm looked at.’

‘What do I tell them?’ Her voice was strangled, fear and grief and loss and failure squeezing her throat. I knew this, because I was once this woman.

‘The truth,’ Kelly said.

‘I, I don’t know if I can.’

‘You can,’ I said. Matter of fact.

‘What if he—’

‘He won’t,’ Kelly interrupted. ‘Trust us, Esme. He just won’t. Even since we spoke out, things have changed.’

‘And we won’t let anyone hurt you. Okay?’

‘Okay.’

‘Where is he now?’

‘Out, I don’t know where, he never tells me.’

‘Will you have somewhere to go?’ I asked.

She nodded. ‘My mum’s.’

‘That’s good. Do you want us to call her now? Get her to come meet us?’

‘No. No. I don’t want anyone here. Just you two.’

‘That’s fine. We’ll not leave you,’ Kelly said.

Esme looked at me. I could see there was a question forming in her eyes, likely one about The Caretaker. We were now what the media called ‘the saved’ as our abusive exes had been killed earlier in the year. But she didn’t ask. I was grateful. I didn’t want to lie to her. For a woman living through abuse, lying was part of the day-to-day. I had lied about the injuries, the appalling behaviour from my ex, I had lied about being okay. Happy. Safe. Every day was a lie. And even though Kelly, Madison, Hannah and I had a secret we could never tell, I didn’t want to lie ever again.

‘Esme. Kelly and I, we will stay with you, but when you talk, they will want to talk to you alone.’

‘Do I have to?’

‘Yes. But I promise, as soon as you start, it will all come out. It starts with you saying just one word.’

‘What word?’

‘Help.’

‘I can’t do this,’ she said, wanting to walk away.

But I took the hand of her uninjured arm, and squeezed it. ‘You can. We won’t leave, we’ll wait for you, and we will make sure you get to your mum’s after you’ve been discharged.’

‘Please tell me this will help, that I’ll get my life back.’

‘It will change everything,’ Kelly said. ‘We get how scared you are, we’ve been where you’re standing now.’

‘And you’ve done the hardest bit,’ I continued. ‘You reached out to me, told me how you have lived. You’ve spoken the truth of your relationship. Trust me, it gets easier from here. But you have to be brave, really fucking brave.’

‘I don’t know if I can.’

‘We do,’ I said.

‘Okay, Okay,’ Esme said, mostly to herself. I wanted to lead her in, get her arm looked at and help her tell the truth of how she was hurt. But she had to take that step. Just like I did on New Year’s Eve. So we waited.

‘I’m ready,’ she said.

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Chapter Three

As soon as we stepped through the automatic double doors to Accident and Emergency, I felt a cold shiver run up my spine. It wasn't coming from the air conditioning unit blowing cool air down, rather it was almost like I was back in December again, oppressed by the ever-watchful gaze of Lewis, knowing one mistake, one wrong word or stumble, I would be punished. I needed to push it down, that feeling, I couldn't have Esme pick up on it. But I wasn't sure she would. She was locked in, stuck in her own head, her voice on autopilot as she checked in with the receptionist.

Once she had given her details and was told to wait, Kelly and I escorted her to a row of blue plastic chairs, purposefully placing her in the middle. A safe space in the sea of pain and suffering. Because Esme would suffer no more.

As the hours limped on, the sounds of coughing, crying and muffled conversations became relentless. Kelly and I made small talk with Esme. We told her about the group, how we met, how we became friends and how we were now helping others.

'I feel bad you are waiting here with me.'

'Don't be. We are happy to be here. You shouldn't have to face this alone,' I replied, giving her hand a reassuring squeeze.

'Who was here for you?' she asked, and I shook my head.

She looked at Kelly, who smiled. ‘This is why we want to stay,’ was all she said.

‘I wish I was as strong as you two.’

‘Strength isn’t a competition,’ I replied. ‘There are no parameters for who is stronger than who. We all face our own battles, we all make our own way. Fear is fear. It’s just as powerful for everyone.’

‘But you did this alone.’

‘And you don’t have to.’

‘And then, with The Caretaker stuff...’ She trailed off.

‘Yeah. Well, we cannot change what he did. Even if we wanted to,’ Kelly said.

‘Esme Spenser?’ a voice called, and we looked up to see a young doctor looking for her. Esme stood and walked towards him. She looked back.

‘We’ll be here,’ I said.

She nodded, and disappeared into the belly of the hospital. With Esme gone, all we could do was wait.

Stifling a yawn, Kelly patted my leg. ‘I’ll get us a coffee.’

‘Thanks.’

Kelly stood and walked to the vending machine. A few moments later she turned. ‘Broken. I’ll go on the hunt.’

She headed towards the atrium to hopefully find a working coffee machine. I sat back in my chair and fought the urge to have a long, deep stretch. It was only just after 10.30pm, but it felt a lot later. Life had changed – I was now a different woman – but it seemed sleep was even more of an enigma than before. Tonight would be no different, even if I hadn’t been at the hospital trying to help a stranger. I had to hope I would get some sleep at least after we made sure Esme was okay. I had the support group, our usual Friday morning session, and then I was working with Will and Eva. Without sleep I couldn’t do my job properly.

Opposite me in the waiting room, an older lady sat in a wheelchair, staring into nothing. She wore the expression of someone who was tired, not just because of the time, but because of life. I wondered what her story was, what woes she carried, what moments of joy she had felt in her long time on this earth. I wondered if she had a family somewhere, if she had love in her life, children, stories, adventures. She might well be the most interesting person in the world, and yet, almost invisible now. I wanted to say something, but I didn't know what. So instead, when Kelly arrived back with the coffees, I took mine over.

'Excuse me,' I said, lifting her from her thoughts.

'Yes?'

'I wondered if you would like a coffee?'

'Oh, you read my mind. I've been here for hours, haven't had a drink.'

'Oh, you poor thing.'

I handed her the cup, and she took it in two hands. Taking a sip, she sighed in appreciation, and giving her arm a gentle squeeze, I returned to my seat.

'Still a goodun, aren't you?' Kelly said.

'Well, one day, if I'm lucky, I'll be old. I'll want someone to give a shit about me.'

'You're stuck with me. So yeah, you'll have someone give a shit.'

I smiled. 'Same goes. Just you and me and the girls.'

I looked across at the woman once more. She was still alone, nursing her coffee, but that lostness in her eyes was gone. A glimmer of something alive was in its place.

'I mean, that's nice, but I do want the occasional man too,' Kelly said.

I laughed out loud, attracting attention. That sort of thing used to embarrass me, but not anymore.

'Don't get me wrong, I'm still healing. Duncan was, is, a lot to process. And I love you, and Hannah and our Mads, but I have no intention of

becoming a born-again virgin, thank you very much.'

I laughed again, and made eye contact with the older lady opposite. She looked back, beaming a smile, nodding at what Kelly had said.

'You'll want more grass stains when you get to my age. Trust me,' she said.

It was Kelly's turn to laugh, loud and dirty and unapologetic, as did I. The older lady was mid-naughty giggle when her name was called by a tired-looking nurse.

'Frances Mullis?'

'Here,' she said, and, just like that, she was whisked away from us.

'Think she'll be okay?' I asked after I had calmed.

'Probably not,' Kelly said honestly.

I nodded, and, sitting back, I thought about what Kelly had said. She was clearly moving on with her life now, able to see beyond her ex and the trauma he had caused, and I hoped she would get there. Find someone new. I didn't think I would ever be able to do the same. Lewis had not just physically scarred me; the wounds were deep, so deep I wasn't sure they would ever heal. I was okay with being alone. I was making peace with it day by day.

The doors opening snapped me from my thoughts, and I saw two police officers walk in. I didn't recognise either.

'Kel, look,' I said, and she turned her attention to the door. 'Think they are here for Esme?'

'Maybe.'

As the two officers spoke to reception, and then left in the direction of where Esme was, a third person walked in, a man I knew very well.

DS Jones, on paper, was a decent copper, long-serving, good at his job, unless you were a victim of domestic violence. Appearances can be deceiving. Jones had a run-in, on a beach near Cromer, with The Caretaker. He was warned to be better. Or The Caretaker would have killed him, too,

like the others who abused their partners. If he wasn't a police officer, I had no doubt he would already be dead.

No sooner had Jones walked into the waiting room than he saw us and, if looks could kill, I was pretty sure we'd both drop in a heartbeat.

'What are you two doing here?' he said.

'Whatever we want,' Kelly snapped back.

As he walked past, I heard him call Kelly a bitch before he disappeared behind a door. I was sure they were there to talk to Esme, which told me she had done it, she had taken that massive and terrifying step towards being free from her abuser. Since the beginning of the year, when The Caretaker did what he did, a woman who was reporting abuse was treated differently. Better. I wanted to be able to say it was because of positive change, but really the police were still trying to find the serial killer who targeted abusive men, and every woman who came forward was a potential lead.

But still, she was being listened to. They were taking her seriously.

'Think he's changed?' Kelly asked when Jones was gone.

'He's still a prick.'

'I mean, do you think he's a better partner?'

'I don't know.'

'Me neither. I do know one thing for sure, though.'

'What's that?'

'Your pal DS Sophie Salam is going to know we are here tonight.'

'Yeah, she will.'

Chapter Four

SOPHIE SALAM

P

ropped up in her bed, and staring at her laptop screen, Sophie knew she should close it for the night. Start again in the morning. Sometimes a case was a quick result. Sometimes it took longer. But, even though this one was less than six months old, short compared to some, The Caretaker killings would be the longest case of her career. It seemed that, when she felt she was on the right path, going in the right direction, something derailed it. Something threw her off the scent and took her further away from the truth. There was no doubt in her mind that Jess, Madison, Kelly and Hannah were involved in the deaths of their partners and husbands. No doubt that they were complicit in the crimes, but, with alibis for each – alibis Sophie felt were too convenient – and not a shred of DNA at any of the crime scenes, pinning them down was impossible. The Caretaker was gone, four months and counting, and she assumed he would never come back. He'd served his purpose, he'd ended the lives of four bad men, shook fear into countless others, created conversation and change. New legislation was being considered, laws to give more power to the public, more women were coming forward, and more help was there for them when they did. And because he had vanished, he had become almost a thing of myth. People still feared The Caretaker, even though he was gone, even though Sophie felt he was never real in the first place. And his crimes would remain

unpunished. She could spend years looking at the information they had, and still she would be no closer. It was why, whenever Jess Pendle and her friends were together, she wanted to know. The Caretaker was gone, but they might still slip and confirm her suspicions about who he really was.

Yawning, Sophie closed her laptop, and gently placed it beside her in the bed so she didn't wake Lottie who was sound asleep, lying across her legs.

With her attention shifted out of detective mode, and back to mother mode, she watched her little girl. It seemed the struggles she faced, the overwhelm that used to often sweep over her, had really eased. She wished she could take credit, or even that her mother could, but neither of them had unlocked the thing that Lottie could use to help her regulate her feelings. Her suspect, her friend, Jess Pendle was the one who had helped, when no one, not even doctors, could.

Sophie really hoped Jess wasn't involved in what The Caretaker did, but hoping wasn't enough. The law stated people were innocent until proven guilty; however, for her friend, it was the other way around. Jess needed to prove she wasn't involved, or else Sophie would forever think she was. Still, involved or not, Jess Pendle had good in her, she cared about people, wanted to help. Sophie would forever be indebted to her for how she helped her little girl.

Closing her eyes, Sophie pushed away all thoughts of work, and Jess. She focused on the sound of Lottie's breathing, and the feel of her soft hair as she stroked it. As she settled, she felt herself begin to drift.

Then her phone vibrated, and opening her eyes, her vision blurring through tiredness, she reached for it. DS Jones had messaged.

At the hospital dealing with a disclosure of DV. As per your request that the boss agreed, wanted to inform you that both Jess and Kelly are in the waiting area.

Sophie exhaled loudly. Even in his messages, she could feel the contempt he always had for her. She wanted to bite back, but stopped herself.

Thanks.

Putting down her phone, Sophie once again stroked her daughter's hair. Jess and Kelly were at the hospital at the same time that a woman had come forward. She knew they were linked. The woman had reached out to them, perhaps, asked them for help.

It made her worry. Jess and Kelly helping women was a good thing. But, if they were helping, would The Caretaker come out of hiding and help too?

As she closed her eyes once more, she knew that she wanted to speak to Jess. Tomorrow was Friday, support group day, and before the meeting Jess always stopped at the same coffee shop where they first met. Maybe Sophie would grab a coffee, too, and accidentally bump into Jess Pendle.

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Chapter Five

JESS

I think everyone has a thing that lives inside them, resting along the diaphragm, something that's like a hand, waiting for anxiety to form, so it can squeeze or pluck, stretch. Stir up those anxious feelings. Make them spill. I think for most, it strums like a harpist when love or anticipation is there. Its melody scary and exciting, and welcomed. Mine was, no doubt, that way once too. Until Lewis. Now it was arthritic and scarred through the years of manual labour, from twisting up my insides every time he was angry or upset or drunk. And its melody was flat, angry.

The morning of a support group meet, still, to this day, plucked my internal harp. I didn't know why: these woman were my friends. I trusted them all more than anyone else in the whole world, and for some of us, we were bonded in a way that was unspeakable and unbreakable. But still, the little gnarled hand that wanted to squeeze my lungs was there.

The first time I visited the group, it nearly squeezed me to death; maybe I still hadn't quite shaken free from that moment. But likely, it had something to do with The Caretaker.

Still, I couldn't let it stop me. I had to keep moving forward. Because women like Esme needed me to. The Caretaker started something, and as I was involved, with Lewis being a victim, I was now someone people came to, depended on. One of 'the saved', giver of hope. It gave me purpose.

Between that, and the kids I worked with, Will and Eva, I had a reason to fight my demons. So, locking my flat, I headed out into the morning heat, and got into my car. Having a car was a luxury, one I wasn't used to, and as much as I loved it, there was guilt too. Lewis had life insurance. I didn't know until after he was gone, and some of the payout after his death came through his mum to me. I felt like I didn't deserve it, until Kelly told me that, of all the people in the world, I did. He'd put me through hell, made my life harder when he should have made it brighter. So, I put some money aside, just in case, and I got my little run-around. No more buses for Jess Pendle.

Firing up the car, I headed towards town, driving past the bus stop I used to stand at, whatever the weather. The drive was only ten minutes, but by the time I got to the coffee shop, the anxiety had dipped. The sun was shining, I was about to see my best friends, and in the night, I'd helped a stranger come to terms with the abuse she had suffered. Esme was, rightfully, really upset when she emerged back into the waiting room with her arm in plaster. She didn't speak when Kelly and I took her to her mother's, and we didn't try to make conversation. We both knew what she was processing. She was no longer living a lie, no longer living with secrets. She told her mum as soon as we dropped her off, and Kelly and I left knowing she would begin the journey to healing, just like we had. I hoped she would be at the group, but doubted she was ready. I made sure she had Becky's number, though, so that when she was, a professional could help.

Parking outside the coffee shop. I got out of my car and walked in. I hoped to see James, the chatty, chirpy barista who I had come to like in the last few months. But he wasn't in so, instead of chatting, I ordered my black coffee and grabbed a seat by the window to watch the world go by. I needed this moment of calm and quiet. The support group was vital, a part of my identity, but it was a lot. Soon I would hear stories that mirrored my own. It

would rekindle a flame of the pain I had felt, and I would have to process my feelings, as well as help someone else process theirs too. After, I would leave unable to shake off the conversations for a little while. Post-group, I didn't like being alone. I needed Kelly, or Madison, or Hannah, knowing they needed me too. Or, like today, I was going to work, which would keep my mind active and distracted. So, before a session, alone time was important.

Once I couldn't sit alone in a café through fear. Now, it was as normal as anything else.

Sipping my coffee, watching people in the same way I had the night before, I caught eyes with someone coming into the coffee shop I wasn't expecting to see. Kelly was right: Sophie had been told about us being at the hospital. It wasn't a coincidence she was here, despite how she might play it.

Seeing me watching her, she nodded my way and I returned it. Then, as she entered, I continued to look out of the window, minding my own business. I wondered how she would proceed. Was she just making me aware she knew my movements, or would she want to speak? She was treading a fine line between being a friend, an investigating detective, and harassment. I didn't try engaging with her, despite wanting to. She and I hadn't spoken in a few months, not since The Caretaker did what he did, and I missed her, despite everything we had been through. I didn't wait for her to approach. I just looked out of the window, focused on my breathing, and remained calm. I needed to appear like I didn't care about her being there. I didn't want her to misread my reasons why. This was her rodeo: if she wanted to talk to me, she would.

A few minutes later, I got my answer.

'Hi,' Sophie said, coffee in hand. She was staying for a chat.

'Am I Jess or Miss Pendle today?'

'Jess, I think.'

‘Then, hi, Sophie. You okay?’

‘May I sit?’

‘Sure.’

Sophie sat opposite me, and for a moment we looked at each other. I knew she knew I had information regarding the events from a few months back. She knew I knew there was more to her than she was letting on. We didn’t need to say it. It hung silently in the air between us, a thick cloud of unspoken words. For all intents and purposes, she was the hero, searching for a villain, and I was, well, maybe I was the other side of that coin.

‘It’s been a while,’ she said, and I nodded.

‘It has. A few months now.’

‘How are you?’ she asked.

‘I’m okay. How are you?’

‘I’m okay.’

‘Sophie, I know you want to say something, so just say it.’ As much as I liked her, respected her, I knew this wasn’t a social visit. In another life, she and I would no doubt be best friends, but not this one.

Sophie took a sip of the coffee, and I waited for her questions around what I was doing at the hospital last night, or maybe she would ask directly where The Caretaker was, but what she said surprised me.

‘Lottie misses you.’

I was taken aback. I had only interacted with Sophie’s daughter a few times. But she was easy to warm to, and I missed her as well.

‘Does she?’

‘Yeah. She’s mentioned you a few times lately.’

‘Why?’

‘Bird song, it always comes back to you.’

I smiled. ‘How is she?’

Sophie nodded, a slight smile creeping onto her face to match my own, and for a moment, with Lottie in the middle of our thoughts, I forgot she

was the detective who had once arrested me. ‘She’s good, really good. She still listens to bird song every night as she goes to sleep. Honestly, it’s been a game-changer.’

‘I’m sure you would have found it eventually.’

‘Maybe,’ she agreed. ‘But I found it quicker because of you.’

‘I’m glad I could help,’ I said, meaning it. Lottie was a lovely kid. ‘I miss her too.’

‘Really?’

‘Yeah, she has a nature that’s just, how do I word it? It’s like she sees the world a little brighter than the rest of us.’

‘Yeah, yeah, she does.’

‘Sophie, why are you here?’

Her smile faded. ‘I know you were at the hospital last night. Is everything all right?’

‘Are you asking out of concern, or in a professional capacity?’

‘A bit of both.’

I nodded. At least she was being honest. ‘I had a woman come to me via Instagram. She needed help. Kelly and I gave her some support.’

‘Good.’

As we simultaneously sipped our coffee, keeping eye contact with each other, I could see she wanted to ask me more. She wouldn’t, she had professional boundaries to preserve. I, however, didn’t have the same constraints.

‘How’s work?’ I asked.

‘Jess.’

‘I’m just curious, since you spoke to us all under caution, and nothing came of it. I’m assuming we aren’t suspects anymore, so.’

‘Jess, it doesn’t work like that. And you know full well I can’t talk about this with you.’

‘I know,’ I said. ‘Sophie, you look tired.’

‘I am tired.’

‘Have you had a break at all?’

‘Honestly, I want nothing more. Just don’t have the time. With The Careta—, with a big case ongoing. I’m so wrapped up in it all.’

‘You’ve gotta look after yourself.’

‘Same goes for you.’

‘I’m doing okay,’ I said.

Sophie smiled, and then she stood up. ‘I’ll leave you to it.’

In that moment, I didn’t want her to go, and I didn’t know why. ‘You still have my number. If you need anything, for Lottie, I’d be happy to chat.’

‘Thank you,’ she said. ‘But I can’t do that.’

‘As long as I’m just Jess, and you’re just Sophie, you can. If in your head I’m Miss Pendle, you can’t.’

‘Okay.’

‘Sophie. I know it’s been really rough for you lately.’

‘As it has for you.’

‘But I would listen, if you ever wanted to offload. Woman to woman.’

‘Friend to friend?’ she asked.

‘Yeah.’

‘See you soon, Miss Pendle,’ she said, smiling.

‘See you soon, Detective Salam.’

As Sophie left, I turned my attention to outside the window and the clouds that were lazily floating by. Sophie crossed in front of my eyeline, and I watched her get into her car. And then, for a moment, she looked back at me. I didn’t move, didn’t deviate my eye. I held hers until she drove off. Then, taking a deep breath, I finished my morning coffee in peace, before heading towards the support group.

Chapter Six

THE CARETAKER

Months of watching, of planning, of preparing was going to culminate in a little over fifteen hours' time. The Caretaker was nervous. For months, he had vanished, became a ghost much like the four men he had killed. The world spoke of him still, but the conversations had become quieter, isolated. And even though some change had happened and victims of abuse were being heard, it was still not enough. Bad partners and spouses, mostly men, were getting away with hurting, sometimes killing those they were meant to love. But abuse wasn't just physical. The Caretaker knew sometimes it was about money, sometimes it was about controlling someone's mind, their thoughts, their self-belief. And that was just as punishable as raising a fist.

They spoke of new legislation. He needed to ensure it came to fruition. Words needed to become actions. The conversations may have gone quieter. But not for long. Soon they would be talking about The Caretaker all over again, in a bigger way than before, for two reasons. Firstly, The Caretaker was almost a myth, a legend, and him rising like a phoenix from the flames would capture the world's attention. And secondly, The Caretaker wasn't isolated to one location, not anymore. He had the length and breadth of the UK as his hunting ground. His first of this new wave: a forty-seven-year-old building contractor who liked Spanish food, rugby over football, and cheating.

Robert Worthing had never raised a fist to his wife, Melanie. He'd never struck her or grabbed her in any way. In the twelve years of their marriage, he hadn't ever bruised her body. Her mind, however, he had beaten black and blue with his constant belittling, mocking and embarrassing in front of his friends. Melanie was a sweet woman, she meant well, the glass was always half-full. And instead of protecting her innocent nature, he weaponised it. Melanie was once a woman who loved to be out, having adventures, discovering new things. She was once social, confident. Now, The Caretaker knew, she hadn't left the house in two months. Two months of being a prisoner, because of his venomous tongue.

And the law, although changing for those who had been abused physically, wasn't doing enough for women like her.

Part eight of the manifesto in the blue book stated women are expected to endure.

The Caretaker refused endurance as a moral requirement.

Even though he knew what he was going to do was right, that Robert should be held to account for his crimes in a system which offered no justice for his particular offences, The Caretaker's nerves were frayed. So to pacify them, he re-rehearsed his preparations, donning and removing the protective clothes he would wear to ensure he wouldn't be discovered. The putting on, taping and removing of his overalls, wellies, gloves and mask became his mantra, a safe space. He checked the cuffs, the taper on the leg, ensured all was tight, and then stripped it all off, before carefully folding and placing it all in his rucksack along with the things he would need for the task he was to complete.

It was Friday. Robert didn't go home on a Friday or Saturday anymore. He claimed he was at work, always pulling the weekend shift to earn more money to make up for her lower income, but really, Robert earned very well, and rented a small studio flat on the outside of Cambridge. There he

would meet a woman ten years younger than him. Lorna, she was called. She had no idea of his other life with a wife and child.

Lorna always arrived at around 1am on a Saturday morning, after she finished work in a bar in town. They would sleep together and then go into Cambridge around 10am, have breakfast, walk along the river. They looked like any other couple. She would then go to work, doing a day shift before coming back to him later in the evening. Robert would usually go to the gym in the centre of town after work, and then, at around 9pm, return to his flat, and take a long shower. He would leave the door unlocked, and she would enter. The Caretaker knew this, because he had watched. He had walked the corridor that led to the flat, he had opened and closed the door without Robert ever knowing he was there. In his little book, the new one after the original was burnt to a cinder on a beach a thousand miles away, along with the manifesto, there as a note, an observation about people being creatures of habit. Robert was no different, even if he was more monster than creature. The new book, although not original, was just as detailed, just as specific and just as educational as it would have been if the first had not been destroyed.

People were creatures of habit. But tonight would be different. The habit would be broken, because when Lorna did come back to his after a long shift, she wouldn't be able to get within one hundred feet of Robert's flat.

The Caretaker was going to rise, like a phoenix.

But, for a phoenix to be reborn, there had to be flames.

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Chapter Seven

JESS

As I turned the car at the corner, I had to come to a sudden stop as Madison walked into the road ahead of me. She was lost in her own world, and when she looked up and saw me waiting to enter the narrow lane, that ran alongside the church, to the obscured and dated support centre, she jumped. I waved, she waved back and then scooted to one side so I could head up the lane.

I got out of the car, the mid-summer sun hot on my skin, and walked towards her, giving her a big hug when we came close enough. She felt slimmer in my arms, not quite as strong as she once was. The sinewy muscles she had when we first met had faded. She felt weaker. Conversely, I had gone the other way, and was now stronger and fitter than I'd ever been in my life.

We all cope in our own ways.

'Hey, how are you?' I said when we let go of our embrace.

'Good, I'm good,' she said, painting on a smile, similar to the smile Kelly painted: below the eyes, it was real, above, it wasn't.

Usually, Madison would ask how I was, ask about my week, but lately, she didn't. It wasn't that she was disinterested, she was still the same woman as before. It was more like she was tired. I guessed she was. Her ex, Jake's, death was a lot to take on, and she was the only one of us with a

child to try shield from it all. She was the only one who had to remain connected to her ex's family, because of her little boy. We'd all been through a lot, living with abusive partners and in the wake of them dying, but maybe none more so than Madison.

'Feel like we've not hung out in ages,' I said, testing the waters.

'I know. I'm so sorry, it's just been so busy lately.'

'No, darling, don't say sorry. Life is life. I just miss spending time with you.'

'Me too.'

Taking Madison by the hand, our friendship being one where this was totally normal, we walked towards the day centre. My first visit had been completely different to this one. I was so nervous, I almost didn't enter, until the leader, Becky, found me. Now, I walked in confidently. This was our space, our safe place, our home.

As we headed in and down the corridor, I could hear the quiet chatter of voices inside, and opened the door to the main room. The walls were filled with bright and cheerful children's paintings as this centre doubled as a daycare the first half of the week. The women of the support group looked up, and smiled our way.

In the wake of The Caretaker, and everything he had done, we had lost a few members of the group. The constant harassment by the press after The Caretaker was linked to this group was too much for a few. Steph had vanished, Claire had, too, and Rachel didn't come often anymore. Their exes, although not targeted by The Caretaker, were still terrified they were next, and for them, the group wasn't a safe space. It was sad. But, then, things in life are. As much as we wish that wasn't true. There was a rumour that the reason Steph didn't come back was because she went back to her ex. I hope if she did, he had really changed. But then, did people actually change? Or did they just become experts at hiding who they truly were?

In the room, the usual suspects were there, Kelly, Hannah, Baheela, Vija and, to my surprise, a new face, one I didn't expect.

'Esme?' I said, rushing over to give her a hug. 'I didn't think you'd be here today.'

'I almost didn't come,' she said quietly. 'I called Becky. She said I would be okay.'

'That's totally normal, to think you can't do it, we all had the same thoughts. Becky is great. She will look after you,' Hannah said.

'I'm a bit nervous,' Esme said, laughing in a way that was almost a cry. The type of laugh you do when you're on your arse, and wondering if you'll ever get up.

'Again, that's totally normal.'

'Is it?' she asked.

'My God, yeah,' I said. 'If it wasn't for Becky being at the door on my first session, I would have run away. Speaking of Becky, where is she?'

'She is picking up someone from the train station, she is only a minute away now,' Kelly said.

'Ah. Good. How did you get in?' I asked.

'I have the code for the door,' Kelly said.

'Who is she bringing?'

'I don't know.'

'Maybe it's Geoff?' Hannah said, with a hint of excitement in her voice. I hoped it was. At the beginning of the year, he was the main suspect for The Caretaker killings, and was hounded until he ran to Scotland to be with his daughters. He was a good man, he deserved better than how he was treated.

'I'd love it to be Geoff.' I said.

As I introduced Esme to the group, telling her their names, Vija, Hannah, Madison, Kelly, who she already knew, and Baheela, I watched her acknowledge each woman as if she knew them. She kind of did: everyone

knew us in the wake of The Caretaker. But still she said hello politely, and as we began to catch up on our weeks, Esme quietly listening, just like I did on my first session, I heard the centre main door open, and then close. And looking towards the entrance to the room, I waited for Becky and the other person who was joining us. As she walked in, I saw it wasn't Geoff beside her. But someone else. A woman. We had met her once, at a retreat on the Norfolk coast. And we had spoken to her a lot since. Her being here was interesting to say the least. I shared a look of apprehension with Kelly: this visitor's arrival only meant one thing.

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Chapter Eight

‘Morning, ladies, I am so sorry I’m a little late. Traffic was terrible,’ Becky began, unable to mask her excitement. ‘Everyone, this is Kimberley Murphy. Founder of the charity Women Against Abuse.’

We all looked at each other, shifted in our seats at the fact Kimberley Murphy was in our little support session. Me, Kelly, Hannah and Madison for one reason, the other ladies for a different one. To them, Kimberley Murphy was something akin to a celebrity. Her charity, one that had existed for over fifteen years, had been quietly working to help women who were abused. But lately, she had become more and more discussed, with Kimberley herself even delivering a speech at parliament about the charity and how the law needed to evolve. For victims of domestic violence, she was the white knight, the light of hope that directly contrasted the dark of *The Caretaker*. For us four, however, Kimberley Murphy was someone else entirely.

‘Hello, ladies. I understand this is a surprise. I wanted to visit discreetly. I hope you all don’t mind.’

No one did, and thanking us graciously, Kimberley asked to use the bathroom. It had been a long journey. And no sooner had she left than the excitement of her being in the building spilt over.

‘What is she doing here?’ Vija asked. ‘Is this because of what happened?’

‘Yes and no,’ Becky said. ‘Yes, she knows of us because of the events earlier this year. But Kimberley also actively visits groups discreetly to talk about her journey.’

I looked at Kelly and could see she was thinking the same as me. Kimberley being here now wasn’t a coincidence. But we couldn’t let it show that we knew her, or that we were expecting her to get in touch at some point this summer. So, I turned my attention to Esme, who looked shellshocked that, on her first session, such an important person was in the room.

‘How’s the arm feeling?’ I asked.

‘Sore.’

‘I still cannot believe you’re here.’

‘My mum said that you and Kelly and the group would be the best thing for me.’

‘Well, I’m glad you came.’

‘Me too,’ said Kelly.

‘So am I,’ Becky said. ‘Thank you, Jess, for giving Esme my number.’

‘Not at all,’ I replied.

Kimberley walked back into the room, and took a seat. Our attention shifted her way. And Becky spoke. ‘Firstly, I would like to welcome Esme to the group. The first step is always the hardest. You should be proud of what you’ve achieved in doing that.’

‘Thank you,’ she said quietly.

Becky nodded, and in true style to not make our newest member feel uncomfortable, she moved on and introduced all of us, including Esme, by name to Kimberley, who didn’t bat an eyelid when she was introduced to the four of us who spilt our secrets with her months before. She behaved like we had never met, never spoken, never shared our burden and planned

future events. She was good at keeping things close, but then, that was the main requirement of someone who is or was suffering abuse. Keeping it all in, showing no one the truth.

‘Becky has shared with me that in your last session you touched on the subject of failing and how it’s difficult to shake that emotion,’ Kimberley started. ‘I would love to talk about this with you. That thing, that feeling that wants, no, insists to us that we are solely responsible for the events of our life. Ladies, I want to start by stating, categorically, that what happened to us all is not our fault or our doing. We are the victims, and blameless.’

‘We clearly all chose the wrong men, though,’ Baheela said, her voice raspy from the damage she sustained in the acid attack by her ex-partner years before. He was now blind, acid having melted his retinas, a gift from The Caretaker right back at the beginning.

‘Yes, we did, all of us did. Baheela, isn’t it?’ she asked.

‘Yes.’

‘Retrospectively, we can all sit here and talk of how it’s our fault we chose the wrong partners. But you are not a mind reader, none of us are. When you get into a committed relationship, there is an unspoken contract between both people, stating that they will care and protect. That’s it. That’s the job. They failed on their end of that contract. You didn’t.’

‘If only I knew before.’

‘But you didn’t. You couldn’t. You are not to blame.’

Baheela nodded, and Hannah reached out and took her hand, before she herself spoke. ‘I guess, for me, it’s hard to feel blameless when I was always told the things that happened to me were my fault.’

I nodded. Madison, who had barely looked up since the session began, nodded, too, and I think I saw Esme do the same.

‘I hear that,’ Kimberley said quietly. ‘Sorry.’

‘Hannah.’

‘Hannah, yes. We were told it was our fault things didn’t work. It’s typical gaslighting behaviour attached to narcissistic partners. They were never wrong, were they? In their eyes?’

‘Not once,’ Hannah said.

‘And to be honest, I still have my days where I doubt my own innocence in it all. If you’re told the same thing, over and over and over, it’s hard to remember that thing isn’t reality.’

‘It’s hard to move past that, isn’t it? Feeling guilty,’ Madison said quietly, and I wasn’t sure what guilt she was referring to.

‘Yes, but one day, we will all be open to trying to trust again. Trust ourselves. Trust another person, another man.’

‘Romantically?’ Vija asked.

‘No, not necessarily,’ Kimberley said.

‘I tried dating recently,’ Kelly said. ‘He was sweet, funny. He said nice things, about me, about the world.’

‘He sounds like a good man.’

‘Probably is. I called it off after the second date.’

‘Why?’ Esme asked, and I was proud of her for joining in. I remembered how hard it was for me.

‘Because I wanted to believe what he was saying. But I couldn’t.’

‘Yeah,’ Hannah said. ‘I get that.’

‘Me too,’ Vija said.

‘Maybe one day,’ Kelly said, her voice cracking a little. ‘Sorry, I need a second. I’ll make us all a tea,’ she said, getting up and leaving the room. I watched her go, and then Becky followed. It was unlike Kelly to wobble. But we all did, we all struggled. Even the bravest and strongest of us.

Kimberley moved the conversation on to how we cope with the automatic negative triggers we all had.

‘Automatic what?’ Hannah asked.

‘Automatic negative triggers. It’s that little voice that says negative things before we can process and understand and rationalise the information we know. It’s that voice that says, “if I was a better wife, he’d want to stay at home”. Before you can process that him going out all night isn’t your fault, you didn’t do anything to cause it, it was his choice, the blame is shouldered on you. You hear it so much you believe it. These thoughts speak the loudest, they speak first, despite being wrong.’

We all listened as she continued telling us her story, how she fought against these triggers and shifted her sense of failure into a small box in her mind she can lock. And we listened, captivated by her power, storytelling and charisma. When Kelly rejoined, with Becky and a cup of tea or coffee for us all, she was back to her usual self.

‘Sorry about that, ladies. Perimenopausal.’

‘Nothing to say sorry for,’ I said.

As we drank, we openly chatted about our thoughts, and Kimberley spent the session listening and offering advice. Vija cried. Esme did, too, although she didn’t say much. I thought of my now deceased boyfriend Lewis, and how a lot of what I was hearing from other women could have been Lewis in their lives too. There was a pattern to the things said, and all patterns, once understood, could be manipulated.

It was wonderful to have Kimberley with us, offering all of her thoughts as a victim, survivor and now advocate for change, but, as we listened, chatted, shared, I kept one eye on the wall clock, knowing that when the session was over, we members of the secret group within the support group would learn the real reason for Kimberley’s visit.

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Chapter Nine

With the session finished, Kelly and Madison washed up the cups, quietly chatting as they did. Even though I couldn't hear what they spoke of, I could see Kelly giving Madison a pep talk of some kind. Her tone was soft, Madison nodded gently. I wanted to join them, but knew if I did, I would interrupt something that was clearly important. Baheela and Vija left together, and Becky was with Esme, escorting her to the car park and her waiting mother. It left me, Hannah and Kimberley in the room. We tidied the chairs away, chatting lightly about her journey back to London where she was based, but the conversation was weighed down with everything unsaid. The pauses were loaded. We all knew what she came to speak of. It was just a matter of time. And opportunity. What she needed to say, Becky couldn't hear. Then, I remembered, Kelly had the code to the building.

When Becky came back into the room, I switched the attention to her. 'Was Esme okay?' I asked.

'A little teary, but she is coming back next week. I told her she was safe now, we would look after her.'

'How did she find the group?' Kimberley asked.

'She sent me a DM on Instagram,' I said.

'Brave of her.'

‘Very,’ I agreed. ‘Kimberley, I’m going towards the train station now, I can drop you off, if you like?’ I said, and she looked at me knowingly.

‘Thank you,’ she said.

‘You sure, Jess? I was going to nip that way.’ Becky said.

‘No, it’s fine, it’s the other direction to where you go. I’m passing on my way to my mum’s.’

‘Okay, great, thank you.’

We all drifted towards the exit together, said our goodbyes and Kimberley climbed into my car. I looked at Kelly, my gaze telling her we would be back very soon.

Pulling out of the centre, both Kimberley and I appearing relaxed and chatty as Becky was still watching, I turned left, as if I was heading to the station, then I did a loop and waited for Kelly to message.

Becky has gone.

I rang her. ‘We’ll drive around for five minutes, just in case, and then come back.’

‘I figured that was the plan.’

‘Great minds and all that.’

‘See you in five.’

When we arrived back at the centre, we found Kelly, Madison and Hannah waiting inside for us.

‘Hello again, ladies,’ Kimberley said. ‘Shall we sit?’

Doing as she asked, we grabbed chairs and sat in a small circle. Almost like a therapy session was about to begin. Only what we were going to discuss was far from words of comfort.

‘Kimberley. Needless to say, we are all a little surprised to see you,’ Kelly said when we were settled.

‘I wanted to give you the heads-up, but didn’t want to leave a trail. I’m going to visit several other groups today, so it’s just me acting in a

professional capacity.’

‘Are you here for the reason we think you’re here?’ Hannah asked.

‘Yes.’

‘Are they ready?’ I asked.

‘Yes, they are.’

‘Who is it? Who is The Caretaker?’

‘It’s better you don’t know.’

‘Okay? Where is the first, then?’ I asked.

‘Cambridge. Then Bolton. Slough after, to name a few. I wanted to come and tell you, before it all begins. The first video is ready.’

‘You have already recorded the first video?’

‘Yes, we have recorded them all. We wanted to be organised. And if anyone traced the source, which we don’t anticipate, it’s several hundred miles away from Cambridge. Each video speaks of the target, each video looks the same, sounds the same, and no one will be able to tell they were pre-recorded.’

‘Jesus,’ Hannah said.

‘When is The Caretaker doing it?’ I asked.

‘Tonight,’ she said.

‘Shit. It’s actually happening?’ Hannah said.

‘Yes, thanks to you, teaching us how to get away with it, recalling your journey for the book that is now a tool to help others continue your work.’

‘How long for?’

‘Hopefully not long. A new law has been put to the House of Commons. Through the charity, and your work, we’ve collected over a hundred thousand signatures. The Caretaker will stay until that law has been passed.’

I nodded, the others did, too, and I could see we wanted to know more, but also didn’t feel like we should ask. Kimberley had taken something created by Kelly, Hannah and Madison, something I later joined, and turned

it into a monster for change. It was intimidating, and, as she said, the less we knew at times, the better.

‘Download an app called Signal,’ Kimberley continued. ‘It’s an encrypted chat forum. Anonymous names, un-linkable to your phone numbers. Create a user name, then text me. Do not share your identity in the chat. We all remain anonymous.’

‘Is texting safe?’

‘We have specific numbers for calls. I have burner phones for each of you. Each will come with a number preloaded. Message that one. They will be delivered to you individually, by a woman within the network.’

‘Fucking hell,’ Kelly said. ‘Sorry, this is just so, well, it’s like an organisation.’

‘It is an organisation, a network,’ Kimberley said.

‘When will the phones come?’ I asked.

‘They are likely already in your letterbox.’

‘This is freaking me out a bit,’ Madison said, who until that point had been so quiet it was like she wasn’t there.

‘We have been busy. But don’t freak out, these are just measures to keep you safe,’ Kimberley continued. ‘When it’s done, I’ll make sure we all know on Signal.’

‘All? How many of us will be in this group?’ I asked.

‘Seventy-four,’ Kimberley replied.

‘Seventy-four?’ Kelly said. ‘Seventy-four women?’

‘Yes, some to be The Caretaker himself, most are to support, deliver things. Provide alibis where needed.’

‘Fuck,’ I said quietly, before looking at my friends.

‘Ladies, I’m only here because you are the reason for all this. But we need nothing from you now. You’ve done the hardest bit of all – you created a man who gave us all hope. And hope to countless others. The Caretaker is no longer your concern. We are taking him national.’

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Chapter Ten

SOPHIE SALAM

Her arms loaded with paperwork she had brought home due to the extra responsibility thrown at her by DI Hawkins – transcripts of interviews with friends, families and surviving partners of all the victims of the killer – Sophie was forced to close the front door with her foot. She wanted nothing more than to run a hot bath, then climb into bed and watch something trashy on TV. Some days on the job were quick, exciting; she would be interviewing a suspect, or assisting on an arrest. Some days she loved what she did.

It hadn't been one of those days.

As with all jobs it seemed, hers was becoming more and more about admin and paperwork and ticking boxes. The Caretaker had killed four men, and vanished like a ghost, and instead of finding new leads, her work consisted of revisiting old notes to try to find new things. Occasionally, someone came forward, claiming to have fresh information. But, so far, every one of them had been a dud lead. A lot of people out there were thinking they saw or heard things of interest, and were trying to do the right thing, but some were delusional and hell-bent on wasting police time. The Caretaker had a cult following. He was a hero in some eyes, and without even asking, strangers were willing to protect him. Each new piece of information had to be processed, investigated and ruled out. It made a long

shift feel longer as hour after hour of compliance work needed to be done despite Sophie knowing it was nonsense. It hadn't helped that it was DS Jones's admin day, too, which meant she was sharing an office with one of the few men she disliked in this world. She had always been on edge around him, but since the events on Cromer beach where Jones had met and been warned by The Caretaker, she trusted him even less. She kept away from Jones as much as was possible without looking unprofessional. But she'd been stuck in the same small room as him for an eight-hour shift, and she had felt his eyes on her the whole time. He thought she hadn't noticed, but she had. She wasn't sure if it was professional jealousy or if he was just a creep; either way he made her skin crawl.

As she put down her files on the sideboard by the front door, Daya stepped out of the kitchen. 'Hey. You okay?'

'Long day,' Sophie said, kicking off her shoes. 'You?'

'Want a glass of wine?' her mum asked, ignoring the reciprocated question.

'You read my mind.'

Following her mum, Sophie leant against the kitchen side as two glasses of white wine were poured, a large one for Sophie, a small one for Daya. They both drank a mouthful and then sighed in unison.

'Needed this,' Sophie said. 'Looks like you did too. Has Lottie been okay?'

'For the most part, amazing. She settled well, asleep in her bed.'

'That's good. And the other part?'

'She had a wobble. I've not seen one in a while now. Bird song didn't help.'

Sophie put her glass down. 'How bad?'

'Not horrific. But she did try banging her head again.'

'Oh God. Mum, why didn't you call me?'

‘I was going to, but then she calmed down quickly. I stopped her hurting herself.’

‘Thank you.’

‘I’m sure it’s just one of those things,’ her mum said, noticing Sophie looking a little panicked.

‘Yeah.’

‘Why did you need the wine?’ her mum asked.

‘Oh, just a long day. Mind if I go check on her?’

‘Of course not.’

Sophie kissed her mum on the cheek before ascending the stairs and going into Lottie’s room. Her night light was on, throwing stars onto her ceiling and, despite how warm it was, she was perfectly tucked in under her covers. Even if it was thirty-five degrees, Lottie needed to be covered. Touch was a lot for Lottie. Good, and bad, same with sound. Bird song worked; it was melodic, organised. She was prone to overwhelm quickly, but then, many with autism were.

Quietly leaning over her baby, who was looking more and more like her dad by the minute, Sophie knew she wouldn’t change a thing. Lottie was perfect, despite who her father was. She just had to hope, as Lottie got older, she looked more like her. It was hard seeing his features in her little girl.

Sophie kissed Lottie on the forehead, and seeing with her own eyes all was well, she returned to her mum in the kitchen, who was putting on her shoes.

‘All okay?’ her mum asked, finishing the rest of her small wine.

‘She’s fine. Thank you, Mum. You going home?’

‘If that’s okay. It’s been a long day.’

‘Yeah, yeah, of course.’

‘Drink your wine, get some sleep,’ Daya said, kissing Sophie on the cheek before heading for the door. As she reached it, she remembered

something and turned back. 'Oh, sorry. You had a call today. Someone wanting to talk to you.'

'Did they leave a message?'

'No, he said he'd catch up with you another time.'

Sophie felt the hairs on the back of her neck stand up. 'Who was it?'

'Didn't catch his name.'

'Mum, did he have an accent?'

'Yeah. Northern. I wondered if it was the same man as a few months back. Remember?'

'Did you tell him anything?'

'I never do. None of my business.'

'Mum, if he calls again, ever, you tell me straight away, okay?'

'Sophie? What's wrong?'

'It's just my job,' she lied. 'I don't want to take any risks is all. That man. I think he's a journalist or something. Trying to get a scoop on the case I'm on,' Sophie lied further. Hating that she had to. But it was for her mum's own good, and Lottie's, and also hers.

'Bastards. If you're worried, maybe change your number?'

'Good idea,' Sophie said, even though she had after the first time he called months before.

'Get some sleep, love,' Daya said before leaving.

When her mum was gone, Sophie locked and then checked the front door, as well as the back, and even though it hadn't dipped below twenty degrees yet, she pulled all of the windows closed, locking them in the frame so some air could still get into the house. Once happy the house was secure, she poured the wine down the sink. As much as it would be nice to unwind with it, sipping the cold wine in a hot bath, she knew she wouldn't.

He had found her number again. Somehow.

She wanted to ask her mum if Lottie could have been heard on the call, but didn't. She didn't want her to panic and probe her with questions,

questions Sophie couldn't answer, even though she wanted nothing more than to tell her who Lottie's father was, and the circumstances around him not being in her life. She wanted to tell the truth of the things she had done, the ethical boundaries she had crossed. And the things she'd had to do to protect her unborn child. But she couldn't tell her, or anyone, ever. She would lose it all.

Checking once more she was secure in her home, Sophie went upstairs, quickly got ready for bed, and then climbed in with her little girl. She knew she needed to try to sleep. But, with Karl, Lottie's dad, wanting to reach her, able to find her new number, even from inside prison, she knew sleep wouldn't come. An awful thought came to her: what if he was due to be released? What if he came to her? Would he take one look at Lottie, and know she was his? The thought made her want to throw up.

Lottie, sensing her mum was with her, woke and, sleepy-eyed, she smiled at her before repositioning herself on her mother's chest.

Sophie, shaken and alert, stroked her daughter's hair and whispered, 'Go back to sleep, baby girl. Mummy has you. Mummy will always have you.'

Sophie wiped a tear from her eye with her free hand.

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Chapter Eleven

THE CARETAKER

I t was time.

Even after months of planning, preparing, diligently researching the movements of his victim, The Caretaker felt on edge. He had meticulously put on and removed his hazmat suit on countless occasions, making sure it was sealed correctly, as he had been shown. As the blue book told him to do. It was now in the rucksack on the very top. Under it was everything else he would use, packed according to when he would need the item. He double-checked the contents of the blue book, containing all of the movements of his intended victim, even though he could recite it word for word.

With the bag securely on his back, he left his home, and made the hour train journey to where he would strike. The carriage he sat in was packed. Tourists going to the ancient and globally known university city, as well as those who were coming home from a long day at work. Most had that burnt-out look you only got from working in London. A life he couldn't ever understand. He wondered, did any of them have the faintest idea that he was who he was? Did anyone know they were so close to a soon-to-be murderer? He doubted it. He wasn't someone you noticed. And people were too wrapped up in their own self-importance to worry about anyone else. As the blue book said, hiding in plain sight was easy, as long as you

remembered people aren't looking at you, they care too much about their own problems and worries.

He looked at the commuters and wondered if any of them would be a victim of his. How many people on this train abused their partners? He hoped it was none, but the evidence suggested his hopes would be wrong.

Pushing down the questions about others, The Caretaker looked out of the window, observing the world moving by at speed, his thoughts back on his target, his reasons why, and the execution of his mission.

He was ready, he knew he was, and he would achieve what he set out to achieve, because there was no choice now. Robert's wife, Melanie, needed The Caretaker. She had said it in her own words when she realised that, whatever she did, she would never be free from his controlling ways.

Robert Worthing had to die, not because he physically hurt Melanie, but because he had scarred her internally and the woman she was meant to be in this world might not ever surface. She might have been a doctor, or a life coach. She might have been an award-winning journalist or activist. She might have been many things, if she'd been allowed to take flight rather than have her wings clipped by years and years of systematic, cement-like language that had solidified into concrete she could never escape. Not when he was there, pouring on more and more. Maybe, just maybe with him gone, and with some time, Melanie might find a chisel inside her somewhere, a thought or feeling or want from before he came into her life, and maybe, just maybe, she could dig herself out of it.

The Caretaker had to believe it was possible, that she could be saved, and that belief was the fuel needed for the flame the phoenix would rise from and burn so bright.

Boy, would it burn.

The hardest part in the preparation to end the life of this bad man was how he would enter the apartment building and ambush his prey without attracting unwanted attention. Thankfully, The Caretaker, *this* Caretaker

was able to hide in plain sight, and no one knew The Caretaker wasn't a man. He was sold as a vigilante, a male acting in the interest of women. In the first wave, The Caretaker, when ending the life of a man named Lewis, simply asked someone to let him in, and that was exactly what he would do now. So, once in Cambridge, he walked for ten minutes to the address of his target. Outside the main door, which was fob-protected, The Caretaker knelt, and pretended to be struggling to find keys in the rucksack. The word 'serendipitous' was mentioned several times in the book, and at first The Caretaker, new and evolved, didn't understand why. However, when a man approached, a man who would let him in to do what he came to do, The Caretaker understood exactly why.

'Lost your keys?' Robert said.

'They are in here somewhere,' The Caretaker replied, hoping the stress in his voice was attributed to the lost keys.

'Here, I'll let you in.'

'Thank you.'

He presented as a nice man, a polite man. The Caretaker knew the truth. But he didn't comment, he didn't attack; instead he smiled, walked inside. And then turned towards the stairs as Worthing took the lift.

Robert Worthing had now aided and abetted in his own murder.

It was serendipitous. It. Was. Perfect.

Walking up the stairs, he moved slowly: he had a little time, ten minutes or so. As he reached the fourth floor, the top floor of the building, Worthing's floor, he paused. There was a small cupboard there; he knew from his research it contained mops and cleaning products. It was locked, it always was. So, grabbing a screwdriver from his bag, he forced it into the side of the door where the lock sat, and snapped the wood around it. It opened with ease. Stepping in, he quickly donned the hazmat suit. Binding the cuffs and sleeves before putting on his hat, face mask, size ten

wellington boots. Then, happy he was secure, he felt the front pocket of the rucksack. The item he would use was heavy, hard. Waiting.

He hadn't tasered anyone before, but there was evidence of the previous Caretaker doing so. In principle, it was easy enough. You pointed at your target, pulled the trigger. Electricity would do the rest.

He was ready.

Leaving the stairwell onto the hallway that had several doors to people's homes on it, he was aware that internal security camera would pick him up. But that was okay. There had to be proof it was him, so he walked slowly, intentionally allowing himself to be seen as he headed towards apartment 273, the home of Robert Worthing. And knowing it would be unlocked for Lorna, he quietly opened it.

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Chapter Twelve

Inside, The Caretaker could hear singing coming from the bathroom, a tuneless melody that reverberated around tiled walls. Worthing sounded happy. This man was having his cake, eating it, and simultaneously stealing everything sweet from another woman. Him singing in the shower when he should have been at home with his wife was just another reason The Caretaker hated him.

Quietly closing the apartment door behind him, The Caretaker locked it. He wasn't expecting Lorna to arrive early, but he wanted to take no risks of her being hurt. She would carry her scars from this event. All of the women that had been saved did. But, in the long run, she would benefit from this act of mercy.

Moving closer to the bathroom, to the sound of running water and Worthing's terrible singing, The Caretaker slowly removed his rucksack from his back. Lowering himself behind the bathroom door, he unzipped it, pulling out his tools. In his right hand, something heavy, in his left, something light. A third thing, something tiny, was already in his right pocket, and the fourth, something sharp, in his back one. Apart, they were harmless enough. Together, they were a destructive force so powerful, others would be drawn to watch it. Together, they would end the life of

another bad man, and bring The Caretaker back to the centre of everyone's conversations.

For months, he had planned, researched, studied. For months, he knew exactly how he would kill Robert Worthing, and yet, now, in this moment, he felt his anxiety want to spill. He wanted to cry, to leave, to run away. But he couldn't. He wouldn't. He would see it through for Melanie, for the other countless victims of domestic violence. He had to do it, or he would not only fail himself, he would fail them all.

Taking the lid off the heavier object, he sniffed it, and recoiled. Some loved the smell of petrol. Some didn't. He definitely didn't. But like it or not, the smell snapped him into a more alert state.

Wired, ready, he opened the bathroom door, and stepped inside.

Worthing didn't hear him approach, his back turned to The Caretaker. He continued to sing and wash, blissfully unaware of what was about to happen. And The Caretaker, unblinking, not daring to breathe, drew closer to the misted-up glass that separated him from his target. Putting down the petrol, he turned on the taser in his left hand, and pointing it at his target, he pulled the trigger.

Robert Worthing convulsed, every muscle in his body spasmed before he fell to the floor of the shower. The Caretaker reached over him, turned off the shower. He then pulled out a surgical scalpel from his back pocket, and carved into his chest, as instructed to. Placing both the scalpel and taser safely in his pocket, he grabbed the petrol, and poured the contents of the bottle over his victim's head. Robert recoiled again, the smell of the petrol acting like sniffing salts. As his eyes focused on his surroundings, The Caretaker saw that his target understood what was happening. Worthing was face to face with the man who haunted the dreams of men like him.

'No, no. Please,' he begged, paralysed by fear, the whites of his eyes showing, his hands going up to defend himself. But as much as The Caretaker could see his fear and want for things to be different, he knew

men like him, they didn't change. They talked of it convincingly, but with hollow words, like a tree that had long since died and was destined to fall at some point, killing anything living in its branches.

‘Please, please.’

The Caretaker had stopped listening. Reaching into his pocket to pull out the last item needed, he flicked the steel against the flint, and a flame leapt from the Zippo lighter. Worthing, realising what was happening, began to panic. His flight mode kicked in and, in his desperation to fight his way to safety, he slipped on the petrol which had covered his shower cubicle base, and fell. Hitting his head against the shower tap on his way down. It all but knocked him out. Worthing, now incapacitated, further allowed The Caretaker to take a step back, so he wouldn't get burnt, and then throw the Zippo lighter at him.

Flames exploded up Worthing's body, and for a moment, he did nothing. He looked confused, like somehow the flames hadn't worked as flames should. But that would pass: his nervous system was in shock, the fire so hot it rendered his nerve endings useless.

The fire moved quickly, consuming his exposed skin and, with that, the pain began. Worthing's silence was replaced with a high-pitched scream. It was quickly followed by flailing arms, a desperation to outrun his fate. But the pain kept him contained. He wouldn't outrun this, death was coming for him. Quick, white-hot, vengeful.

The Caretaker thought of the sixth point in the manifesto.

Violence is not the point. Ending violence is.

As the fire worked its way up to Robert's head, setting his hair ablaze, The Caretaker knew he wouldn't be able to watch what came next. He threw the petrol canister into the shower, to melt any evidence of him touching it, and turned to leave. Reaching the door, he needed to look. It was like when a video on Facebook declared a warning that something awful was going to happen in it, but you watched anyway.

One look wouldn't hurt.

As he turned back, Robert was writhing on the floor of the shower cubicle, his body ablaze, his face melting. And The Caretaker knew it wouldn't be the screams that haunted him, nor the smell, it would be the fact that, as he looked, he saw his target's eyes had gone, succumbed to the heat and fire. Two lifeless, charred holes. A gateway to nothing.

As Robert's screams died down, The Caretaker carefully packed his bag, knowing there would be no trace of him on a DNA level. He left the flat, running to the stairwell as the building's fire alarm system kicked in, flashing lights and shrieking an intermittent siren. Just as he had hoped.

Hiding back in the supply closet full of mops and cleaning products, he quickly ripped off the hazmat suit, boots, mask and hat and stuffed them in the bag, metamorphosing into someone else, someone unsuspecting. He joined the gathering people leaving the building. One, a young woman, commented on being able to smell petrol. He had accounted for this, and moved quickly towards the exit.

As he stepped out into the street, teeming with scared, bleary-eyed, excited residents, he looked back to the fourth floor, and saw the unmistakable flicking of firelight through the bathroom window of Robert Worthing. He then moved to the opposite building, and down a side alley to a carpark where his car sat. He opened the boot, threw in the bag, and quickly dosed himself in perfume, before making his way back towards the commotion.

At first, they would assume it was accidental, then they would learn someone had died. A tragedy. But The Caretaker wouldn't let that be. A video was being prepared as he watched the fire burn. One that would be released within the hour.

The phoenix had arisen, and soon, everyone would be talking once again about The Caretaker, and his justice. And boy, was it hot.

Chapter Thirteen

JESS

Armed with the knowledge that The Caretaker was about to attack, but not being involved in the planning or knowing of how he would kill, was for my own good. Soon he would be back, people would be talking and, like it or not, the focus and attention would come back to us four. The original ‘saved’. The media and the police would investigate everyone who was involved, the partner of the victim, the families of both, but ultimately The Caretaker and us, the original group, went hand in hand. You couldn’t talk about one without the other. Me, Kelly, Hannah and Madison would be thrown under the microscope once more. Scrutinised. People didn’t know we were once The Caretaker. That three of the four of us killed, pretending to be that man. For everyone outside of our tight group, we were simply the focus of his retribution, just as much victims as those who died. People didn’t know the truth, although one person heavily suspected it, but she couldn’t prove it.

I wondered if Sophie would call once it was out that he had returned.

Unable to sleep, I created my profile on the Signal app as Kimberley said. I then sent her the username via a text message from the burner phone that was on my doorstep when I returned home from our secret meeting. Within minutes I was added to a chat entitled ‘The Network’. Unable to see anything posted before I joined, if there was anything to see at all, I paced

my flat, I cleaned the kitchen, ironed my work clothes ready for the morning, and I waited, but waiting alone was hard. Feeling agitated, I rang Kelly, who picked up straight away, like she was waiting for someone to call.

‘Hey.’

‘Hey, you got that quick,’ I said.

‘Phone’s been in my hand for ages now.’

‘You okay?’

‘Yep, you?’

‘Yeah. All good,’ I said. And I sensed she was in the same place as me: anxious as hell and wanting to know it was done, the new Caretaker was safe, and the message had been released. However, we couldn’t talk about that. Neither Kelly nor I were sure it was safe to talk about anything on the phone. So we chatted about everything else: the session, Esme, the newest member, and our friends.

‘Kel, have you noticed Madison isn’t quite herself lately?’

‘Yeah, I have.’

‘Should we be worried?’

‘I don’t know, maybe. We should have an evening together. Just the four of us, make sure she’s coping.’

‘That’s a good idea. We’ve not hung out for a while now.’

‘Nope, which is shit. It’s us against the world.’

‘Okay, let’s get through the next couple of days,’ I said, knowing I couldn’t dare say any more. ‘And we’ll get it sorted.’

‘Sounds gre—’ Kelly started before falling silent. I almost asked what was wrong, but then my phone buzzed in my hands, and I knew what had happened.

‘I’ll speak to you later,’ Kelly said.

‘Yeah,’ I said, hanging up, and opening the Signal app, I saw there was a new post from a user called ‘The Network Supervisor’. It was direct,

plain. Three words.

It is done.

And then more encrypted messages flooded in.

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Chapter Fourteen

THE NETWORK GROUP CHAT

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

It is done.

INTH3SHADOWS

Shit really?

FAIRANDSQUARE666

Yes. And soon everyone will know. TikTok will have it, YouTube too.

BLACKWIDOW

It will be taken down again quickly.

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

But not quickly enough. We've seen it before, the world moves too fast for anything like that to stay hidden. What 'the saved' created with The Caretaker is too loud to be silenced.

B3LLADONNA

I cannot believe it's finally happening.

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

As we planned, everything went as it should.

INTH3SHADOWS

Is The Caretaker okay?

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

All is well. He is safe, and resting.

CAPABLESALAMANDER

Is the man...

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

It is all dealt with. He is dealt with.

THESUNMAID

For those originals, 'the saved'. Things will get messy.

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

They will be fine, they have been prepared.

B3LLADONNA

What happens next?

REDSHADEKIMBA

We wait for the world to talk again. Those directly involved will need shielding. This is about ensuring that, when they talk, new legislation that has been proposed is pushed to the finish line.

NORTHERNUPROAR

What legislation?

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

A law to create a database of all those who have been investigated and charged with DV. With public access, to ensure that those who have hurt in a domestic situation are able to be held to account. They might not face prosecution, but those with a violent past towards their partners will not be able to hide anymore. It doesn't help those who are current DV victims, but it will stop future ones from happening. The Caretaker will ensure this law comes to pass.

B3LLADONNA

Isn't that Clare's Law?

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

No, it's more than that. With Clare's Law, the police are the only ones who know if a man, or woman, is considered dangerous. This law is to give people, mostly women, more power to make sure they are safe. Clare's Law was a big step, born of a crime, a death, that shouldn't have ever happened. But still women are dying at the hands of men who are known to be dangerous. This law is to give power back to individuals.

REDACTEDUSER

I can't believe it's actually happening. The originals, are they members of this?

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

Yes. They are here. No names, though, please.

NO-ONE.HOME

I am one of them.

SILENTINDEX

As am I.

INTH3SHADOWS

What do we do now?

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

We move on to the next in our plan. Bolton, are you ready?

RADIOACTIVE-CAT2911

Bolton is ready.

Chapter Fifteen

SOPHIE SALAM

Sophie knew sleep wouldn't come. Karl Kendrick, Lottie's biological father, had called a few times in as many months and she didn't know why. She reasoned he wanted her for something, Karl wasn't the type of man to waste his time on anyone, or anything, if he didn't want something specific. But, so far, he'd not asked. She had even changed her landline number, blocked all unknown calls to her personal mobile, and still, somehow, he had found her. She was fairly confident he didn't know about Lottie. There was no reason for him to believe he had fathered a child. And she wanted to keep it that way.

In the wake of his arrest, she ensured she covered her bases. Even then, she knew no good would come from her time by Karl's side. She had been careful, ensuring there was another man, a one-night thing, after him so, if anyone wondered, she would be able to claim that other man was the father. She knew people would think less of her, but the truth was far worse. In reality, she had violated all rules and codes to do with her time undercover. She had blurred boundaries, she had slept with her mark. Her job had been to get close, gather evidence. Lottie was proof that the lines had blurred. If the truth came out about who the father was to her little girl, she would lose her job. If the truth ever came out about that night in February when she first discovered she was pregnant, and what she was involved in, she would

go to prison, and lose so much more. But back then, she had no choice: even when she was unborn, even the size of a bean, Sophie knew she would do anything to protect her daughter – even unspeakable things.

With Lottie snoring gently on her lap, Sophie remained vigilant, and to pass the time she Googled his name. He was, as far as she could see, still in prison serving out his sentence.

‘Okay, so not that,’ she said, relieved that he wasn’t already out, ready to bang on her door at any moment.

Closing her phone, she placed it on the bed beside her, and then focused on Lottie. Her little girl had a slight twitch in her eye. A stress marker, and she wondered what that would mean. She hoped it would fade, but with that, as well as trying to bang her head, it felt like a relapse was coming. She wanted to message Jess, ask her if a relapse was normal, and how to prevent it, but she couldn’t.

She realised she missed her.

‘Jesus, Sophie, get a grip. Close your eyes,’ she said to herself. Lottie was safe. If she was stressed, Sophie would deal with it. Karl didn’t know he had a daughter, and as he was in prison he wasn’t going to find out any time soon. All was well. All was well.

Sophie closed her eyes, focused on the sound of Lottie’s deep breathing and the feel of her soft hair as she stroked it. Her mind raced, but she fought to find a pocket of stillness, a breathing hole of silence in her mind, and she leant into it until her body began to feel heavy, her heart slowed, and sleep drifted towards her.

Her phone vibrated, stealing her from her moment of peace. Looking at the caller display, she saw it was Clarke. A forensic officer within the police force, and her long-suffering friend, and looking at the time, she knew all wouldn’t be well as soon as she and he spoke. Clarke didn’t call her at home, especially at three in the morning.

‘Hey, didn’t wake you, did I?’ he said when she answered.

‘No, no, I don’t sleep much these days.’

‘All okay?’

‘Fine.’

‘Are you sure? You’re getting enough vitamins, there are supplements you can—’

‘Clarke, it’s three a.m., have you really called me to talk about supplements?’

‘No, sorry.’

‘Also, you’re not my dad.’

‘Thank fuck for that. You’d be a headache.’

‘Charming.’

‘Listen, I’ll cut to it.’

‘Wish you would,’ Sophie said.

‘There has been a fire in a flat, in Cambridge.’

‘All right?’ Sophie said, yawning.

‘A man died.’

‘Clarke, why have you called me for this?’

‘I’ve just been told by the crime scene investigator there, the victim had a small cross carved into his chest.’

‘What?’ Sophie said, sitting upright and almost waking Lottie, who grumbled and rolled over onto her side. ‘Are you sure?’ she continued, her voice a hard whisper.

‘I’m heading there now. I can confirm and call you back. But Sophie, they’ve sent a picture, I’m pretty sure it’s him.’

‘Shit.’

‘Yeah, shit.’

‘Has there been a video?’

‘Nothing yet. Might be a coincidence, the cross might be an old scar or mark, or shitty tattoo maybe, but...’

‘Yeah, but,’ Sophie echoed.

‘I’ll call you in about an hour. Okay?’

‘I’ll get my mum over. I’ll meet you there. Cambridge, you said?’

‘Yeah, I’ll send the address now.’

Clarke hung up and Sophie took a deep breath. Cambridge. Where she began her career, where she crossed the line with Kendrick, the place she vowed to never return to.

But that didn’t bother her as much as the thought that The Caretaker might be back.

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Chapter Sixteen

THE CARETAKER

The crowd that gathered when the fire alarms started had swelled as passersby stopped to gawp. Now, several hundred pairs of eyes watched as the flames danced and licked the top floor of the building as the firefighters battled against them. The smoke that bellowed into the night sky and the orange hue of flames that stained the clouds was biblical in nature, end of days, thick and consuming and awesome.

Twenty-four-year-old Cheryl Mellor was just like everyone else, mesmerised and small in comparison to what she witnessed. She watched, shoulder to shoulder with strangers. Like it was New Year's Eve on the Southbank. She thought she would feel more: regret, adrenaline, fear maybe. But she felt nothing at all. But then, she hadn't done this, Cheryl Mellor wasn't culpable, so she pushed her down, and stayed as The Caretaker, in thought if not body. The Caretaker had committed this crime, this justice.

Soon they would find the body of Robert Worthing, and then, when they had, it would be time.

No longer Cheryl Mellor, The Caretaker watched, mingled, speculated with strangers as to what had happened. He heard several say, 'I hope no one is in that flat,' to which he agreed.

An hour passed, an hour of firefighters working hard to make the building safe, and then, once they had, from outside the building, the emergency services stepped up. Paramedics ran in. Not long after, a police team followed. They had found Robert Worthing.

Logging into Signal, The Caretaker posted a simple message.

He's been found.

After sending the message, The Caretaker drifted towards the back of the crowd. It was time to leave; however, he wanted to experience the rush the original Caretaker would have felt when becoming famous. It wouldn't take long, with social media. Things rarely did.

The first whisperings of his name came within a few minutes. A ripple that spread quickly through the crowd. And a man standing beside The Caretaker, possibly one of the university's students, gasped. 'Oh shit.'

'Are you okay?' The Caretaker asked.

'Yeah, sorry. It's just, have you seen this? He's back.'

'Sorry? Who?' The Caretaker said, feigning ignorance.

The young man turned the screen to face The Caretaker, and the image of him dressed in a hazmat suit, black hat and face mask filled the screen.

'Can you turn it up? I want to hear what he is saying.'

'Hang on, I've got headphones.'

The student plugged in his headphones, handed The Caretaker one of the earpieces, and they listened together, two strangers bonded by violence. The Caretaker looked around: many more stood as they stood, no longer looking at the awe-striking scene as the building smouldered, but focused on small screens. Strangers sharing this experience with people they didn't know.

It said a lot about the world.

'Tonight, I have returned,' The Caretaker began in the video. 'Robert Worthing was a man who destroyed a woman's sense of self by drowning

her fire with his words and actions. This woman will never find her flame once more. He didn't hit her, but his words bruised her, cut her deeply. She may present as a woman who is okay, but his words have killed her inside.

'He snuffed out her flame, and so paid for his crime by becoming the flame.

'Those who abuse, even silently: I am back, a phoenix rising from this fire tonight, and I will come for you. There is nowhere safe for you anymore. You have buried women with your abuse. Now I will bury you.'

As the video ended, The Caretaker looked up and saw people recoiling from what he had said. And the divide began instantly. Some cheered his return, some booed, like The Caretaker was a pantomime villain. For most, this was just a spectacle, a game that allowed them to offer an opinion, and that was okay, it was needed. Because the more divisive the conversations became, the more change would happen. There was a law to pass, and, with their voices combined with his actions, change would happen quickly. As the excitement of his return spread like a plague through the crowd, a chant began to ring out into the night.

'I will bury you,' they said. Not *he* will, but *I* will.

Interesting.

The people of Cambridge would think that The Caretaker was targeting their streets, targeting their bad men. Soon they would know his reach was far more than they anticipated.

Seeing enough, and feeling a wave of sickness sweep over him, no doubt as the adrenaline was wearing thin, The Caretaker began moving through the crowd towards the waiting car. He would never be caught for this. The original serial killer support group had covered for one another, but rumours were that someone in the police knew of their connection. A DS named Salam. She wouldn't ever catch on. This Caretaker didn't know Robert Worthing. He didn't know Melanie Worthing either.

Leaving The Caretaker's energy in the crowd, Cheryl walked away. The need to sleep, cry, throw up was beginning to press on her. But, despite feeling overwhelmed by what she had done in his name, she knew she was safe. She was just another woman in the network, and with no link to either victim or those connected to the serial killer who had returned. Cheryl Mellor would continue with her life, knowing she had saved a woman, knowing soon a stranger would save her from the life she was stuck in.

Pushing to the back of the crowd, Cheryl crossed a road in front of a slow-moving car, and as she waved to say sorry for stepping out, she saw that in the car was DS Sophie Salam.

She was here quickly, and already on the case. But she would fail. Nothing could stop the network from putting right the wrongs in the world. Nothing would impede their bringing of justice to those who deserved to be punished. Nothing would stop them pushing and pushing until the laws around perpetrators of domestic violence had been changed.

Still, she sent a message on Signal, so the original members, the heroes they were, knew.

YOUDONTKNOWME

SS is here.

A message came back within seconds.

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

Don't linger. She is too smart to toy with.

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Chapter Seventeen

SOPHIE SALAM

Getting out of her car, the pre-dawn light threatening to push over the horizon, Sophie looked at the crowd in front of her. People argued, some had the look of violence, and unless it was dealt with promptly, that's what would follow. People were chanting too. She heard The Caretaker mentioned, loved and loathed in equal measure, and she knew what that meant. He had already posted. He had already shared his kill. To do so, he must have filmed nearby. She scanned the buildings, wondering where he could be. It was pointless looking, though: he wouldn't declare he was there. Standing close to her, a group of teenagers were stood looking at a screen.

She flashed her identification. 'I need to see that.'

She didn't wait for them to offer, or protest: she took the phone.

'Hey, I have rights, man,' a gangly young man said. More pimple than polish.

Sophie ignored him, and looked at the phone. The Caretaker looked back. She couldn't hear what he was saying, but that wasn't what she needed to focus on. He was near to the scene, and she wanted to see where.

The room he was in was dark, neutral. It looked like an unfinished building site. She looked at the buildings nearby, hoping, but in a busy student area, with hundreds of flats, he could literally be anywhere.

‘Hey, you gonna give me back my phone or what?’

‘Yeah, yeah,’ she said, handing it back, not interested in the moaning of the kid who felt violated. Instead, she scanned the crowd, looking for someone acting like they knew more than everyone else. She looked for Kelly, Jess, Madison and Hannah, but she knew they wouldn’t risk being there.

She wondered where they were right now.

Approaching a uniformed officer, she had to shout over the din to get his attention, and when he turned, he recognised her instantly.

‘DS Salam? So, it’s true?’

‘We don’t know anything yet.’

‘But he’s posted.’

‘If it’s him. Look, right now, we need to focus on this crowd. Get more officers here. This will turn to shit unless these people are dispersed.’

‘Already on it, ma’am.’

‘Great, let’s see if we can get them back from the building. Close the road. Send everyone home.’

‘And what if the building is their home?’

‘Then send them somewhere else. No one comes in this building.’

Nodding, the officer moved on towards the swell, and as he began to talk people down, Sophie felt she should help, but that wasn’t her role. Hers was to look at the scene. Work the crime. Find The Caretaker.

Stepping into the building, Sophie was greeted by the fire service crew manager.

‘Building is sound, fire was mostly contained to the room and roof.’

‘Okay, thank you.’

‘Guys are saying it’s that Caretaker fella. Is that true?’

‘We don’t know,’ Sophie said, walking past him and up towards the scene.

Sophie was out of breath by the time she reached the fourth floor and the victim's front door. Clarke was waiting for her in his white overalls. She could see smears of black on his arms, telling her he had been in the charred flat already. As she approached, he pulled down his face mask, concern etched into his expression.

'Maybe you need to hit a treadmill, Soph. You're looking a bit puffed out.'

'Yeah, yeah. Nice to see you too,' she replied, catching her breath.

'I've got almost two decades on you, skipped up those stairs.'

'Good for you, Clarke.'

'Just kidding. I thought I was going to die,' he said, breaking into a big smile as he stepped in and gave her a hug. 'How you doing, kid?'

'I'm good.'

'Lottie?'

'She's great.' Sophie smiled.

'Good.'

'Why you being so nice? It's unnerving.'

Clarke laughed. 'Well, I figured, what I'm gonna show you is going to cause you a massive headache, so thought I'd be nice to lessen the blow.'

'How thoughtful. So, lay it on me.'

'Suit up.'

Grabbing protective overalls and shoe covers, Sophie stepped into the flat. Mobile lighting had been set up, powered by generators that whirred noisily, the bulbs blindingly bright and illuminating every nook and cranny inside. The smell of melted plastic was powerful, even through the mask Sophie put on.

'Where is he?'

'In the bathroom,' Clarke mumbled.

Following him, Sophie took in the scene, and what was left of the victim. A lot of his body remained intact, but his face was gone. His eye

sockets were empty, as if death itself was staring back at her. His cheeks were gone, too, exposing blackened teeth.

‘Jesus,’ Sophie said.

‘Looks like petrol was poured on him. See how the left side is worse than the right. The petrol ran off his head down that side before it was ignited. They did a good job torching him.’

‘So it seems. Can you imagine?’

‘I’d rather not.’

‘Do we know who it was?’

‘Robert Worthing. An estate agent. Seems like an ordinary type. But outside it’s gotten crazy. I’m guessing The Caretaker has taken credit?’ Clarke asked.

‘Just as I got here. Are we sure it’s him, and not just a fanatic? Or a copycat?’

‘Yeah. It’s him. Look.’

Clarke shone a torch on the torso of the victim. It was charred from flame, his skin blackened and broken. His left arm was almost gone. But his chest was mostly intact. Sophie leant in, trying to ignore the smell that reminded her of pork roasts she had as a kid, as well as the patches of melted human, exposed bone, black eye sockets, and glistening fat. Instead, she focused on a tiny patch of skin on the victim’s chest. If you didn’t know to look, you’d never see it. However, it was there. As it had been before.

A tiny cross.

The police hadn’t released this detail of the kills. It was undeniable proof he had returned.

‘Shit,’ Sophie said.

‘This is your case now, isn’t it? Anything to do with him comes through you?’

‘Yeah, it is.’

‘Then congratulations, and equally, I’m sorry, kid. This is great for your career, but this is also gonna be a total shitstorm.’

‘Yes, it is.’ Her thoughts moved from the man in front of her, who he was, why he was chosen, and for the second time in a handful of hours, but for a very different reason, she thought of Jess Pendle. She pushed it down. Jess would be spoken to soon enough. Until then, she had work to do. The Caretaker killing again would put more pressure on her for answers, and she had to be the one to find them.

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Chapter Eighteen

JESS

Just like the night I first discovered the truth about what the support group was doing in the shadows, my mind whirled, hours passed slowly and – when I did manage to slow my heart, calm my mind, close my eyes – my dreams, vivid and visceral, woke me quickly.

Kelly, Madison, Hannah and I had been told nothing about the plan, to protect us. We knew he was back, he had killed again, but who the victim was, and how he was targeted, we were as much in the dark as the rest of the world. We weren't told, to ensure that when the police came asking – and they would come asking – we were able to tell the truth this time. It was to keep us original members safe, and I knew this; however, all it did was empower this sense of not being in control.

But, we four, we had done our bit. We had created change and now someone else, The Network Supervisor, who I was sure was Kimberley Murphy, had taken the reins. We were protected by our ignorance. I didn't know who the victim was, or who The Caretaker was, and that would keep me safe. Because one thing I did know was that eyes would now look at me again. One of 'the saved' the media had branded us after The Caretaker murdered our abusive partners. Saved, maybe, but there was a cost.

Today, everything would change, again. The moderate calm as The Caretaker story began to fade would once more be thrown into the spotlight.

My past would be dug up, Lewis would no doubt be mentioned, as would the other men The Caretaker targeted, and I wanted nothing more than to stay at home, hide away. However, I knew I couldn't. Hiding in plain sight was always part of the plan, and that couldn't change now. Besides, Will and Eva needed me. Jenny needed me to come to work. So, I got out of bed, turned on the radio, and made myself a coffee. With it in my hands, its astringent taste waking up my nervous system, I looked out of my living room window into the early-morning street, expecting to see at least one reporter or influencer waiting for me. To my surprise, no one was there. I realised their immediate action would be to stalk the victim's family, the newest 'saved'. Get the scoop, and then it would filter back to the source. I breathed a sigh of relief. Change was still coming, just not before my coffee.

Wanting to ensure I was gone before anyone turned up, I showered, made myself look presentable enough, despite the lack of sleep and rising anxiety, and prepared to leave. I was too early for work, so I would grab another coffee before heading to Will and Eva. I was sure Jenny wouldn't mind me being there off-shift for a while before my working day began. She was more than my employer, she was family, and so were her children.

Since The Caretaker swept into my life, work had been harder. The children were different. They understood enough to know something had happened to me. When we went out, me trying to do my job properly in caring for them, we were sometimes accosted and I was asked questions.

Today, Jenny was at the office. Samual was away at a conference, and I wouldn't leave their house. Will, Eva and I would colour, watch a movie, play games until their mum came home and my shift ended. It wasn't ideal, the children had complex needs and being outside in nature regulated them so well. But I couldn't face being hounded today. I couldn't put them through it.

Hiding in plain sight didn't mean I needed to put myself in a position to be seen.

Having one final check into the street to ensure I was alone, I headed outside into the warm and cloying early-morning air. It was going to be hot today, really hot. Another good reason to stay inside with the kids.

Crossing the road and unlocking my car, I opened the door to get inside and was grabbed by the shoulder. I jumped, spinning around to see a man stood in front of me.

'What the fuck?' I said, shoving him hard, making him stumble. 'Don't you dare touch me.'

'I'm sorry, please, tell him I didn't mean to do it,' he said, his hands up, chest height, palms showing. Sweat glistened on his forehead; heat, or stress maybe.

'You need to back off. You can't approach someone like that,' I said, hoping I sounded calmer than I felt. The way he snuck up, grabbed me, it reminded me of Lewis. I wanted to run away, but I was The Caretaker once. I had stood in front of a bad man, told him I would kill him unless he changed. I wasn't running ever again.

'Sorry,' he said, taking two steps back. 'Please, tell him I didn't mean it.'

'Tell who?'

'The Caretaker. He's back. You know him. Please.'

'I don't know him.'

'You are one of 'the saved'. You must be able to get a message to him. I didn't mean to hit her.'

'Who?'

'My girlfriend.'

'Then why did you?' I said, feeling myself wanting to step closer to him.

‘We were play-fighting, messing around. I caught her in the eye by accident. I was just trying to tickle her. I swear, it was an accident.’

‘Does she fear you? Don’t lie, I’ll know if you’re lying.’

‘No, not at all. We were just playing,’ he said, and I could see, this man was not one of those men. They are masters at hiding in plain sight. But I could see in this man, there was nothing of Lewis, or Jake, or DS Jones.

‘We can call her if you want?’ he said.

‘What is your name?’

‘Bill. Bill Highton.’

‘Bill. Go home.’

‘But, I swear.’

‘Bill, you have nothing to worry about. Go home.’

‘So, you’ll tell him? You’ll tell The Caretaker I’m not a bad man.’

‘I don’t know him, but if I did, yeah. I would.’

‘Thank you, Jess, thank you.’

‘Go home, Bill. Stay a good man, please. We need more of you.’

‘I will, I swear.’

Bill turned and walked away from me, and I could see the relief in his shoulders. The Caretaker was back, and his message was once more ringing out for all to hear.

Getting in my car, I felt the surge of adrenaline fade, and I wanted to cry. Not for Bill, but for how Lewis, even gone, still had the ability to make me wobble. I wondered, does anyone who has suffered like I did, ever escape it? Even with The Caretaker to help?

I pushed down the question. Now wasn’t the time to regress. I had to move forward, look like I was a woman who was just surviving each day and nothing more.

Bill was a good man and he was still afraid. I hoped that The Caretaker’s return would light the fuse for the law to be changed. Even I didn’t want him around for long. Even I was afraid.

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Chapter Nineteen

As I drove, I checked my mirrors anxiously, my hands shaking uncontrollably. That man was mild-mannered, and he was afraid of me because of my association with The Caretaker, but even knowing that, the way he snuck up on me, grabbed my shoulder, my first instinct was fear.

Lewis was dead, but still he lingered within me.

Reminding myself I was safe, that no one could hurt me ever again, I turned on the air conditioning and pointed the vents directly at me to cool me down. Sweat had formed on my upper lip, and I could feel it running from my neck, snagging on my bra strap. Heat and anxiety working together perfectly.

I needed to stop.

Pulling over, I turned the fans as high as they would go, and took a moment, knowing if I didn't get control, I faced the real risk of this feeling spiralling into a full-blown anxiety attack. Grabbing my phone, I scrolled, watching videos and looking at photos on Instagram. I didn't much care for it anymore, social media, but it distracted me, which I needed.

It didn't take long, maybe a minute, for me to see the first post that mentioned The Caretaker. The ad for an online media source, with an image of Hannah when she was The Caretaker months before, carried its clickbait title 'Man Killer Returns?'

I looked at the post. It was brief but spoke of a new killing in Cambridge. That much I knew; however, one thing I didn't know was that Sophie Salam, my friend, was mentioned.

...Heading up the task force, Detective Sergeant Sophie Salam is yet to comment on the speculation that this murder is in fact notorious serial killer The Caretaker...

Heading up the investigation. Sophie Salam was now the boss.

Closing my phone, I tried to ignore the niggle caused knowing that this woman I liked, one I called my friend, was now leading the investigation which would no doubt cast its light back on me. She had been close before when The Caretaker killed, too close. I couldn't let that happen again. Friend or not, if she had proof, we would all go to prison. I pulled out my phone, and as I continued my journey, I called Kelly.

'You okay?' she said as soon as she picked up.

'Yeah, you?'

'All good. It's early, what's up?'

'Have you seen?'

'Everyone has, I think,' Kelly said, yawning as she did, like the events in the night were of no matter at all.

'No, I mean Sophie.'

'What about her?'

'She's in charge of The Caretaker taskforce.'

'Then she will be busy.'

'You're not worried?'

'She's smart, but Jess, she is gonna be far away from us. The more she has to do elsewhere, the more likely it is she will leave us alone.'

'Yeah, you're right.'

'All is good. Okay?'

‘Okay.’

‘Great. Working today, aren’t you?’

‘Yep. Plain sight, right?’

‘Exactly. I know we said we’d wait for things to calm down, but lets grab a drink later, the four of us. Got something I want to talk to everyone about?’

‘Sounds good. Everything okay?’

‘All fine, just another event we have been asked to attend. Besides, we needed to anyway, for Madison.’

‘That’s true.’

‘I’ll message the others. Seven?’

‘I’ll be there, thanks, Kel.’

Kelly was right, Sophie being in charge was a good thing. She would be busy, and from the limited things I knew of the plan, she would be far away from me and not have any reason to come looking my way for answers. If I was going to see Sophie, it would be for social reasons only. Knowing this, my anxiety faded further, allowing me to drive with less tension and take in the morning. People were out, no doubt sleep-deprived from the heat that seemed to intensify at night, walking dogs before the tarmac became too hot, or pushing babies in buggies, trying to settle them before another relentless day. Keeping an eye on the road, I took in the trees, swaying in the heat, some losing their leaves because the ground was so parched. Grass had lost its lustre; greens faded like an old photograph.

The world was too hot, like at any moment it could burst into flames, but that wasn’t for me to worry about. My world was keeping myself fit and healthy, caring for Eva and Will, looking after my friends, and carrying a secret.

By the time I had reached the coffee shop, my heart rate had calmed to a steady seventy beats a minute, and the sweat that threatened to consume me had passed. Getting out of my car, the early-morning heat slapping me, I

walked towards my favourite coffee shop. But, as I approached, and looked inside, I saw in the queue was Sophie Salam and her daughter Lottie. I hesitated at the door, causing a woman behind me to tut angrily as I blocked her entry.

‘Sorry,’ I said.

She didn’t reply, but brushed past me and opened the door. The cool of the café was inviting, the smell of coffee enticing. But I didn’t enter straight away. Between The Caretaker and being grabbed by a terrified man, I worried Sophie would see I knew something about what happened in Cambridge and have questions. I was about to turn and walk away when I heard a little voice calling.

‘Jess!’

Lottie had seen me and came running over, stopping short of giving me a hug. ‘Hello.’ she said.

‘Hello, Lottie, how are you?’ I replied, knowing without needing to look that Sophie had now seen me.

‘Good. Mummy and I are having hot chocolate.’

‘You lucky girl.’

‘Come on,’ she said, grabbing me by the hand and dragging me inside. As she did, Sophie came over and lowered herself to Lottie’s eye level.

‘Lottie, you know not to run out of a shop like that.’

‘But Mummy, it’s Jess.’

‘I know, but you have to be safe, okay?’

‘Okay.’

‘Why don’t you go and sit down? Anywhere you want.’

‘Uh-huh.’

Lottie left our side, and Sophie, standing up came eye to eye with me. ‘Sorry about that.’

‘No, it’s fine. Kinda needed it,’ I said.

‘I bet,’ she replied, and I could see she wanted to ask more.

Thankfully, before she could, Lottie ran back and grabbed my hand.
'Come and sit.'

'Oh, Lottie, I'm not staying today, I'm grabbing a takeaway, I have to go to work.'

'Please,' she said and I felt torn. I didn't have the energy to deal with questions from Sophie, but Lottie was a sweet girl, and I didn't like the idea of upsetting her.

'It's okay, today it's Jess,' Sophie said, and I nodded.

'Jess, huh? Not Miss Pendle, even with what's happened?'

'Right now, no. Right now, it's Jess. What did you want to drink?'

'Just a black americano. Thanks.'

Letting Lottie pull me by the hand, I was guided to a table in the corner. Sitting, Lottie beside me, I listened as she chatted about the birds she liked the best. It seemed my bird song idea when I first met her had taken on a life of its own. The day we met, she was mid-meltdown, and I let her listen to bird song through my headphones. It calmed her that day, and by the sound of her talking about herons, which I assumed were her favourite type of bird, it seemed it had become something bigger.

Sophie joined us a few minutes later, and handed me my coffee in a takeaway cup. I thanked her.

'What are you talking about?' she asked, sitting opposite me.

'Herons. I'm guessing they are her favourite?'

'Right now. She's obsessed, though. You're to thank for that,' she said, teasing.

'That makes me happy,' I said.

'Wait till you've had a few hours of it. Usually at bedtime.'

'Oh God.'

'She's now an expert in delaying going to sleep.'

'Thank you for the coffee,' I said, shifting to stand. 'I better go to work. Lottie, thank you for telling me everything about herons. I liked learning.'

‘What’s your favourite bird?’

‘Ummm, maybe a kingfisher?’ I said.

‘They are nice. I like their blue.’

‘Me too. See you soon, Lottie.’

Lottie picked up her drink and began to enjoy it as I got to my feet.

Sophie stood too. ‘Jess, I, um, there’s a lot going on.’

‘Yeah, I see you’re heading up The Caretaker thing.’

‘I am. Can I ask you something?’

‘Sure?’ I said, hoping my lack of sleep and elevated stress didn’t show.

‘Lottie, stay here, okay,’ Sophie said.

‘Where are you going?’

‘I’m just walking Jess to the door. I’m not leaving.’

‘Okay.’

I walked away, and Sophie came with me. As we reached the door, she looked back to make sure Lottie was happy. She smiled a hot chocolate smile, and I smiled back.

‘I assume I’m Miss Pendle again?’ I said. ‘I know nothing about last night. I was at home, you can ask—’

‘No, it’s about Lottie.’

‘Lottie?’ I said, feeling my flight mechanism shift. ‘What about her? She okay?’

‘She’s great this morning, she’s been great for a long time. But she started to slip a bit.’

‘Oh no.’

‘Bird song isn’t enough. We are going to go to the doctors, and I know I’m working a lot more which isn’t helping, I just, I don’t know what to do.’

‘Kids are like adults: some days are good, some days aren’t, and sometimes we just don’t know why.’

‘I know, but I don’t want her hurting herself.’

‘Nor do I. But try not to worry, a backward step isn’t always a bad thing. I’ll think of any other tricks. She’s really into birds, there will be something linked that will help her regulate when she’s overwhelmed. I’ll give it some thought.’

‘I feel like a terrible mother.’

‘Not at all, Soph. Just an overworked one.’

‘Thanks, Jess. You look tired.’

‘So do you.’

‘See you soon,’ she said, and I noticed it was more of a statement than a question. I wondered in what context she saw it in her head.

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Chapter Twenty

D riving to work, I replayed the conversation with Sophie over and over, making sure I'd not said or done anything that would show her I knew more. Our run-in, in a professional capacity, had been tough, and I didn't want to face being questioned again by the police.

Arriving at work, satisfied I had done okay and Sophie wouldn't send the police to kick down my door, I knocked, and was greeted by a very excited Eva.

'Aunty Jess.'

'Hello, darling,' I said, picking her up and giving her a big squeeze. 'How are you?'

'Good.'

Putting her down, I walked into the kitchen and Jenny smiled from the kitchen island. 'Morning, you're early?'

'I was up and figured I'd just come, see you before you had to shoot off. Where's Will?'

'In bed, he didn't have a great night. He's fine, just restless, the heat.'

'I'll go check on him in a little while.'

'Thanks, Jess. You okay?'

'Yeah, I'm good.'

'I assume you saw the news?'

‘Yep,’ I said. ‘Thankfully, I’ve not had anyone at my door. Wasn’t followed here either.’

‘That’s good to know.’

From the living room, Eva called my name and, excusing myself, I went in to join her. She was watching something on YouTube, a young streamer who had horses. I sat with her, and we watched the girl tend to and ride her horse. I found it all too loud, like everyone felt the need to shout into the camera, but Eva seemed to like it, and despite the annoying shrill, it was informative. There were a lot worse things she and I could have been watching on the internet.

I sat with Eva for thirty minutes whilst Jenny worked in the kitchen and Will slept, and maybe because I was with the little girl I thought of as a niece, or maybe because the YouTube programme was becoming repetitive and dull, I felt myself begin to drift off to sleep. I fought it, wanted to stay vigilant for the kids, but my body won out and I closed my eyes.

When I opened them again, Eva was gone, and in a panic I leapt from the sofa and half ran towards the kitchen.

‘Eva?’ I said.

When I stepped in, she was at the breakfast bar, eating her cereal, Will too. Jenny came and led me out of the kitchen, away from little ears.

‘Jenny, God, I’m so sorry. I didn’t mean to—’

‘It’s okay. Jess, go home.’

‘No, no I’m fine. I just closed my eyes for a moment.’

‘Honestly, it’s okay. I’m working from home now and the kids want a quiet day anyway. Go home, get some rest. I know you probably didn’t sleep last night, and to be honest, I was expecting you to call in sick.’

‘No, Jenny, I don’t want to be off from work, I don’t, I want to be here.’

‘We want you here too. And Samual and I have been so amazed that, with everything you’ve had going on, you’ve still been here for our children and able to do your job. You’re amazing, but you’re also exhausted.’

‘I didn’t mean to fall asleep.’

‘I know. Jess, this isn’t punishment, I promise you. And if you’re worried about the money, you’ll still be—’

‘I’m not.’

‘Okay.’

‘I just, this year has been a lot, and I feel like I’ve lost loads.’

‘You have.’

‘I can’t lose them, too, or you.’

‘Oh, Jess,’ Jenny said, pulling me into a long embrace. ‘You’re part of this family. You won’t lose us, we love you. And because we love you, we want to look after you. Go home. Catch up on some rest, and then you and I, we can take the kids to the seaside again.’

‘Okay,’ I said, a tear escaping. ‘Say bye to the kids, I don’t want them to see me upset.’

‘I will.’

Grabbing my bag, I walked towards the front door, and left, and as I drove home, I couldn’t stop myself from crying.

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Chapter Twenty-One

SOPHIE SALAM

With Jess gone, Sophie returned her focus to her daughter, and for a blissful hour the pair sat and watched cartoons, drank their drinks and looked like any other mother and daughter having some time alone. Until it was time to go. Despite working until almost 7am, Sophie was due on shift soon, and she knew at some point they would know for sure that the mark on the victim's chest was surgically added either just prior, or just after the man was killed, confirming that Robert Worthing was the fifth victim of The Caretaker.

'Right, darling, ready?'

'Can we stay, Mummy?'

'I wish, darling. I have to go to work.'

'Is Nana looking after me?'

'Of course.'

'I don't want you to go to work.'

'I know, baby, I don't want to go to work either.'

'Then why are you always there?'

Sophie smiled. 'Not always.'

'Yes, always, all the time.'

Her smile faded. Lottie was right, she was at work more than she was at home, but how do you explain to a seven-year-old the complexities of

needing to earn a living, pay bills, and find a serial killer before he could kill again.

‘I tell you what: next week, Mummy can get a few days off, maybe, and we could go away?’

‘Go away where?’

‘Maybe we can go to the seaside for a bit. How does that sound?’

‘The seaside?’

‘Uh-huh, just you and me. There are loads of interesting birds by the seaside.’

‘Really?’

‘Yep.’

Lottie leant over and hugged Sophie. The sudden outburst of affection was uncommon from Lottie, and for a full minute Sophie didn’t say anything or do anything other than stroke her daughter’s hair.

‘Right, come on,’ she said when Lottie pulled from her embrace, and the pair grabbed their things and walked to the car.

As Sophie drove home, Lottie asked a thousand questions about the seaside: what would they do, would there be whales and sharks, what would happen if a shark jumped from the sea and stole their chips? And Sophie answered each question, enjoying the excitement in her daughter’s voice. She made a note to herself to try to book a hotel somewhere coastal when she was on shift.

As she pulled up on her drive, Daya was there waiting for them both on the doorstep.

‘Hey, my girls,’ she said, giving Lottie a big cuddle, before she could run into the house.

‘Hey, Ma,’ Sophie said.

‘You two left before I woke.’

‘Wanted to grab a little time with her. Work is busy at the moment.’

‘I know you’ll roll your eyes, but you’re burning the candle—’

‘I know.’

Walking into the house, the women headed for the kitchen, Sophie looking into the living room to see Lottie sat on the floor, playing with her toys, a farmyard set with cows and sheep, fences and a barn. She chatted to herself, as she built a little farm, everything in lines, organised, tidy.

‘Is it true?’ Daya asked when both were out of earshot of Lottie.

‘What?’

‘You know, him, is he back?’

‘Ma, you know I can’t talk about work.’

‘I know. But is he?’

Sophie hesitated, then nodded.

‘Shit.’

‘Yep. We have to have it confirmed.’

‘But the video.’

‘Could be a fake. We won’t know for sure just yet.’

‘Darling, I know I don’t have to say anything, but, please, be careful, okay?’

‘Always.’

Sophie looked at her watch, and then back to her mum.

‘Guessing you haven’t got time for a cuppa?’

‘Sorry. It’s going to be crazy today.’

‘That’s okay. If you think you’ll be late, let me know. Lottie and I can pop back to mine and I can grab some things.’

‘Might be a good idea. Just in case.’

Daya nodded and then turned to flick on the kettle, and Sophie felt her guilt resurface: asking so much of her mum was bad. But then, what choice did she have? Being a single parent was tough, compromises had to be made.

Grabbing her work bag and jacket, despite the heat of the day, she kissed her mum on the cheek. ‘I’ll keep you posted.’

‘Thanks, love.’

Sophie made her way into the living room, and getting on the floor with her daughter, she played with her. Lottie told her about the function of the farm, the order, and Sophie marvelled at her logical thinking. Her autism was complex at times, and also beautiful.

Leaving her daughter to play, Sophie stood, kissed her on the top of her head and made her way to the front door. As she approached, she saw that hanging from the letterbox was a brown envelope. Pulling it out, she saw her name was handwritten, no address, no stamp. Someone had hand-delivered this.

Curious, she opened it, and pulled out a letter. It was short, polite, but scared her half to death.

Sophie.

You are a hard woman to pin down, I'm struggling to not be offended.

It seems, things are going well for you, head of a taskforce now. A hotshot in the police.

If only they all knew the truth about who you really are.

See you soon SS

K

Opening the front door, Sophie ran outside to see who had delivered the note. But the street was quiet.

‘Mum? Did you see this letter?’ she asked, and her mum popped her head from the kitchen.

‘A letter? I didn’t know it was a letter. Someone posted it about half an hour ago, assumed it was junk mail. Who’s it from?’

‘Doesn’t matter, half an hour ago?’

‘Yeah, about then. You okay?’

‘Fine, all is fine,’ Sophie said, relieved that when it was posted, whoever posted it, she and Lottie had been out. But she didn’t want her daughter in the house. She didn’t want Karl to find out about her, and hoped to God, whoever had been at her front door, didn’t look inside and see toys.

‘Mum, how about instead of going home to get things, take some things of Lottie’s, and stay at yours? I can then come to you later?’

‘That would work.’

‘Saves you being at mine two nights on the trot.’

‘Oh, that doesn’t bother me.’

‘I know, but still.’

‘Okay, if you’re sure.’

‘Be a nice change for Lottie too.’

Sophie wanted to say more, tell her that she needed to leave, that somehow Karl knew where she lived, that her mum needed to be vigilant, just in case, as her ex, Karl Kendrick, the man she put in prison, and the father of her child, had someone on the outside who could deliver a message to her. But she knew she couldn’t. Her secrets had to remain exactly that, secret. Or she would lose everything.

Tucking the letter in her pocket, Sophie said a final goodbye, and closed the door. She knew Karl was just fucking with her. But, it was obvious he wanted her attention, and that left her no choice. Despite never wanting to speak to him again, if she didn’t, he would keep coming for her. He could never know about Lottie.

Sophie knew she had no choice, she was going to have to call the father of her daughter.

Chapter Twenty-Two

JESS

Even though I felt shame at being sent home from work, I slept for four hours, and waking mid-afternoon, it took me another two to feel like I could leave my flat. Jenny was right, I needed it, and catching up a little lifted a fog I wasn't aware lingered. Despite The Caretaker being back, and what that would mean, I was excited to see my friends.

My life was now completely different, the fear I felt, the judgement I faced, gone, taken to wherever Lewis ended up after he died. I still struggled with indecision. Kelly had arranged for the four of us to meet in a bar in town, just for a quiet drink or two, maybe a bite to eat if it took our fancy, and I didn't know what to wear. Sometimes, I was strong, independent, sometimes I knew my mind, and other times, I could hear Lewis calling me fat, ugly, a whore if I had too much flesh on display. Kelly had done wonders in helping me see that dressing confidently was important, and when she was by my side, I felt fearless in my outfit choice. Alone, I wanted to cover up, hide, like I had been trained to by a man who was supposed to love me.

Deciding on black jeans, despite the heat of the day enduring into the evening, and a white blouse, I appraised myself once more in the mirror, reminding me of who I now was, then, before I could change my mind, I left and headed into town.

I was the last to arrive. Madison, Hannah and Kelly were there, half a drink down, and joining them I picked up the white wine Kelly had ordered for me.

‘You look nice,’ Hannah said, kissing me on the cheek.

‘Thanks, love, so do you.’

‘All okay today?’ Kelly asked, as I took my seat with my friends.

‘All good,’ I said. ‘What have I missed?’

‘Just us talking about how busy it’s been on socials.’

‘Oh, I’ve not looked’ I said.

‘Really?’ Hannah said. ‘I think I’ve had about a hundred friend requests today.’

‘This is why I’ve not looked,’ I said, taking a mouthful of wine. The crisp, cold liquid making me sigh with appreciation. ‘God, I needed this.’ I looked at Hannah, who smiled, as did Kelly, and Madison tried as well, but failed.

‘Madison?’

‘I’m fine, long week. I’m just tired.’

‘Sounds like you need a wine more than me.’

‘Yep,’ she said, this time managing a small smile, one laced with sadness too.

As we settled into our drinks, ordering our second quickly, I felt the tension in my shoulders loosen, and judging from the conversation easing into a relaxed catch-up, I think everyone felt the same. We didn’t talk about The Caretaker, or the support group. We didn’t discuss the dreams or worries of carrying such a burden of truth. We were like other women on a night out. Work and plans and life admin. Hannah had started running and was planning to take part in a half-marathon, which we all agreed to be there for, cheering her on. Madison talked of her little boy, and when she did, it was like she was the old version of herself once more. There was a

light in her eyes again, one that we all noticed, and missed. And then Kelly dropped a bombshell.

‘So, you know at the group, I mentioned I went on a date and I cancelled seeing him again.’

‘Yes?’ Hannah asked.

‘Well, I messaged him, I decided to try again.’

‘Did you? Kel, that’s amazing,’ I said, leaning in and giving her a hug.

‘Details please!’ Hannah added, leaning in also. ‘How did it go?’

‘Pretty well, I think,’ she said with a knowing smile.

‘How so?’

‘Well, he woke up in my bed.’

‘Oh my God, Kelly, are you telling me you got laid?’ Hannah said, so loud and excited that, despite the pub being busy and noisy, people turned and looked. She instantly knew she had spoken too loudly, and apologised.

Kelly blushed so much she almost became the colour of her hair. ‘Bloody hell, Hannah, wanna speak up, not sure they heard you in Spain!’

‘Sorry.’

‘And yes, if you must know, I got laid.’

‘Oh God. What was it like?’ Hannah continued.

‘I’ve only ever slept with two men before. One was a lad called Kenny when I was sixteen.’

‘Kenny?’ I said.

‘Yes, Kenny. He was a bit older than me.’

‘Name like Kenny, I suspect he was a lot older.’

‘Yeah, looking back, it might have been a bit weird. After Kenny, it was Duncan. And now Paul.’

‘So, details...’ Hannah said again.

‘My God, Hannah, are you okay?’ I asked.

‘Shush, Jess, I need to live vicariously.’

I laughed, and wondered, did I want to live vicariously too? I was curious, of course, but imagining being with another man? I wasn't there.

'A lady doesn't kiss and tell,' Kelly said, teasing us.

'Since when have you been a lady?' Hannah joked, making us laugh again.

'Oi,' Kelly protested, then shrugged. 'Fair enough, you've got a point. It was good, really good. I kinda thought I was dead down there, you know?'

'Yep, God, yes I know,' Hannah said.

'Me too,' I agreed. Madison nodded as well.

'Let's just say, there's life in me yet.'

'Were you nervous?'

'Shitting myself, it's been so long. I was afraid I'd forgotten how to do it.'

'I think I have,' I said.

'Yep,' Hannah agreed.

'Well, trust me, it's like riding a bike,' Kelly said.

'What I would give for a ride,' Hannah said, and we all laughed.

'Maybe you need Tinder,' I offered.

'God no,' she countered. 'Could think of nothing worse.'

'How did you meet him?' I asked.

'Tinder,' Kelly said, before she and then I burst out laughing.

It was Hannah's turn to go scarlet. 'Oh shit, Kelly, I'm sorry, I sound so judgy.'

'Oh shush. It's fine. It's a weird place, online dating.'

'What was it like being naked in front of another man? I don't think I could do it,' I said.

'Me neither,' Hannah said, and I took her hand. We all bore scars from what our exes had done to us, Hannah's were physically the deepest.

'I asked him to keep the light off. Not ready for that yet,' Kelly said.

‘And to use your metaphor of riding a bike,’ I said, moving us along before any of us could dwell on the damage done in our pasts. ‘You going to be riding it again any time soon?’

‘I think so.’

‘When? I wanna know when,’ Hannah said and we all laughed again.

‘God, Hannah, you really need to get laid,’ I said, and she nodded.

I raised my glass, and my friends joined me, and loudly, to embarrass her more, I said, ‘To Kelly getting laid.’

‘Kelly getting laid,’ Hannah and Madison echoed, and then, from behind, a group of lads, mid-twenties, applauded and I laughed so hard I nearly spat my wine.

As the young men returned to their evening, Kelly, once again bright red, smiled at us. ‘You arseholes! God, I need another drink now.’

‘I’ll get these,’ Hannah said.

As Hannah went to the bar, brushing past the lads who smiled at her, I thought about the distance we had all travelled. Hannah was ordering drinks, Kelly had met someone new, and despite The Caretaker being back, we were all able to be here. There was hope for both me and Madison yet.

As Hannah arrived with the drinks, assisted by one of the lads, who carried two of the drinks before returning to his evening, wanting nothing more than to be kind, we talked a little about the group on Friday, and whether Esme would return. I wasn’t sure, but I hoped, and then, inevitably, we moved on to current affairs.

‘So, Cambridge, do we wanna talk about it?’ Kelly asked.

‘Is there much to talk about?’ Hannah said. ‘It’s weird, being on the outside of this now.’

‘Yeah, I don’t wanna know, but then, I do at the same time,’ I added.

‘I think it’s great we don’t,’ Kelly said. ‘We’ve done our bit, we’ve earned the right to move on.’

‘Can we?’ Madison said quietly.

Kelly opened her mouth to say something, but faltered, and I stepped in.

‘Yes, with time and kindness to ourselves, we can all move on, find happiness again. Look how far we’ve come.’

Madison nodded, but I wasn’t sure she believed me.

‘Kel, you said you had to talk about something when we arranged this meet up,’ Hannah said, rescuing the conversation. ‘Was it about your sexual deviance?’

‘Hardly a deviant. More like dipping my toe. But no, we’ve been asked to another event.’

‘When?’

‘In about a week. The fifth of July.’

‘Where is it?’

‘Up near Manchester, it’s another one from Kimberley’s charity.’

‘Should we go? With him being back?’

‘Hide in plain sight, remember. I think we should, but I didn’t agree. As we are a team, we decide together.’

‘I’m fine with it,’ I said. Madison nodded, and Hannah agreed too.

‘Okay, I’ll go back and confirm details.’

‘Will it be like that retreat we went to?’ Hannah asked, and I wondered the same. That night in March the four of us were invited to an event by Kimberley, and that night the truth of what we were came out.

‘No, this is just a talk, from survivors to survivors. Not about him.’

‘Everyone asks about him, though,’ Madison said.

‘And we say the same as we have always said, we have no idea who he is, or why he chose us.’

‘It’s hard at times,’ Madison said quietly, and we didn’t reply. She was right, it was hard, so hard. Every day I felt tired for what happened, and I wasn’t even one to have stepped up, I hadn’t killed. Madison had, Hannah, too, Kelly twice.

‘We just stay the course, look after each other. In time, all will be well,’ Kelly said, and we all agreed, and picked up our drinks. I didn’t want to talk about The Caretaker anymore, none of us did, and our conversation moved back to sex, Kelly’s recent escapades and the rest of our lack of them. I hadn’t thought about it in so long, I wasn’t sure I ever would again. The idea of being with another man, it made me feel sick. But still, I laughed and joked about wanting it until a woman approached the table. Younger than us, with dyed blue hair and arms covered in a patchwork of tattoos.

‘Fuck, it’s you,’ she said.

‘Sorry?’ Kelly replied.

‘It’s you, “the saved” shit. Everyone knows you know The Caretaker.’

‘I’m sorry to disappoint, but we really don’t, and we don’t like talking about it, so could you...’

‘Why don’t you like talking about it? He’s a hero, you’re heroes. Burn the patriarchy, that’s what I say, bury them all.’

‘I don’t think that’s what he’s trying to do,’ Kelly countered.

‘No? He kills men, bad men, but aren’t they all bad? And now he is back, you must be so excited? Hey, shit, can I get a selfie with you?’

Before we could protest, she pulled out her phone, and took a picture, the flash blinding us. Without thanking us, or saying goodbye, she wandered back into the crowd, to a group of friends who all looked our way.

‘I think I want to go home,’ Madison said, and none of us argued. We got our things, and before more could come and ask us questions or try to take more photos, we left.

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Chapter Twenty-Three

THE CARETAKER

The little blue book had arrived after dark, hand-delivered by a woman he didn't know nor had ever met. The Caretaker was simply handed it, and once it was in his grasp, the woman, middle-aged and carrying the weight of abuse in her eyes that only those who had suffered could see, smiled and spoke the only two words they would ever exchange.

‘Good luck.’

She then turned, left, and The Caretaker stood, awestruck by the choreography of what they were doing.

Closing the door, he walked into his living room, sat down, and for a full minute he stared at the book, knowing its contents were the manifesto, along with plans of how The Caretaker operates, guidance for him, and the thoughts, notes and reflections of the original members, those he first saved. It felt hallowed somehow.

After the success of Cambridge a few nights before, the pressure felt more extreme. What he was planning to do, the kill he would complete in a week's time, played heavily on his mind. But he wouldn't back down, he couldn't. Too many people were involved, too much at stake. The work that began with the original members was now for him to continue, their legacy would rage on until the laws were changed.

He was just one small cog in a much, much bigger plan, and knowing it settled his mind. He would complete the task alone, but within the book there was all the support he would need. He would transfer his observations, write down his method, and reflect after the job was done. Then, someone would come, take the book, and deliver it to the next Caretaker, at a place and time he didn't know, and the teaching, reflections and mission would continue.

He would then rest, knowing a woman had been saved, knowing it would be his turn to be saved in time.

Opening the book, he read the first pages, which the founding members had transcribed from memory of their time as The Caretaker. It spoke of the fitness needed, the philosophy of becoming a man, and the reasons why.

A woman cannot be The Caretaker, because then people will talk of the woman, try to unpack her mental state, she would be sexualised by some, torn apart by others for being unhinged. A woman would be the story, and the message, the reasoning for it, would be lost. Only a man can communicate the message and reason that The Caretaker needs to exist. As sad as it is to admit this.

It was sad, but also, not wrong. The reason was much more important than the one committing the crime. And that was why Justine Michell, a twenty-eight-year-old accountant, would become the man so many men feared. Justine would be protected by being male.

The Caretaker skipped forward in the blue book until he found an extract that had been spoken of often in the setting up of the network.

He hoped that it was true. His plan hinged on it.

People were, by default, just like every other animal on this earth, in that they were creatures of habits. In the animal kingdom, it was much easier to identify habits, as species tended to act like the masses. Rising, eating, mating, building in the same patterns that particular species had for millennia, all dependant on the trajectory of their evolution. Humans were

different, in that no two humans behaved the same on a microcosmic level. Sure, they all rose and ate and fucked, they all cried for their mums when young and wished they had spent more time seeing the world and taking more risks when they were close to dying. But day to day varied so much, it was like every human was in fact their own species. Following their own evolutionary path. But, if you knew the movements of someone, seldom did they deviate, once you understood someone's habits, they rarely let you down...

Knowing he would read the rest of the blue book from cover to cover, its thoughts, plans, reflections and philosophies, later when he couldn't sleep, The Caretaker skipped to the next empty page, and, from his own research, he added everything he knew about his target, the man he was, and his routines. The man who would become infamous, the sixth brutal killing by The Caretaker, was thirty-six-year-old Freddie Markwell. A self-employed plasterer, separated for two years from his wife, Michala, but still controlling her finances through delaying the sale of the house and refusing to pay support for his two children. It was in the court system, lost in the backlog.

The Caretaker didn't know a lot, but he did know that Michala had tried to move on with a kind man named Craig, but Freddie sabotaged their relationship. He buried her in his control.

And, as The Caretaker said after Cambridge, these men would in turn be buried.

Freddie's fate was sealed.

After work on a Monday, he played football with some friends. He would then walk home along fields that lined the football pitches. The path was poorly lit, tarmacked, but in the evenings, seldom used. The path only linked the football pitch to the edge of town. Once it would have been a walkers' route connecting an old factory that had long shut down. Now it was overgrown, the pavement was cracked and only one of the nine

lampposts worked. It was a path of nothing, leading to nowhere. The Caretaker had walked it several times, always on a Monday, before, during and after the football. The Caretaker had passed Markwell twice, on that path, avoiding eye contact. He was alone both times. If the reflections were right, he would be there a week from today. Like a creature of habit. Like he had been there before.

If he was this final time, it would be undeniable that the plan would work.

Writing his notes, and setting aside the blue book, The Caretaker sat back and took a deep breath. Seeing Markwell for a final time before he and The Caretaker met wasn't the end of his plan. There was a lot more preparation to do before The Caretaker claimed his sixth.

Markwell was burying his soon-to-be ex-wife with his control.

In seven short days, he would know exactly what that felt like.

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Chapter Twenty-Four

JESS

‘I know this isn’t our usual meeting place,’ Becky began. ‘But it seems that, with recent events being as they are, our privacy has been slightly compromised.’

‘It’s fine, we understand,’ Kelly said.

‘I promise, when it’s all died down, we will go back to our usual space. It’s important to be consistent and I’m sorry that we cannot be at the moment. I had hoped, when I set up for the men’s group, we’d be left alone, but unfortunately there was some press waiting to talk to us.’

‘Honestly, Becky, it’s fine, we are all together still. Thank you for finding this room on such short notice,’ Hannah said.

Becky nodded.

‘How is the men’s group?’ I asked.

‘No one came,’ Becky said, and I saw both Kelly and Hannah shift ever so slightly in their seats – guilt. I felt it too. Those men needed support, and although there were fewer men who were victims of domestic violence, there were still some. They were just like us: they needed The Caretaker, but him resurfacing also brought suspicion to their doors.

Out of the corner of my eye, I saw Esme sat looking bewildered. I was, too, when I first learnt Becky helped men, and I was about to explain how there was a group before ours, and how once a month we crossed paths to

try to build healthier relationships with the opposite sex, when the door to the generic rent-an-office building that was our temporary home opened and Madison stepped in.

‘Sorry I’m late,’ she said, her eyes downcast.

‘Nothing to be sorry for,’ Becky said, getting up to greet her. ‘Glad you’re here.’

‘I went to the community centre, but there was press everywhere.’

‘Did they say anything to you?’ Kelly asked, as Madison came and took a seat beside her.

‘No, they didn’t see me.’

‘Sorry. We messaged,’ Hannah said.

‘I just saw,’ Madison said.

‘You good?’ Kelly asked giving her hand a squeeze. Madison looked up and saw us all, giving a smile. She then saw Esme was back, on the edge of the semicircle of chairs. The room was too small to have a full circle, as we usually did.

‘Nice to see you again,’ Madison said.

‘You too,’ Esme replied.

‘This week, we have a visitor coming to see us. Someone I know some of you will be happy to see. But during the visit, and after, nothing is off limits today, we can talk freely, and as always, we will listen and support. The change in location isn’t ideal, and recent events have impacted most of us, I’m sure.’

There were nods from around the room, all four of us who had become The Caretaker, as well as Baheela and Vija. Only Esme didn’t nod, and we needed to keep it that way.

‘Who is the visitor?’ Hannah asked.

‘You’ll see,’ Becky said, with a smile. ‘They’ll be here soon. Until then, let’s address the elephant in the room. As we all know The Caretaker being

back in Cambridge is a lot to process. I want us to touch upon this, if people want to.'

There was silence for a full minute, with all of us looking away from Becky and into nothing.

'I have bad dreams,' Madison said, and I shot a look at Kelly, worried she would say something about the reason why she, Kelly and Hannah had bad dreams.

'I dream about Jake, how he must have felt when he...The Caretaker comes often when I sleep.'

She trailed off, and then looked at Kelly. The woman who killed Jake. I didn't see anger, just a longing perhaps. Longing for things to have been different. It only lasted a moment, and then it faded, replaced with a gentle nod, acceptance.

Grief was a funny thing: we couldn't stop ourselves from grieving, even when the person didn't deserve it.

Madison's dreams wouldn't only be about grief, they would be about the rage she experienced, the things she did when it was her turn to be The Caretaker.

'What you lived through, both when Jake was with you and now after, is so much to deal with. Dreaming is your subconscious way of processing it all. They might be really awful dreams, but they will inevitably help, I think,' Becky said. 'But Madison, I know I can speak for everyone here when I tell you you're doing such a great job.'

'Am I?'

'Don't even doubt it for a second.'

'I dream too. About my ex and The Caretaker,' Kelly said.

'And me,' Hannah agreed. Vija nodded. So did Baheela, and Madison sighed.

'My dreams, Mads,' Baheela said, her rasping voice a permanent reminder of the acid attack she suffered. 'They would make the *Saw* films

look like Disney. I used to fight them, but not anymore, I accept they are a part of me. I dream, but then I wake and I live. The dreams remind me of how far I've come. How strong I am.'

'Thank you,' Madison said. 'I wish I had your strength, what you've been through, compared to me, I—'

'We don't compete,' Baheela interrupted. 'We don't compare. Yours was no easier than mine, just different. And you are as tough as me, we all are.'

We all nodded, smiled and Hannah reached over, giving Madison's hand a squeeze.

'You okay?'

'Yeah, just didn't sleep much. I'm fine. Let's move on.'

'Can I ask a question?' Esme said.

Smiling, Becky replied, 'Of course.'

'Is it, I mean, does anyone else sometimes wish, no not wish, miss, does anyone miss their ex, even though they know they shouldn't?'

'I think so. I know I do occasionally. I'm guessing you have?' Becky asked.

'Only at night, when it's dark and quiet. He wasn't all bad, he had a good side.'

'They all do,' Kelly said, 'and yeah, I miss my ex sometimes too.'

'So I'm not failing because I sometimes want him back?'

'No,' Becky said. 'It's great you've opened up on this, brave too. But no, anything you feel is completely valid. But feelings and actions are different. Be mindful of that.'

'I don't wanna go back. It took me so long to get out, and although I'm thirty-two and back living with my mum in her spare room which is really the laundry dumping space, I know I'm in a better place.'

'Then miss as much as you want, and stay strong,' Becky said.

'I know I'm new here. And I don't have any connection to what happened earlier this year to a lot of you. But, as much as The Caretaker is

bad, and as much as I can see he haunts you, and I'm so sorry for that, I found you, Jess, because of him. It probably doesn't help you knowing, but it's saved me.'

'That's really kind,' I said.

'It's not fair you carry it all, but it has made such a difference, not just to me, to others too.'

'Thank you, Esme. Needed to hear that,' Madison said, a small tear escaping.

From the closed door, there were three gentle knocks. We all looked to the door, and then to Becky, who smiled. 'Our guest is here.'

'Who?' Hannah asked.

'You'll see,' Becky said.

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Chapter Twenty-Five

Getting up and walking to the door, Becky paused, and when she opened it, everyone but a very confused Esme jumped up in delight.

‘Hello, all,’ Geoff said, coming into the room. He made only a handful of steps before Hannah grabbed him and pulled him in for a massive hug.

‘Geoff, I am so happy to see you,’ she said, or at least that’s what I thought she said, her words muffled under long happy sobs.

‘I’m glad to see you too,’ he said, his Scottish accent soft and warm and familiar.

As Kelly, Madison, Vija, Baheela and Becky joined Geoff for hugs and smiles, I turned to Esme. ‘Geoff used to look after us at the community centre, before...’

‘He was arrested. They thought he was The Caretaker.’ Esme finished.

‘Yep. He left England, went home to his daughters. He’s a good ’un, as he would say. Come on. I’ll introduce you.’

Taking Esme by the hand, I led her towards Geoff, who was grinning ear to ear. Kelly’s lipstick sat proudly on his cheek.

‘Hey, you,’ I said.

‘Hey, Jess, can an old man get a hug?’

‘Always.’

I hugged Geoff long and hard and, when we parted, I introduced Esme to him. He smiled, shook her hand and told her it was a pleasure.

After the excitement calmed, Geoff, being Geoff, offered to make everyone a hot drink. We tried to insist that we should be making him a drink, as he was our guest, but he wanted to, and there was something familiar in him doing so, something safe. He knew what we all drank, aside from our newest member, and when she told him, he nodded, and left to find the kitchen. I asked to tag along, leaving the group to continue to discuss feelings of longing for what could have been.

Finding the kitchen, I filled and flicked on the kettle, and Geoff gathered enough mugs for us all. As we filled them with coffee, or tea, adding sugar when needed, we chatted.

‘No Steph? Rachel?’

‘No, after what happened, some couldn’t come back.’

‘I understand that.’

‘Geoff, are you okay? We all felt so shitty you were arrested.’

‘Not your fault.’

‘I know but.’

‘Jess, honestly, it’s fine, I have loved being closer to my girls, closer to home. I’m back as I’m finalising the sale on my house here.’

‘Even still, I’m sorry you were hounded out of here.’

‘Me too. But, weirdly, there isn’t much talk of The Caretaker up in Scotland, so I’m not hounded anymore. How are you doing?’

‘I’m okay.’

‘And Hannah, Kelly, Madison, how are they?’

I paused for a moment, wondering why he would highlight only those of us in the serial killer support group. But then, he would, wouldn’t he? We were the only women who had been ‘saved’ by the serial killer.

‘I won’t lie, we are all struggling a bit, but we are looking after each other.’

‘That’s all you can do.’ He picked up the boiled kettle to pour into the mugs. ‘So, who was first? I can’t imagine how hard that was.’

‘First?’

Geoff put down the kettle, began to add the milk. ‘I’m guessing it was Kelly, she seems to be most proactive. Most ready.’

‘Ready?’ I asked, feeling my heart rate increase. I tried to keep it from showing, but the tension was in my voice.

‘I don’t think Kelly was the one who first beat Hannah’s ex, maybe she was. But I think she was the first to be him.’

‘Geoff, I don’t know what...’ I trailed off, suddenly too tired to lie. Geoff was Geoff, a good man, a kind man who really wanted to look out for us.

‘It’s okay, Jess. I think I always knew.’

‘How?’

‘I’ve known you the least amount of time, but with Hannah, Kelly, Madison, I’ve known these women for quite a while now. I’ve seen them at their worst, most afraid, I’ve seen them at their smallest.’

‘Smallest?’

‘Like the world was about to tread on them at any moment.’

I didn’t speak, I didn’t want to confirm what he believed to be true. I couldn’t. I promised those women, myself, it would be our secret always.

‘Then, I saw all of them, and you, suddenly taller,’ he continued. ‘The Caretaker took credit shortly after, and I think, in the back of my mind, even when I was being arrested, I knew who The Caretaker really was. At first, I thought it was just one, Kelly, but then Duncan was killed when she was away and I knew you were doing it for each other. Clever. Really clever.’

‘Geoff, I—’

‘You don’t have to say anything, love. But if I’m wrong, tell me now.’

I didn’t reply, and he nodded. ‘Okay. Well, I’m here for a while, sorting things in my house, a few weeks, maybe a month. Need anything, you know

where I am,' he said, before finishing making the hot drinks.

'Geoff, I'm sorry they arrested you, I'm sorry you had to leave.'

'It was the right time to go home, rebuild my relationship with my girls. But don't think for a second I left because of a little pressure.'

'Then why did you?'

'For my girls. Also, to make sure I didn't slip up for you.'

'Slip up?'

'The police were watching me, and I knew the truth. I didn't want to compromise what you were doing, and why.'

'Really?'

'I've always wanted to look out for you ladies, reasoned the best way would be to go.'

'We thought you'd hate us.'

'Not for a second.'

I stepped in and gave Geoff a hug. 'Thank you.'

'Anytime, kid. Now come on, people will wonder what's happened to us.'

Releasing him from my embrace, we loaded two trays with the drinks, and made our way back. Joining the others, each of us holding a drink, we continued to chat, and for the first time ever, Geoff stayed, sat with us, talked and laughed, and listened. And if you didn't know he knew the truth, you wouldn't ever assume.

The support group had become a network, and now we had gained our first male ally.

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Chapter Twenty-Six

SOPHIE SALAM

Even though she knew the answer to whether or not the man who had been killed was in fact the victim of the real Caretaker and not a copycat, Sophie couldn't stop herself from pacing the long, dark corridor in the belly of the police station, that only led from the upper floors to the mortuary where Clarke worked. She could have been in there, waiting, watching him work, but it was colder in there. And she didn't have it in her to be standing next to a burnt victim. She was tired, having seen more death than she cared for recently. So she kept walking, up and down, waiting. She paced, partly because of what was happening with The Caretaker, but mostly, it was the letter that hung limply in her letterbox. Karl was trying to find a way back into her life, and she didn't know why.

She could have spiralled, wondering what was going on in his mind, and whether she had done enough to hide Lottie, or make him believe someone else was the father, but, instead she forced her mind to focus on the reason she was continuing to pace in the most depressing place in the whole of the force. Only thirty or so feet away from her, Clarke was ensuring undeniable proof that this latest crime was connected to the four murders months before.

Really, it was a forgone conclusion. Clarke's work a mere formality. The apparent cross on the victim's chest was the only thing that needed

confirming. That knowledge was never made public, the calling card something only a handful of people knew about. It appeared at the scene it was there, but there were variables, and with burning on the chest round the mark, it needed investigating. It could be an old mark, a scar from another moment. A coincidence. Even though Sophie didn't believe in such things. The Caretaker had already taken credit, the video posted. She had watched it over and over again, looking for anything that told her where it was filmed or who the person behind the face mask really was. She looked for signs that Jess was him, or Kelly, or one of the others. But he, the man in the video, was tall, calculated by the tech team to be almost six foot. None of the support group was taller than her, and she was five foot seven.

Someone other than one of the four women she thought was The Caretaker posed as The Caretaker.

She wondered if she'd been wrong this whole time.

It made no sense, but nothing about the past few months did. Jess and the others were involved, but also clearly not. Alibis were tight, bullet-proof, and now, with this new death, the modus operandi was changing. The victim, Robert Worthing, wasn't connected at all to her suspects. As far as her digging told her, none of the four woman knew Worthing or his partner. None had connections to Cambridge.

None of it added up anymore.

'Soph?' Clarke said, snapping Sophie away from her thoughts. She looked at him, smiled, and he looked back in concern. 'You all right?'

'Fine.'

'Your finger.'

Sophie looked at her hand: she had been biting the nail to the point a thin line of crimson had sprung.

'Ah, I caught my nail.'

'Right, anything on your mind?'

'Just this. Is it him?'

Clarke considered her for a moment, but didn't press. 'Yeah. It's him.'

'Okay.'

'But, Sophie, it is also not him.'

'What?'

'Come here, I'll show you.'

Leading Sophie, Clarke headed back to the mortuary, and Sophie assumed he was going to show her something on the body. But instead of leading her to the slab where the victim rested, he turned into a small office adjoining. And unlocked his desktop computer.

'Right,' he said, as he began to open folders on the screen. 'We both know that the cross is the calling card.'

'You found it on the first victim.'

'That Jake fella. Almost missed it. Take a look.'

Clarke opened a high-resolution image of Jake Murrey's chest, the small, neat cross carved into his sternum. He then opened another image beside it. 'Here is our second victim, Duncan Miller, and here are the other two, Martin Goodfellow and Lewis Nixon.'

Sophie looked at all four images, small crosses on four different men. 'Okay?'

'And here is our latest,' Clarke said, opening a fifth on the same screen. 'See how it's different?'

Sophie looked, comparing the five pictures in front of her like a spot-the-difference she used to enjoy on the back of a newspaper when she was young. But they were all different. One was slightly longer than the others. One slightly wider. One was clearly deeper.

'What am I meant to be looking at here, they are all different?'

'Look closer.'

'Clarke, all due respect, and I really mean that, but could we not? I'm knackered from being lead on this case.'

'Congrats again.'

‘And I want to get home to my girl at some point before she’s eighteen and moving out.’

‘Ah, fair, sorry, love. She good?’

‘Yeah, she’s good.’

‘Okay, so, without my bullshit this time, here it is. With these first four, even though they are different, the angle of the cut isn’t. You can see, from the entry point in all of them, the person applying the pressure on the scalpel is right-handed.’

‘Okay?’

‘This new one, is by someone using their left hand.’

‘What are you telling me?’

‘The Caretaker could be ambidextrous, but it’s unlikely. I don’t think it’s the same person.’

‘A copycat?’

‘Sophie, only a handful of people know about this calling card. Now, unless the copycat is one of us, there is more to this.’

Sophie nodded.

‘You don’t seem shocked by this?’ Clarke said.

‘No,’ Sophie replied. ‘No, I’m not. Clarke, keep this quiet for a bit. Okay?’

‘What? Why?’

‘Trust me on this one.’

‘What aren’t you telling me, Soph?’

‘I’m not surprised there is discrepancy. I think The Caretaker is not a person.’

‘What is he, then?’

‘Something much bigger.’

‘Sophie, are you saying that there is more than one serial killer?’

‘I think there is more than one person, pretending to be a serial killer.’

‘Fuck,’ Clarke said. ‘Who are these men?’

‘Women, Clarke.’

‘Huh?’

‘I don’t have proof yet, so I’m keeping it close to my chest, but I think those being The Caretaker are all women.’

‘Jess Pendle?’

‘And Kelly, Madison, Hannah too.’

‘So one of them did this?’

‘No, I think there are more involved now. The Caretaker isn’t just a killer now, he’s a movement.’

‘Fuck.’

‘Yeah. Fuck.’

‘If you’re right about this, then he is likely to kill again, isn’t he?’

‘I have no doubt.’

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Chapter Twenty-Seven

Leaving Clarke stunned but agreeing to keep her theory close to his chest, Sophie headed for home. The cut being both the serial killer's calling card and also clearly not the same serial killer leant into the theory that Jess, Kelly, Madison and Hannah weren't covering up for The Caretaker, but were more involved. Without proof, it was just a theory, bordering on conspiracy, and she would likely be labelled a nutjob. Without more evidence to support it, she knew the case would fold. She had already spoken to the four women under caution. If she went for them again, without it being solid, she would be kicked off the case. She needed more. Something that placed one of them, or all of them, at a scene. However, with this new victim, there was no link back to the four. Not one.

And she couldn't help but feel relieved. Jess was definitely involved, and part of her hoped she would never be able to prove it, and even thinking it felt wrong.

'What the fuck am I doing?'

By the time she got home, the sun was dipping; a myriad of colours, hopeful and beautiful and dangerously misleading, painted the sky. It spoke of wonder, something divine, peace. But the world didn't work like that. Not anymore. Sophie knew Lottie should be asleep, it was almost ten, but

she hoped she was up. She missed her little girl's voice, her questions, her smile.

Opening the front door, Sophie could tell that the idea of a sleepy little girl, full of calm and love for her mummy, was as misleading as the evening sky. For she heard her little girl's quiet whimpering coming from the living room.

Walking in, Sophie saw Lottie hiding behind the sofa, and her mum, sat on the rug, defeated and drained.

'What happened?' she asked.

Daya looked up, her eyes red from crying. 'She had a bad dream about an hour ago. She's been down here since. I'm trying to get her to settle. But she won't let me near her.'

'It's okay. Mum, you should have called.'

'I tried. Several times.'

'Really? Okay.' Sophie said, feeling a crushing guilt roll over her. 'What was the dream about?' she asked, pushing down the feeling of knowing she was failing.

'I don't know. She won't talk to me.'

Getting on the floor, Sophie crawled over to Lottie who was curled up in a little ball.

'Hey, darling, it's me, it's Mummy.'

Lottie didn't look up, but Sophie knew her girl had heard her, as the sobs eased ever so slightly.

'Can I come closer?' she asked, and when Lottie didn't reply, she crawled towards her little girl. As she reached her, she gently placed a hand on Lottie's.

'It's okay, baby, Mummy is here.'

She barely finished her sentence when, out of nowhere, Lottie lunged at her and started hitting her, crying in a way Sophie hadn't heard before. It was pained, afraid, it hurt more than any physical thing her daughter could

do. She moved too quickly, and Sophie wasn't prepared, so Lottie's first swing caught her in the mouth. Straight away, Sophie could taste blood.

'Oh my God!' Daya shouted, leaping up to help.

'It's okay, Mum,' Sophie said, keeping her calm. 'Hey, darling, stop,' she pleaded, trying to grab her daughter and hold her without hurting her. As she did, Lottie managed to get some of her hair and pull so hard some detached at the root. But Sophie didn't let go, she didn't cry out, she just kept repeating she was there and the bad dream couldn't hurt her. Eventually, Sophie managed to get both of Lottie's arms folded across her own chest and, holding her by the wrists, she positioned herself so her daughter was sat with her back pressed into her mother's body. It rendered her unable to kick or hurt herself or anyone else.

Beside her, Daya was crying, and Sophie gave her a small smile. 'It's okay, Mum. These things happen.'

'Okay,' she said, but Sophie could see, really, she didn't think it was okay at all. Her mum likely mirrored her: lost, afraid, failing.

From her arms, Lottie let out a long shaky breath and Sophie felt her settle deeper into her embrace.

'It's okay, darling, Mummy's got you. Mummy's got you,' she said over and over, shushing her little girl until, exhausted, she began to drift, sitting into her mother.

'I'm so sorry, Sophie, your mouth,' Daya said, her eyes brimming once more. 'It's bleeding.'

'It's slowing down already. It's fine.'

'I, I tried, I didn't know what to do.'

'Mum, it's not your fault. I'm sorry, I should have checked my phone. I should have been here.'

'She's been doing so well, calm, the bird song, she's been self-regulating. Did I do something wrong?'

‘No, not at all. I should have been here tonight at bedtime, and I wasn’t. It’s not your fault, or hers, it’s mine.’

‘Soph.’

‘Lottie has complex needs, she has to have regularity in order to feel safe, and I’m not doing my part.’

Daya opened her mouth to say something, but faltered, and both women fell into a post-conflict silence, punctuated only by the deep breathing of Lottie.

‘Can I do anything?’ Daya eventually said.

‘No, Mum, we are okay now. You look tired. Go home. Tomorrow, I’m going to take some time back. Spend the day with her.’

‘Are you sure?’

‘Yeah, it’s fine. I’m so sorry it’s so hard sometimes.’

‘It’s not, darling, it’s really not. You’re my girls. I don’t want anything other than this.’

‘Me neither.’ Sophie smiled, the cut on her lip pulling as she did.

‘You sure you’re okay?’

‘I’m good, Ma. I’ll stay here for a bit, and when she’s really asleep, I’ll take us both to bed.’

‘Okay. My phone is on, all night. I can come back, anytime.’

‘Thank you.’

Getting up, the effort showing Sophie that her mum was no longer a young woman, Daya got her things, and with one final smile, she quietly left the house. As she locked the door, Sophie looked up to the ceiling, and knowing she was alone with her little girl, she began to cry. Even though she had just told her mum to go home, Sophie needed someone, a friend. Someone who understood. Because, if she was honest, she was lonely.

It was ethically wrong, as she was a person of interest, but Sophie could only think of one person who she felt close enough to lean on, and before she could talk herself out of it, she pulled her phone from her pocket and

dialled Jess. She hoped Jess would pick up, she needed a friend. She needed someone to tell her everything was going to be okay. Even if that someone was a person she suspected of murder.

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Chapter Twenty-Eight

JESS

When my phone started vibrating, I was watching an old movie from the early 2000s about how three women were searching for something more from life. I found it by mistake, but it resonated. I was just at the point where two of the lead women kissed, and there was a longing in me, too, not for sex, for connection. I wanted to ignore the call, but when it began vibrating a second time, I reached towards the arm of the sofa, where my normal phone sat beside the burner phone. I checked the burner first, in case it was Kimberley warning me of the next, but there were no missed calls. I grabbed mine. I expected it was Kelly, or Hannah, maybe even Madison, although she didn't call much these days. But it wasn't any of my friends. It was Sophie.

'Shit.'

Sitting up, I sorted my hair, wanting to look presentable and, grabbing the remote, I paused, mid-kiss between Meryl Streep and another actress I couldn't name. I didn't know why, Sophie wouldn't be able to see me, but still I wanted to look nice. Then taking a deep breath, I answered.

'Hello?' I said, wanting to sound sleepy and like I didn't know who was calling.

'Jess, it's Sophie.'

'Sophie?'

‘Did I wake you?’

‘No, no,’ I said, ensuring I sounded like I had indeed been woken. ‘It’s fine.’ I didn’t want to ask what was up, why she was calling. It couldn’t be for official police business, so I waited for her to speak.

‘Lottie isn’t great,’ she eventually said, and the heartbreak in her voice told me this wasn’t about me or her or The Caretaker, this was about a little girl.

‘What’s happened?’ I said.

‘I’m away a lot, with work. She’s struggling with it. Bird song isn’t enough, she needs her mother and I’m failing her.’

‘Soph, you’re not failing her at all.’ I said, recognising that she was almost repeating word for word what she said in the coffee shop. A broken record of self-blame. Although the context wasn’t the same, I knew that record, I had something similar with Lewis.

‘She hit me tonight, she had a bad dream and I wasn’t there to comfort her and she hates me.’

‘You know that’s not true. At all.’

‘I feel like I’m failing her, and work. Like everything is going to come crashing down.’

‘Sophie, listen. I don’t have kids, so really I don’t understand how you are truly feeling, but working with Will and Eva, I do get how hard it is. Trust me, you’re doing a great job.’

‘Sorry, I shouldn’t have called.’

I hesitated. She was right, she shouldn’t have called, but then, I shouldn’t have answered. And I did.

Besides, hide in plain sight.

‘I’m going to a survivors’ thing tomorrow afternoon, but the morning I’m free. I’m going for a coffee at about ten, if you and Lottie want to join me.’

‘No, no, I shouldn’t.’

‘I know, but the offer is there. Lottie seems at ease there. I have a few ideas, too, I can share them. You said she hit you?’

‘Yeah, right in the mouth.’

‘Are you hurt?’

‘Only my heart,’ she said, and I felt a pang too.

‘Oh, Sophie. I promise you, you’re doing a great job. It’s not easy at the best of times.’

‘And at the worst, it feels impossible.’

‘As long as I stay Jess, and not Miss Pendle, meet me tomorrow, I’ll be there around ten.’

‘Goodnight, Jess,’ Sophie said, her voice small, tired, hurting.

‘Night, Soph.’

Hanging up the phone, I put it on my lap and stared at the ceiling.

‘What the fuck are you doing, Jess?’

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Chapter Twenty-Nine

THE CARETAKER

He had arrived.

A dead of night walk with only wind blowing through dry leaves on the trees for company. For a full mile they whispered to him, urging him on, or telling him to stop, he didn't know. But, their company, regardless of what they spoke, made him feel deeply isolated. Like he was the hunted, rather than the hunter.

But it needed to be that way. No one had seen him leave. No one would see him return, and on the patch of grass where he stood, ten yards back from the path he knew Freddie Markwell would walk down in just a few days' time, no one would see him prepare. Being isolated, unnerved, served him in equal measure.

He knew the location was perfect. He would conceal the night's toil, hide his preparation under a canopy of dead branches that had been cut off the trees that lined the path for safety and dumped near to where he stood. He would dig, hide the shallow grave, and then, in less than forty-eight hours' time, he would complete the final step in the plan he had laid out beat by beat in the blue book that was temporarily his before moving on to the next Caretaker in the next city.

Having one final check to make sure he was entirely alone, and satisfied he could work uninterrupted for the many hours it would take, The

Caretaker removed his rucksack, pulled out the telescopic shovel that was tucked inside, and then he got to work.

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Chapter Thirty

JESS

I didn't tell Kelly, Hannah or Madison that I was seeing Sophie. I didn't want to face their questions or their worry, I didn't want them to wonder if my resolve was slipping. They wouldn't understand me and Sophie were more than this cat-and-mouse we were caught up in. It was likely only because of Lottie, her need to be as good a mother as she could be and my need to help. I wondered, if Lottie hadn't been struggling that day when we first met unofficially, would Sophie and I have ever spoken beyond a professional capacity? If I said to Kelly or any of the others I was seeing her, even for Lottie's sake, I would risk losing their trust. Yes, detective Sophie Salam was lead investigator in The Caretaker case, but she was more than that to me. She was someone who needed a friend, and I didn't know why, because I had amazing friends, but I needed that too.

She knew I knew something about the case, but I knew she wouldn't ask anything. Today, I would firmly be Jess, and not Miss Pendle. This was about Lottie being okay, but even knowing that, I still couldn't quite quell the rising tide of nausea that wanted to wash over me. Was I being a friend, trying to help a struggling mum and a little girl? Or making a massive mistake?

As I ordered my black coffee from James, who greeted me with his usual bubble and pop, I realised it didn't matter either way. Last night,

Sophie was stressed, struggling, and needed someone. I got that, there had been a few times when it was late and I'd needed someone, where I'd been tempted to call her. I perhaps would have, if I had a child too. But, as it was a fresh day, I knew she wouldn't come. She'd message, apologising for calling me in the night.

Feeling myself settle, I thanked James, and took my coffee to a table by the large window that looked onto the car park. Despite it being before ten in the morning, the ground was shimmering with heat. Another miserably hot day was on the cards.

As time ticked by, I waited for someone who wouldn't come and by 10.15am I had stopped looking for either her or Lottie in the car park. My mind began to drift to work, which I felt disconnected from lately. I needed to make amends for being careless, but I needed to also honour what was asked by Jenny, and take a little break. I made a mental note to call her later, check in, see how the kids were, and after I made a small peace with not being at work, my mind unexpectedly shifted, and that night in Cromer months before came back to me. The cold winter air. The way DS Jones wobbled down the beach, drunk and oblivious. I thought about how as The Caretaker I had absolute power. I thought about the sound he made as he crashed to the ground, how the wet sand stuck to his confused and afraid face. I thought about the way I knew, if I wanted to, I could have killed him. The power in that moment, there had been nothing like it before, and nothing like it since.

As that night played, I was startled by a tap on the glass beside me. It snapped me from the cold North Sea to the hot tarmac of the coffee shop car park. And pressed to the glass was a tiny face beaming a wide and cheeky smile my way.

'Lottie! Hello, darling,' I said, waving, and pushing away my memory of that dark night. I watched her run into the coffee shop. She got close

enough to hug, and stopped abruptly. I got it: she liked me, but was still wary. Dropping to one knee, to her eye level, I smiled.

‘Hello. Wow, have you grown since I last saw you?’

‘Mummy says I’m getting bigger every day.’

I laughed. ‘I bet you are. How are you?’

‘Good.’

Looking behind Lottie, Sophie was coming into the coffee shop and, standing up, I gave her a tense and slightly awkward hug.

‘Sorry,’ I said when I stepped back. ‘Hi.’

‘Hi.’

The bruise and cut to her top lip were fresh and angry. I didn’t say anything, I wouldn’t, but it was obvious, last night was really rough for her. ‘Didn’t think you’d come.’

‘To be honest, nor did I.’

‘Well, it’s nice to see you. Grab a seat, I’ll get you and Lottie a drink.’

‘No, I can get ours.’

‘It’s okay, you got the last one. What do you want?’

‘Flat white, thank you.’

‘And you, lovely Lottie, would you like a hot chocolate?’

‘Yes.’

‘Please,’ Sophie said, ensuring Lottie had good manners.

‘Yes please.’

‘No problem.’

Rejoining the queue. I watched as Sophie sat down, put her arm around her daughter and pointed to something outside, which she then talked about. She was a police officer, a detective, but right now, she was just a mum, a friend.

Paying for the drinks, I made my way back to the table and sat opposite Sophie. She thanked me.

‘You really didn’t have to get us these.’

‘Honestly, it was my round, besides, I think you’ve had a rough time. Are you okay?’

‘Yeah, yeah.’ She looked from me to Lottie who had pulled out her iPad and was playing what looked like an app for maths games.

‘Sophie. It’s okay if you’re not okay.’

She looked at me for a long time, a sad smile forming on her lips. ‘I’m tired.’

I nodded. ‘There is a lot going on.’

‘Yeah, there is.’ And that was pretty much as far as either of us would go with talk of The Caretaker.

‘What happened?’ I asked, looking at her lip.

She saw me look, and then she turned to Lottie. ‘Darling, if you put your headphones on, you can hear the questions.’

‘Okay, Mummy.’

Sophie reached into her bag, which was hanging on the back of her chair, and removed a pair of over-ear, noise-cancelling headphones. She helped Lottie put them on, and when her girl was settled in doing her maths, she looked back at me just as I took a sip of my coffee.

‘You left-handed?’ she asked.

‘Nope,’ I said, confused at her question.

She nodded. Looked once more at Lottie, ensuring she couldn’t hear us, and then she took a deep breath.

‘Wanna tell me what happened?’ I asked.

‘She hasn’t hit me before. She’s pulled and pinched, but this was the first time she’s ever really hit me. I don’t know, I mean, is that normal?’

I nodded. ‘Jenny, my employer, is hit all the time by Will. He doesn’t mean it, he just struggles to regulate and then it all spills out. He doesn’t hit me, or his dad, or anyone else, only his mum. Know why?’

‘Why?’ she asked, her eyes brimming.

‘Because he feels safest with his mum. Lottie is the same, she only lashed out because she knows that you would never hurt her, or leave her.’

‘I guess so.’

‘I know so. Doesn’t make it any less upsetting, I get that, but it’s not personal.’

‘I just, I think I’m scared I’m failing her.’

‘Soph, as hard as this is to hear, you will fail her. Because everyone fails everyone. That’s just how life is. All we can do is make sure we try our best. Look at her. Look how relaxed and happy she is.’

Sophie looked at Lottie, who, sensing her mummy, turned and smiled, hot chocolate on her chin.

‘Hi, Mummy.’ Because she had noise-cancelling headphones on, her simple comment was shouted. I laughed, Sophie did, too, and then we both heard a tut from a table beside us. A woman, late sixties, maybe early seventies, clearly didn’t enjoy the declaration as much as we did. When we both looked at her, she was clearly displeased but returned to her conversation with her what I assumed to be husband, who looked like he wanted the world to swallow him whole.

Sophie picked up her coffee, and looked embarrassed for Lottie. I couldn’t allow it.

‘Wow, she looked at us like we had just farted in church.’

She almost choked on her coffee trying to hold in her laugh, which set me off again, and once she swallowed it, she joined me in chuckling.

‘She probably heard you,’ Sophie whispered.

‘I’m not sure I care.’ I meant it, I didn’t. Lottie is a little girl. That woman should know better.

‘Thanks, Jess, for seeing me today.’

‘That’s what friends do,’ I replied, not thinking, and she nodded.

‘Yeah.’

‘Soph, don’t worry about what happened last night. Lottie will have ups and downs, like the rest of us, you can’t stop that.’

‘Just worry she’ll hate me for being away with work a lot.’

‘She’ll never hate you, but she might lash out again. If she does, don’t take it personally. She is complex.’

‘Sure it’s not me?’

‘No, it’s not.’

‘With work, this case, I’m gonna be away a lot more.’

‘And she’ll be okay. Just keep coming back to her. That’s all she’ll need.’

‘Thanks, Jess.’

‘Reminds me, you told me Lottie is really into birds, well it got me thinking, and I got her a few things.’

‘You did what?’

‘Just bits that might help,’ I said, reaching into my bag.

‘Jess, you shouldn’t have,’ she said when I placed the books and pencils on the table.

‘It’s okay, it’s only from The Works. Cost me nothing.’

‘But still.’

‘Shush. So, I got her a book on coastal birds. I wanted it to be about all UK birds, but this was all they had. And I got this. Gotta admit, I’m pretty pleased with this.’

‘A colouring book?’

‘Yes, one that’s pages after pages of birds, with a colour code. All of the numbers coincide with a colour: follow the numbers, colour something beautiful.’

‘Why have you done this?’

‘You said bird song wasn’t enough, and she likes birds, and numbers too. This might—’

Before I could finish my sentence, Sophie was up, reaching over the table and pulling me into an embrace. One that was long and desperate.

‘Thank you.’

‘Sophie, it might not work.’

‘You see her as a little girl, not a problem.’

‘Of course.’

Letting me go, Sophie sat down, her eyes brimming, and composing herself by clearing her throat, she turned to Lottie.

‘Darling,’ she said, having to clear her voice as her words snagged. ‘Jess got you something.’

Taking off her headphones, Lottie looked at the books, and after looking at some pictures, I explained how the colouring book worked. She thanked me, and before either me or Sophie could suggest she gave it a go, she flipped open the cover, grabbed the pencils, and began to shade.

‘Jess, you’ve no idea what this means to me.’

‘Well, you and her, you have become quite important somehow,’ I said, and she nodded.

‘You to us too. And what you have done for Lottie.’

‘It’s only a colouring book.’

‘It’s more than that, it’s thought, it’s effort. It means more than you know.’

‘I like Lottie a lot,’ I said, and then I watched another tear form in Sophie’s eye.

Wiping it, Sophie took another sip of her coffee, and I mirrored her, watching her look at Lottie who was happy and content, and I could see some of the tension shift in my friend. Sophie then looked above Lottie, out of the window, and all of that tension shot back into her body.

‘Shit.’

‘Soph?’

‘Jess, can you stay here with Lottie? Pretend she is yours.’

‘What?’

‘Please,’ she implored, and I could see fear, real fear, in her eyes.

‘Okay, sure, okay.’

‘You don’t know me. Don’t look, don’t come over, keep my daughter away.’

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Chapter Thirty-One

No sooner had I agreed, Sophie walked away from the table, sitting as far away from us as she could. I had no idea what was going on, but I got up, and went to sit by Lottie's side, to pretend she was mine. Thankfully, Lottie was oblivious to what was happening as she coloured in a pheasant.

From behind me, a man walked into the café, and instead of joining the queue like everyone else, he made his way in the direction of Sophie. I wanted to look, but there was something in the way she'd spoken, something in her body language which told me that I needed to keep Lottie away from that man. Instead of openly looking in their direction, I picked up my phone, pretending to type, but instead I put on the camera, turned my screen ever so slightly, and watched.

The man didn't sit, and Sophie didn't get up. The fear she had shown me was gone, replaced with a stony demeanour, the police officer I had seen many times. I couldn't hear what was being said, but whatever their conversation was about, it was short. The man, clearly pleased with whatever they spoke of, left, got into an old VW Golf, and drove away.

Sophie got up, walked outside, looking around. She came back in, and bee-lined for me and Lottie.

'Come on, darling. We have to go,' she said, her voice tight and stressed.

‘Sophie, is everything okay?’

‘Fine. Lottie. Come on.’

She took the colouring book off her daughter, and practically lifted her out of the seat.

‘Mummy!’ Lottie protested.

‘Sorry, baby, Mummy has to go, let’s go sweetheart. See you, Jess.’

‘Sophie, what’s going on?’

‘Nothing.’

‘Then why did you ask me to pretend Lottie was my daughter?’

‘I’m sorry, Jess,’ was all she said, before she left, Lottie in tow.

I wanted to follow, to ask her what the hell that was all about, and who the man was and why I had to do what I did, but there was something about the way she moved, the fear that spilt that told me I needed to leave this alone.

I watched her load Lottie into the car, and pull away, and as she turned, she locked eyes with me. I couldn’t read what her expression was saying.

Something was going on, something that concerningly involved Lottie. Kelly told me once, Sophie Salam had secrets, and if we needed, we could dig. Now, I wanted to know what those secrets were. Because I had never seen Sophie Salam afraid, and I was terrified what that would mean for her, and for Lottie.

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Chapter Thirty-Two

After Sophie left me standing, mouth gaping in the coffee shop, I messaged Kelly, asking one simple question.

Can you dig?

She gave me a thumbs up, and I knew she didn't want to ask any more, not over message: we all worried we were being watched. My message was cryptic enough to not be understood, but direct enough for Kelly to know who I needed the digging on. Finishing my coffee, feeling rattled after what happened, I left the café, headed home, grabbed my travel bags and made my way to Kelly's from where we, the original serial killer support group, were going to travel together to the event up in Manchester. Kelly had offered to drive, as she always did.

When I arrived, I let myself into Kelly's house, and knowing everyone would be in the back room, the large hosting kitchen-cum-diner, I headed that way. But when I turned into the space, always in awe of how amazing Kelly's home was, only she and Hannah were there.

'Hey.'

'Hey, Jess, all okay?' Hannah asked.

'All good. Missed you,' I said, meaning it. 'Where's Mads?'

'She's not coming.'

‘Oh.’ I said. ‘Is she okay?’

‘She’s struggling a bit, asked to sit this one out.’

‘She’s the only one with a kid in this. I’m always surprised she is able to do so much,’ I said.

We didn’t say it, but I could tell all of us were thinking the same thing. Madison was struggling, but not only because she was a mum. What she did when she was The Caretaker, the damage she caused, I wasn’t sure anyone could unsee that level of violence. Our friend was lost, and we had to find her again.

‘Jess, Kelly and I have been chatting. I think, if it doesn’t cause too much hassle for Kimberley, we all sit this one out.’

‘Really?’

‘Mads is distant. If we do this without her, what does that say?’

‘Says we are shit friends,’ I conceded.

‘Also, your message, about Sophie Salam? Is she causing you issues?’ Kelly asked.

‘No, it’s just, it was weird.’ I filled her and Hannah in on seeing Sophie in the coffee shop. I chose to leave out that I had arranged for us to meet up, instead opting for us ‘bumping’ into one another. I explained about the man, and Sophie leaving me with her daughter. Hannah seemed genuinely shocked. Kelly, however, simply nodded.

‘Jess, did she ask you anything about The Caretaker?’

‘Nothing, not a word.’

‘Aside from the man, did she say anything else about the investigation. Ask you anything?’

I thought about it, replaying our conversation. ‘The only thing she asked was if I was left-handed.’

‘Left-handed?’ Hannah said.

‘Yep. That was all she asked.’

Kelly, who was half listening, had her phone in her hand, a burner, just like the one I owned, and as it started to ring, it was on loud speaker. A few moments later, a voice answered.

‘Kelly. How are things?’ Kimberley said.

‘Hi, Kimberley, all good, listen something has come up here.’

‘Is everything all right?’ she asked, her tone more serious than before.

‘Fine, fine.’ Kelly explained that Madison wasn’t up for it, and Sophie Salam had been around.

‘I understand, it might be best you don’t come up. If Sophie is around again, she might follow you. The conference is close to ... well, you know.’

‘Yeah, that’s what I thought,’ Kelly said.

‘Well, you will be missed, but I understand. Look after each other, and Madison. Check in. She sounds like she’s struggling.’

‘We think so too.’

‘And don’t worry about what’s next, all is on track, and under control.’

‘Thanks, Kimberley. Oh, wait, before I go. Do you know if the latest was left-handed?’

‘Left-handed? Why?’

‘Just wondered.’

‘I can message her, hold on.’

We waited, looking at one another, and after a minute Kimberley was back.

‘Yeah, she is. How did you know?’

‘Something SS said.’

‘I see. Kelly, Jess, Hannah, be careful. Definitely a good idea to stay away. Salam seems clever.’

‘She is,’ I said.

‘We have our retreat mid-next month. It’s safer. We will next see you there.’

‘We’ll be there,’ Kelly said. ‘Things will be calmer, and the retreats are more discreet.’

‘Exactly. It’s on the Norfolk coast again. Far away from all of this. Where we first met,’ Kimberley said.

‘We can’t wait,’ I said.

‘Be careful. If SS is asking you about being left-handed, she is suspicious still.’

‘She’s always suspicious,’ Kelly said.

Hanging up, I sat dumbstruck. Even when she called me needing a friend, even when it was about Lottie, and her being okay, Sophie still thought I was The Caretaker. She wouldn’t ever switch off, wouldn’t ever leave it behind. Sophie was my friend, but there was no doubt, if she could, she would arrest me.

‘Kelly, you said a while ago Sophie has a black mark on her past?’ I said quietly. Partially reeling from the sense of betrayal.

‘I know you are close to her, so I’ve not said, but after she watched us at the airport in March, I wanted to find out what I could.’

‘You’re not shocked about today, are you?’

‘No. I’m not.’

‘Tell me.’

‘There are gaps, and a convenient lack of evidence, so a lot of what I have found is speculation.’

‘Okay?’

‘What I know for sure is Sophie was undercover years ago.’

‘Right. How long?’

‘Almost nine years ago. She was tasked with infiltrating a gang based in Cambridge. Being a young and bright detective, she was perfect for the job. The leader of the gang was a man called Karl Kendrick. Pretty much as bad as they come. Drugs, trafficking, and after Sophie was involved, there was talk of murder.’

‘Okay?’

‘It was never proved, the murder, so although Kendrick went down, his sentence was only twelve years.’

‘So, Sophie did her job? I don’t get it.’

‘Again, there is no proof, but a rumour lingers around her time undercover. It was quashed in the aftermath of his arrest and conviction.’

‘What is it?’ I asked.

‘This is only what I’ve managed to learn from professional friends, one being in the CPS. Kendrick is likely to have murdered, and although it was never proved, there is talk that Sophie was there, and she was involved.’

‘What do you mean, involved?’

‘I mean, evidence of any wrongdoing obviously doesn’t exist. But, from interrogations of people who were working for Kendrick, looking for a plea, there were several who said that Kendrick did kill a man.’

‘Who?’

‘I don’t know yet, but it’s rumoured your friend Sophie Salam was involved in his murder. That man this morning, I bet it was someone connected to Kendrick.’

‘Kendrick doesn’t know Sophie has a kid,’ I said. ‘The look on her face, the way she told me to pretend to be Lottie’s mum. She is afraid he’ll do something.’

‘Probably. Kendrick is a bad man. Worse than even The Caretaker. That’s my guess, and she is trying to keep her girl safe.’

‘Why doesn’t she just go to her friends at the police?’ Hannah asked.

‘If the rumours weren’t true, she would have,’ Kelly said. ‘Sophie has done something so wrong she can’t even turn to those who could help. Ladies, if Sophie Salam ever comes for us, I think we have leverage.’

Chapter Thirty-Three

SOPHIE SALAM

Kendrick's brother, Pete, coming into the coffee shop to talk to her, shook Sophie into knowing she would have to act. She wanted Kendrick to leave her alone, but blocking his calls, changing her landline, and pretending that it would be enough to stop a man like him had caught up on her. Kendrick was close, his brother turning up, almost seeing her with her daughter. It was time to act.

It was time to visit her ex in prison.

Booking in to visit him provided no issues. Sophie was a detective in the force, and the assumption was that she was visiting in an official capacity. The events from back then had been buried by time. There was no reason for a red flag to fly at her wanting to see Karl Kendrick. Those files, and the reports she conducted, were also just as buried.

The only issue Sophie faced was knowing whether or not she would see it through. But then, as she drove the long and boring A-roads to HMP Woodhill, Sophie realised, despite her fear of being in the same room as him, the deep concern that his brother might have noticed Lottie and seen Kendrick's blood in her, she had to go. Karl wanted her attention, and he wouldn't give it up until he got it. He was that man, he demanded time. And she had to give it.

As she drove, mile after mile of seemingly endless motorway, she thought about her life back then, the eagerness to do good, the dream of becoming chief inspector one day. Life had seemed easy, planned out, then Kendrick changed it all. First with the blurring of lines of right and wrong, good and evil, then by stealing her heart, making her fall in love, and finally, the thing that meant he always had her in his pocket. One horrific night on a wet February when he committed the ultimate crime, staining her hands too. And of course, seven months later, Lottie.

Parking her car in the visitor car park, Sophie made her way inside, and following the rules of the prison, she checked in, providing her driving licence as proof of identity, and then she locked away all of her belongings, including her mobile phone. Doing so, she felt a fresh wave of anxiety. Her mum didn't know where she was, and the last time she didn't answer the phone, Lottie ended up hiding behind the sofa. It was almost enough to make her want to run to her car and drive away as fast as she could, but she had no choice. She had to see Karl and get him to leave her alone.

Once security were happy she had no contraband, she made her way towards the visitors' room with fifteen or so other people, who were all there to see their loved ones.

Taking a seat in the room, she thought about how normal it looked. There was a vending machine where she could buy drinks and chocolate bars. In the corner was a sensory area for little ones and, instead of hard chairs and tables, the space felt more like the coffee shop Pete found her in. She waited, hoping he would and wouldn't come in equal measure, and just as every visitor had their loved ones come and join them for the allotted time, Kendrick arrived. He stopped in the doorway, and Sophie could sense inmates, despite being wrapped up in their families' attention and love, were aware of him in the room. He hadn't changed, he still struck fear.

'Soph,' he said, taking a seat opposite her.

'Hello, Karl.'

‘You look great. You haven’t changed at all.’

She didn’t reply, but waited. Trying to hold his eye, struggling to do so. Whilst she apparently hadn’t changed, even though that wasn’t true – she was now a mother, so everything about her, body and mind, had changed – Karl definitely looked different. He had aged, his high cheek bones higher through being slightly underweight. He had greyed, not just his hair which had peppered, seasoned perhaps stronger than he would like, the grey was more than that, it was his whole being, like the version of him that was bright and fun, even if villainous, had faded. Damaged by time. Prison hadn’t been as kind to him as she thought it would be.

‘I sure was surprised when I was told I had a visit from you.’

‘Were you?’ she said.

He ignored her. ‘Of all the people from my life who I thought would come and say hi. Detective Sophie Salam wasn’t ever on that list.’

‘Well, you made it pretty clear you wanted to talk, so, Karl, I’m here. Talk.’

‘All business, Soph? After all we’ve been through?’

Sophie shifted in her seat. So far, Kendrick hadn’t given any clue that he knew about Lottie, but he was very good at keeping his cards close to his chest. Too good.

‘What do you want?’

‘As you said, just to talk.’

‘So talk.’

Karl clenched his jaw. He did that when he was annoyed, likely because she wasn’t playing the game in the way he wanted her to.

‘So, how’s life on the outside?’

‘Fine.’

‘Work?’

‘Good.’

‘I hear congratulations are in order, lead investigator in that Caretaker thing. That’s gotta be good for your career.’

‘If I catch him,’ Sophie said, despite herself.

‘Seems tricky. Don’t envy you.’

‘Karl, please, why do you keep trying to contact me?’

‘Because soon I’ll be a free man.’

‘Okay?’

‘I know, back then, you were undercover.’

‘Right.’

‘But I wasn’t just the job, and you weren’t just a plaything of mine.’

‘Karl. Stop.’

‘Sophie, look at me.’

Sophie did, and she could see that, under that mask he wore, there was still that man who made her feel happy once, safe even. He was the most violent man she had ever met, but never towards her. She hated herself for almost forgiving him.

‘You know what I’m about, right?’ he said.

‘What do you mean?’

‘I’m a protector, a leader.’

‘Okay.’

‘But I am also a man who won’t be attacked without retaliation.’

Sophie felt her muscles tense.

‘You lied to me.’

Sophie wanted to be sick, assuming that the lie he mentioned was Lottie. ‘I, what are you saying?’

‘You told me you loved me, back then.’

She let out a sigh, not Lottie. Thank God not Lottie. ‘Stop.’

‘And yet, you brought me down.’

‘It was my job.’

‘Tell me, were you tasked with being in my bed?’

‘No. Just to get in your gang.’

‘Right, so you wanted to have your cake and eat it.’

‘You know that’s not true, Karl. I shouldn’t have gotten mixed up with you, but I did, and I have to carry that.’

‘I wonder, if the truth was out about you and me when you were on the job, would you be sacked?’

‘You know I would.’

‘Why did you, then? If all you were meant to do was infiltrate my group, bring me down, why that?’

‘I made a mistake.’

‘Don’t fucking lie,’ Karl snapped, and two prison guards approached. He raised his hands. ‘Sorry, lads, emotional time.’

‘Are you okay?’ One of the guards asked Sophie.

‘Yeah, it’s fine.’

‘Okay, Kendrick, one more outburst and you’re done. Clear?’

‘Yes, boss,’ Karl said, lowering his hands again, placing them neatly on the table and leaning in towards Sophie.

‘Don’t lie, Soph. We don’t do that.’

‘Okay.’

‘Was I only a job?’

‘No.’

‘I know,’ he said. ‘That night, February, what I did, what you didn’t stop. You know why I never told anyone?’

‘Because you’d go down for murder.’

He laughed. ‘Well, yes.’ Then, the laugh stopped, and he shifted to the man Sophie had seen many times, the one everyone feared. ‘But why didn’t I tell anyone about you? The lines you crossed. Why didn’t I drag you down with me?’

‘I’ve wondered the same thing.’

‘Because now, and always, I’ll have the police in my back pocket. If they knew you and I were intimate, you’d be struck off. I wonder what would happen if they knew the other thing, Soph?’

She didn’t reply, she didn’t need to, she knew exactly what would happen. She would be arrested, charged, and she would face prison. And then she would lose Lottie.

‘Is this why you wanted to talk?’ Sophie asked.

‘Now you get it. You betrayed me, and the only reason you aren’t dead is not because I had feelings, fuck my feelings. No, Soph, you are only alive because soon I will be out, and I want to be able to do whatever the fuck I want, and you are going to make sure I can.’

Sophie wanted to tell him to fuck off, to drop dead, she wanted to walk out of that prison and never come back, and never think of him again. But she didn’t.

‘Understand?’ he asked, and Sophie nodded. ‘Good. No more blocking my calls, no more trying to avoid me. I will always find you, Sophie, always.’

‘Okay.’

‘All right. Good chat. Now, I need you to leave, got my soaps to watch.’

‘Karl?’

‘What?’

‘Nothing.’

‘Off you trot, be a good girl, yeah?’ he said with a wink, the same wink she had seen before. Sophie wasn’t anything to him, other than someone he could use. Those he did use ended up broken, or worse, but she had no choice. It was a price to pay for what she did, and Kendrick hadn’t mentioned Lottie. If he knew, he would have said. Her secret, her reason for everything, was safe.

Standing up, Sophie didn’t say goodbye, she walked out, and didn’t look back, knowing that soon Kendrick would be free, and then, whether

she liked it or not, she would be dragged into his world once more.

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Chapter Thirty-Four

THE CARETAKER

It was darker than he anticipated. Thick clouds had swept in, covering the setting sun, making what should have been a bright evening almost as black as night.

As the blue book said. Serendipitous.

Dark or not, it was almost time, and standing in the thicket of lush green shrubs and trees, twenty feet away from a trench that would serve its purpose, The Caretaker waited. He practised his breathing, as he had been taught in the book, and took in the time to ground himself, be fully present in the moment. No thoughts of before, or after. The world, the smells of earth and sky, the sound of evening call from birds. He wanted to savour it all. Not because soon he would kill a man, he reasoned, that part he would want to forget; no, he wanted to savour the moment he would free a woman, save a life, give a future that was lost, a future that should have always been. Tomorrow, the world would be different, the news would be out, the world would be talking, men would fear, women would feel hope, but for one specific woman, everything about the world was going to be brand new. Forever. And The Caretaker wanted to hold on to that for as long as possible. The smells, the sounds, the serendipity of thick clouds.

It was perfect.

Checking his watch, The Caretaker knew, within the next few minutes, Markwell would come walking along. He would have on his over-ear earphones, music so loud his other senses were dulled. He wouldn't see it coming. But he would know, he had to know, they all did.

As he thought about the execution of his plan, the birds stopped singing overhead. Something had changed for them, and silence was their best defence. But in the silence, The Caretaker could hear their message. Markwell was coming.

Ensuring he was perfectly hidden, he checked his sleeves were taped and boots were secure before pulling the face mask from his chin and up over his mouth. The heat of the evening made him sweat, but he knew not to uncover his skin, it all needed to be hidden, ensuring his DNA wouldn't be released. He had to do this by the book, as it had been done five times before.

He had to get it right.

From his left, The Caretaker heard the muffled singing of Markwell, and stepped back slightly, more to ensure he walked on without spotting the man who would make him pay. As he drew closer, The Caretaker knew he need not have bothered. So confident, so self-assured, Markwell wasn't going to see anyone.

Once he had passed, The Caretaker slipped out of the thicket, and as his target drew level with where the trench lay patiently waiting, he raised the shovel above his head, and swung. Markwell sensed something behind him and turned his head just in time to be struck in the face. He stumbled backwards, but managed to keep on his feet until the second swing, baseball-bat-style, caught him in the ear, and sent him crashing to the ground.

Whilst he moaned in a heap, The Caretaker hit him once more to ensure he wouldn't try and get up, then, checking he hadn't been seen, he dragged him off the path towards the waiting shallow grave. The Caretaker was fit,

he had to be, it was fundamental to the calling and, since joining the network, he had trained for this, but even so, the dead weight of Markwell, combined with the heat of the evening and coursing adrenaline, made moving slower than he had hoped. He slipped three times en route, but eventually he reached the grave, and still the world was silent. Birds watched, the wind blew, but they were alone.

Rolling the dead weight into the ditch, The Caretaker didn't pause for him to regain his senses, and began to shovel soil onto the unconscious man. Load after load poured onto his lifeless body until, just after his legs were covered, he began to stir, take in his surroundings, and he realised that standing above him was The Caretaker.

'No,' he said, trying to get up, his words slurring, still only semi-conscious, but it was in vain as he'd only moved a few inches before he was pushed down with a boot.

The Caretaker began to throw soil directly onto his face, and as he coughed, he moved again. This time The Caretaker swung the shovel, hitting him in the head, knocking him into delirium once more.

Dropping onto his target, The Caretaker picked up handfuls of mud, and prising his mouth open, he forced it in. Markwell, even semi-conscious, tried to fight, his body working on autopilot when his mind couldn't, until he began to choke, his mouth too full to do anything but swallow soil. The Caretaker held him and watched as he convulsed, twisted, fought until his body gave up. Then he took the blade and left the calling card that would show undeniably who was responsible. Climbing off his victim, he was sweating profusely, panting hard, this being the biggest workout he had ever done. Composing himself, he finished the job of burying him.

His work was done, all he needed to do now, was return home, reflect, and wait to be told when the book was being collected to continue its journey.

Taking one last look at the fresh grave, knowing it would be found, knowing that was the point, The Caretaker allowed a small victorious smile, remembering what the video from Cambridge said.

You have buried women with your abuse. Now I will bury you.

Above him, the birds began to sing once more, their sound sweet and celebratory, another bad man gone, another reason to sing.

Again, serendipitous.

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Chapter Thirty-Five

JESS

As I lay awake, staring at the ceiling in my bedroom, processing what I had learnt about Sophie Salam, the burner phone pinged, a new message on Signal, and before I opened it, I knew what would be said. Three words, as before.

It is done.

I expected to feel something, a rush of adrenaline, perhaps a little joy, but there was nothing. The Caretaker had killed again, so what? He was there, somewhere, I couldn't even remember which town or city. He was out of my control, he was bigger than me or Kelly or Hannah or Madison now. I was just an observer. And I wondered, was I desensitised because of once being so close, or was I mirroring what others might be feeling, and if that was the case, was his message as strong as it once was?

Desensitised or not, The Caretaker still was able to steal my sleep, and getting up, I went to make a coffee. It was going to be a long night, it always was after he did what he did. Soon, a video would be posted, and until then I may as well stay up.

The kettle hadn't even boiled when my phone pinged, the familiar bulletin sound from the BBC news app. I didn't open it, the headline said enough.

THE CARETAKER STRIKES FEAR INTO THE TOWN OF BOLTON

Instead, I went to YouTube, then X, then TikTok and scrolled until his familiar face filled my screen.

‘There you are.’

Turning up the volume, I listened to the mechanical tones of whoever was speaking.

‘Tonight, I have ended the life of another man, a man who abused his partner over and over, a man who, even after separation, wouldn’t let her be. He buried her with his words and deeds, and now, he finds himself in the ground. I want to make my message clear...’

I closed my phone, feeling suddenly too sick to hear his voice anymore.

Knowing there would be a fresh barrage of friend requests, DMs and tags on my socials, I left my phone on the kitchen side and went into the living room. Sitting on the edge of my sofa, in the dark, I for a moment wondered if this was still working. The Caretaker being out there, doing his thing. Was it landing as it intended? I dismissed the thought, because once I was too afraid to walk around my own flat in the dark. Once I had lost the ability to sleep in my own bed. Once I had a man in my garden, a man who should have loved and protected me, drawing a face on my bedroom window to scare me, or posting notes, or smiling to my doorbell camera in the dead of night. Once I was abused, and now I am not. Because of The Caretaker.

Thinking of how much had changed in the first half of this year, I remembered that there were still so many out there, mostly women. Like Esme, who were living like I had to live. Even though I was now desensitised, The Caretaker’s work would never be done. Not in my lifetime.

Thinking of Esme, I wanted to reach out, so picking up my phone again, even though the new wave of requests was coming, I found her number in my contacts, and I rang.

‘Hello?’ A voice came onto the phone, one that wasn’t Esme’s.

‘Hi, sorry, is Esme there?’

‘Who’s calling?’ the voice said quietly.

‘It’s Jess, I’m a, I’m a friend.’

‘Jess? As in Jess Pendle?’ the woman asked.

‘Yes,’ I said reluctantly.

‘I’m Esme’s mum,’ she said, and I felt relief flood in.

‘Oh, hi. Is she there? I wanted to check in.’

The woman began to cry. ‘Sorry.’

‘No, it’s okay. Is she all right?’

‘He got to her.’

‘What?’

‘He got to her, he attacked her.’

‘Is she okay?’ I asked.

‘She’s been in surgery. We’ll know more soon. I’m sorry, I have to go.’

The line went dead, and I sat there for a full minute trying to process what I had just been told. It wasn’t a part of the plan. Esme needed protecting, I had promised her she would be safe. Our support group was meant to protect her.

Even with the Signal chat talking about the latest kill, I needed them to know. So I interrupted and told them of Esme. I didn’t know why it felt so important. Maybe, maybe, I hoped Kimberley would take matters into her own hands, and add another man to the kill list.

But then, I was equally to blame, wasn’t I? She came to me, and I had failed her.

From the back of my flat, I heard a noise, a quiet tapping, and despite knowing Lewis was gone, there was still part of me that instantly wondered

if it was him. I was about to dismiss the noise as a breeze, or maybe some wildlife outside, when I heard it again, three distinct, rhythmic taps.

Someone was in my garden, someone was tapping on my bedroom window.

I looked at the time, seeing it was after one in the morning, and hearing the taps again, I crouched. Keeping low to the ground, and as quietly as I could, I went into my kitchen to find a knife.

Holding one in my hand, I moved to the doorway, and looked towards my room. Outside was pitch-black, too dark to see, but someone was out there. I began to move into my room, only to hear the handle on my back door squeak as someone tried to open it.

I wanted to scream, to tell them to fuck off. But fear gripped me as tight as I gripped the handle on the knife. The door handle squeaked again.

I wanted to hide, wait it out in the hope that whoever it was would leave. But they tried to get in again, this time rattling the door in its frame, and I had no choice. Stepping into the kitchen, my body shaking through adrenaline, I flicked on the light, hoping it would scare them off. I was temporarily blinded, and when my eyes adjusted, I saw the shape of a person still at my door. I let out a scream before realising I knew who it was.

‘Madison?’ Putting the knife on the kitchen counter, I rushed over and unlocked the door. ‘Shit, Mads, are you okay?’

She didn’t move, didn’t speak, she just stood there, smaller than I’d ever seen her before.

‘Love, come in.’ I stepped out and guided her into the kitchen. She didn’t fight, she just complied. I helped her into the living room, my heart still galloping, and she sat on the sofa. As I sat beside her, I heard my phone vibrating.

‘What, what are you doing here? Why didn’t you call?’

‘I couldn’t find my phone,’ she replied, at barely a whisper. ‘Sorry, Jess, I didn’t know where to go.’

I wondered where her son was, and who was looking after him, but she read my mind.

‘Don’t worry, he is with my mum. He’s there a lot at the minute.’

‘Mads? What’s going on?’

She looked at me for the first time, her eyes so bloodshot she looked like she was under the influence of something. ‘I, I can’t sleep, Jess.’

I didn’t speak, but waited for her to continue. She was fragile, we had all noticed: if I went in too strong, she might clam up. Besides, I still needed a moment myself, Madison had scared the shit out of me. My phone vibrated again, and again. The latest Caretaker was coming back to me. I had no doubt Kelly would be inundated, Hannah too.

‘I get these dreams,’ she continued, ignoring my phone. ‘Like I’m there again, in the house, waiting for him to come back.’

‘Jake?’ I asked softly.

She shook her head. ‘No, not Jake.’

I didn’t need to ask who she meant, if not her ex.

My phone vibrated once more, and this time Madison looked at it.

‘It’s buzzing a lot,’ she said.

‘Yeah, it is.’

‘Has he done it again?’

‘Yeah. Tonight.’

‘I’m glad I can’t find my phone. Where has he done it?’

‘Bolton.’

‘I don’t even know where that is.’

‘It doesn’t matter, not for us, not anymore.’

She nodded, lowered her head. ‘Jess, what we have done, are you ... how do we move on?’

‘With time. Forgiveness.’

‘What I did to that man, the way I...’ She trailed off. ‘I’m not sure I can.’

I didn’t know what to say. We never discussed how Kelly, Madison and Hannah did what they did. We talked of why, and the impact for the good. But we didn’t ever talk about the moment they killed. I had only been The Caretaker for a second, just to warn a man, and as much as it was amazing having some power, I had only hit him. I knew what Madison had done, the way she did it. I couldn’t imagine the things she had seen and heard in that moment.

‘Jess, can I stay here?’

‘Of course, do you need to ring your mum, let her know where you are?’

‘No, it’s okay,’ she said, before lying down, placing her head on my lap.

‘Mads, all is going to be okay. We’ll go to that retreat soon, like before. The sea air, and space. It will help.’

‘Okay,’ she said quietly before she closed her eyes and started to cry. Not knowing what to say, I stroked her hair, said nothing, until she fell asleep. A new friend needed me, and she was now in hospital because I had failed. I wouldn’t fail my old friend too.

Again, I had to wonder, was this thing with The Caretaker worth it, or had we replaced one bad thing in our lives with something much, much worse?

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Chapter Thirty-Six

SOPHIE SALAM

In the wake of meeting Karl, Sophie wanted nothing more than to hide away with Lottie forever, and returning home, she did exactly that. Daya, relieved from her duty as carer, went back to hers, and Sophie locked the door, hoping to forget the past, her work, and The Caretaker. She played Lego, watched a movie, and the two of them fell into the rhythm only a mother and her child could. It almost worked, the outside world was almost forgotten, until her phone started ringing. Lottie was sound asleep, sprawled across Sophie, and moving slowly to not wake her, Sophie picked up her phone. It was Clarke. It only meant one thing. She didn't want to answer. But, with work, and now because of Kendrick, with life, what she wanted didn't matter anymore.

'Clarke? What time is it?'

'Almost midnight.'

'Don't you ever sleep?'

'Not these days, no. Sorry, I didn't want to wake you but, well, you can guess.'

'Where?' she said, realising that the adrenaline she once felt was now mostly just tiredness.

'Bolton this time. Caretaker has taken credit. They are just trying to find the victim now.'

‘What do you mean, trying to find the victim?’

‘From what the video said, he has been buried somewhere.’

‘Jesus.’

‘Yep. I’m going to wait for confirmation, then I’m heading up. I’m part of the task force now too.’

Sophie smiled. ‘Congratulations.’

‘Bittersweet, but thanks. Look, if it is our man, I’ll go for us. I’ll ring you later, update you.’

‘I should be there.’

‘But sometimes, you can’t, and that’s okay.’

‘No, I hear you, but I want to work the scene. I have to see this through, you know?’

‘Yeah, I know. How’s Lottie?’

‘She’s good, sound asleep.’

‘As you should be.’

‘Yeah, but until we crack this, I don’t think either of us is getting any sleep. Clarke?’

‘Yeah.’

‘I’m really glad you’re on this task force with me now.’

‘Sophie, you’re not my type. Too young for me,’ he said, and Sophie could hear the smile in his voice.

‘You’re such a bellend.’

‘Always. Oh hang on,’ he said, and Sophie heard the phone move away. She heard taps on his phone, and then he came back. ‘Still here?’

‘Mute your touchpad on your phone, no one likes that guy.’

‘Never. Sophie, they just messaged from Bolton. It’s definitely him. They have found the body, small cross is there.’

‘Okay,’ Sophie said, a sick feeling washing over her. ‘Okay.’

‘I’ll head up now, you can sit this one out, if you want?’

‘If I’m honest, it is what I want, but they only just put me in charge of this. If I stop turning up, what does it say?’

‘That you’re just like upper management.’

‘Yeah, I can’t do that. I’ll let Lottie sleep a little more, and I’ll take her to my mum’s.’

‘Okay, I’ll see you soon.’

‘See you soon.’

Hanging up the phone, Sophie lay back and stroked her daughter’s hair as she gently snored on her lap. She wanted to stay in the moment forever. Leave it all behind, the career, the past, start again, somewhere new, to be someone new. And as she began to daydream of her and Lottie and Daya moving to a place where no one knew their name, and taking a simple job that paid the bills and fed her daughter, she felt a tear drop onto her cheek. One became two, which became more, and she didn’t stop herself crying. She silently wept, silently prayed for things to be different. She hated leaving her girl, hated that she knew who The Caretaker was, but couldn’t stop him. And above all, she hated that Kendrick was back in her life and she had to comply with his demands. When he called, she would have to answer, when he told her to jump, she would have to ask how high. Because doing that would be the only way she could keep him at bay. It was the only way she could protect her daughter.

She pushed down her grief, it wouldn’t help, and looking at her girl, she smiled. She would let her sleep for a couple more hours, then she would message her mum, arrange an early drop off and drive to Bolton.

It was all so hard, so, so fucking hard, but Lottie was worth it, and the daydream she had of moving somewhere new, living a simpler life, came back. The dream was perfect, even if it was only ever going to be a pipe one.

Chapter Thirty-Seven

Pulling up at the car park her satnav had directed her to, that sat opposite a football pitch, Sophie took a moment to compose herself. The drive was long, her body ached, but she couldn't let anyone see that. Nor could she let anyone see she was stressed, pulled in every direction, and because of Kendrick, afraid. She was the lead on this case, she had to be unflappable. Rain lashed on the windscreen of the car, a deluge that she didn't have the right attire for – she didn't even have an umbrella.

She sighed. 'Great.'

Getting out of the car, squinting against the rain, she was greeted by a young officer who looked too young to be in the uniform, but really, she was just getting older. He put an umbrella over her head. And she thanked him. She could tell, before he spoke, that he was excited to be at a murder scene. It said a lot about the world: excited, not horrified, excited, not afraid.

'Morning, ma'am, how was your drive?' he asked, his accent placing him as a local.

'Sophie is fine. It was good, thanks. Long.'

'I bet. I'll take you to where the site is.'

The young officer walked away from the car park and football pitch, towards a long and picturesque path, treelined and partially sheltered from

the rain. Sophie followed, inwardly cursing for not having the right shoes on for a storm.

‘Is it true, has The Caretaker been here?’ he asked. ‘I mean, it must be if you’re here.’

She didn’t comment.

‘Jesus, I mean, I’ve been reading about him, obviously, everyone has, but for him to be here. I mean. God.’

‘What’s your name?’

‘PC Young.’ His name was fitting.

‘PC Young. I know The Caretaker is now famous. But he’s not a celebrity, he’s a serial killer.’

‘Yes, sorry,’ he said, his excitement fading. ‘Sorry.’

Leading on in silence, it didn’t take long for Sophie to see the crime scene: the path was taped off, not allowing anyone in or out. So far, no press had arrived, but it wouldn’t be long. PC Young, or another eager, excited officer would let slip.

Ducking under the cordon, Sophie saw Clarke dressed in his overalls, smiling her way. She walked up, fighting the urge to give him a hug.

‘How was the drive?’

‘It was all right. You been with the victim?’

‘Yeah, for an hour now. It’s The Caretaker, no doubt.’

‘Okay, let’s take a look, shall we?’

Stepping into the pop-up tent that protected the crime scene from the elements, Sophie grabbed some gloves and a face mask and looked at the shallow grave. Beside the corpse were boot prints. Nothing new.

‘Let me guess, size ten?’

‘Yep.’

The body was half exposed, his torso and left shoulder above the ground. Even from her standing position, Sophie could see the cross.

‘They are usually harder to see.’

‘Yes, they are. This one is several inches larger than any of the others.’

‘Have we checked the size of them all?’

‘Yeah. We spoke about it. How they are all slightly different. Remember? One of them is left-handed.’

‘Yeah, sorry. Of course,’ Sophie said, forgetting entirely that they had spoken of this already. ‘Do we know the cause of death?’ She tried to move the conversation along before Clarke could see she was struggling to recall the details.

She always recalled the details.

‘Well, from what we can see, the man took a hell of a beating. The weapon has been taken to the lab already to be processed.’

‘Weapon?’

‘A shovel. Cause of death initially looked like blunt force trauma,’ Clarke said, getting on the floor next to the corpse. ‘But, as you can see, his mouth is full of soil. So, I reckon it was suffocation.’

Sophie pulled out a torch, and shone it on the battered and blue face of their murder victim.

‘Okay, so he was beaten, dumped in here, and then suffocated in soil?’

‘That’s what I’d guess, we won’t know for sure until he’s been examined properly.’

Sophie nodded, and then keeping the torch on his face, she lowered herself to the ground beside Clarke. She leant in closer to the victim.

‘Soph?’

‘What’s that?’ she said, moving the torch towards the gaping mouth of the victim.

Clarke got closer and, producing a second torch, shone it in the same direction. ‘Oh yeah.’ he said. Sophie waited as Clarke grabbed a pair of tweezers, and carefully pulled a long auburn strand of something from the mouth of their corpse.

‘Hair?’ Sophie asked.

‘Yep, you can see the follicle attached.’

‘Could be from our guy?’

‘Yep. It could be. Great spot.’

Sophie stood, her knees cracking as she did, feeling relieved that, although she had forgotten the conversation about the crosses, she was still able to be sharp on a crime scene. She knew that this was big. The Caretaker hadn’t made a mistake before. She knew that the hair could be coincidental, the crime scene was outside. There could be a thousand reasons as to why there was hair in his mouth. But still.

‘I’m gonna call this in to the boss,’ Sophie said. ‘How long would it take to process this?’

‘A few days. I want to stay here, examine the body properly in the lab up here. But I know this could be a thing.’

‘Yeah, it could.’

Sophie stepped out of the tent and, pulling off her face mask, she took a long, deep breath. Petrichor, the smell of the world after rain, flooded her senses. It was her favourite smell. It reminded her of being a kid, the long summer holidays of playing out until the lights came on. Simpler times. It reminded her life could be easier, was easier once. And maybe the smell meant change was coming for her, an easier life, somehow.

The hair, it could be the break she needed. But it being auburn ruled out Jess Pendle, and she couldn’t help but feel relieved for that. Kelly, however, was a redhead.

As she pulled out her phone to ring the station, a door camera notification pinged, and opening the app, she saw a man stood at her front door. She couldn’t see who it was, he was too close, the screen filled mostly with his chest and neck.

‘Can I help?’ she said, and when he stepped back, so his face lined up with the camera, her stomach dropped.

‘Hello, Soph,’ Pete Kendrick said.

Sophie panicked: if her mum opened the door, Kendrick's brother might see into her home, and know Sophie had a daughter. 'Pete. I'm not in, I can give you my mobile, you can call m—'

Sophie was cut off by the sound of her front door opening, and then she heard Lottie.

'Hello?'

Pete looked away from the camera, and all Sophie could do was helplessly watch Lottie's uncle talk to her.

'Hello, who might you be?' he asked, his accent a thick Geordie.

'Lottie.'

Sophie wanted to tell her to go back inside, to shut the door, but Kendrick would know then for sure that Lottie was her daughter.

'Hello, Lottie,' Pete said.

Then Sophie's mum came to the door, and Sophie had to hope her mum remembered that the Newcastle accent was something that scared Sophie when Karl first started calling.

'Can I help?' Daya asked.

'I was just wanting to see Sophie.'

'I'm sorry, she isn't here.'

'I see, I was just saying hello to this little one. Lottie is a nice name.'

'Lottie, back inside please,' Daya said.

'Bye,' Lottie said.

'See you soon, Lottie,' Pete said.

Sophie wanted to say more, but she felt powerless to do anything but watch her screen.

'Who is that little one?' he asked.

'I'm a childminder,' Daya said, and Sophie wanted to cry at her mum's resourcefulness.

'Childminder. I see,' Pete said.

‘If you want Sophie, you will have to call her. I have to go,’ Daya said, and Sophie heard her front door close.

She continued to watch. Pete didn’t leave straight away. He stooped so he could look into the camera once more.

‘Well, isn’t that interesting.’

‘Pete, I’m not at home much. If you, or Karl, need me, you need to call.’

‘Remember this number, give it a call tomorrow.’

Before Sophie could say any more, Pete recited a number into the camera, turned, and walked away. In a panic, she typed the number into her phone quickly, and saved it as KK.

She wouldn’t message from her phone, she would get a burner, and then find out what he wanted.

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Chapter Thirty-Eight

THE CARETAKER

Putting on gloves, face mask, jacket, he waited for his target, seventeen-year-old Kai Mallark to come home. It was a Tuesday, but it didn't matter the day. He'd been smoking with his mates, as he did every night. But this night would be different, this night everything would change. Instead of coming home, falling on his bed and sending hateful messages to his girlfriend, Emily, calling her frigid one day and a slut the next, he would have The Caretaker waiting for him. He would be taught a lesson.

All The Caretaker had to do was wait.

But the wait was hard; each passing minute felt like an hour, and in that time, he doubted he could see it through. But he had to, Emily needed him to. She didn't quite see the road she was heading down, how her love was being abused. That Kai was taking chunks of who she was away, bit by bit, and he would do until there was nothing left of her.

He would take chunks out of Kai, just to make sure the lesson was learnt.

Kai usually got home from his smoking sessions around 10pm, and true to form, at three minutes past, The Caretaker heard the front door open.

He stepped back into the gap between the wardrobe and the bedroom door, so when it swung open, he would be perfectly obscured. Pulling his face mask up, he clenched his fists, ready to rain them down on Kai.

The door opened, squeaking angrily as it did, and before The Caretaker saw Kai, he could smell the sweet and dank aroma of weed. Kai was mumbling something to himself, as he came in, closing the door without looking back. The Caretaker raised his balled fists in front of him like a boxer, and held his breath. He wanted Kai to turn, see him, before he attacked.

Kai dropped onto his bed face first, still without looking back and seeing the outline of the man everyone feared lurking in the dark corner of his room. And then he rolled over, phone in hand, obscuring his view of the man who killed bad men, and the agonising wait came down to the final seconds.

Hitting send on a message, no doubt to Emily, no doubt telling her she was a bitch, or worse, Kai dropped his phone, and then his bloodshot eyes locked onto those of The Caretaker.

He opened his mouth to gasp, cry out, but The Caretaker moved too fast and, before a sound could be uttered, he jumped on the boy and hit him over and over in the face.

He hadn't ever hit anyone before and was shocked at how much it hurt. His fists screamed at him to stop, but he didn't relent. In the movies, a few strikes and someone was unconscious, but after eight or nine, Kai wasn't, and he began to fight back.

The first blow sent white light flashing across The Caretaker's eyes, the second sent him crashing off the bed, onto the floor.

'Dad! Dad!' Kai shouted, bloodied, but in no way incapacitated, and as The Caretaker got to his feet, his legs feeling not his own anymore, and knowing he couldn't win, his flight mechanism kicked in. Turning, he tried to run to the door, but Kai wasn't finished, and grabbed him, pulling him back into a headlock.

'Dad, help!' Kai shouted again, and the bedroom door swung open. The Caretaker kicked it, slamming it back into Kai's father and somehow,

wrestling himself free, he pushed Kai hard, sending him tumbling over the bed, and ran to the bedroom window.

If it had been winter, it would have been closed and The Caretaker would have been fucked. But it was summer, blisteringly hot, and Kai's bedroom window was wide open. Before he got hurt anymore, The Caretaker climbed out. He lowered himself so he was hanging off the sill and let go.

Hitting the ground knocked the wind out of him, but if he didn't get up, if he didn't run, he would be hurt, or worse. So heaving himself upright, he limped into the night.

Turning a corner, The Caretaker quickly pulled off his mask, gloves and jacket, and threw them in a bush, and began staggering home. The walk was maybe half an hour. After ten minutes, he heard police cars rushing to Kai's aid.

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Chapter Thirty-Nine

THE NETWORK GROUP CHAT

INTH3SHADOWS

I've just seen he has been in Devon. I didn't know we were in Devon. Is she okay?

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

Devon, what do you mean? Is who okay?

INTH3SHADOWS

Whoever was next, in Devon.

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

We aren't in Devon.

CAPABLESALAMANDER

I've just seen a post online.

THESUNMAID

What does it say?

CAPABLESALAMANDER

That he tried to attack a kid, like 17-year-old. And failed.

B3LLADONNA

Shit, I've just found it, Google, Caretaker in Devon.

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

Let me look into this. But this isn't us.

REDSHADEKIMBA

Then who is it?

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

I don't know.

THESUNMAID

You don't know?

NORTHERNUPROAR

I thought this might happen.

THESUNMAID

What?

NORTHERNUPROAR

That people would begin to copy him.

INTH3SHADOWS

I've got to ask, does anyone else think this is getting out of hand?

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

I'll sort this.

COSTA-LOVER777

Has anyone heard any more about that girl, who was attacked. Esme?

NO-ONE.HOME

She's hurt bad, but will make it.

COSTA-LOVER777

That's a relief. It's fucked up that speaking out about abuse is still resulting in this.

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

And this is why we are doing our work. This law, when it is created, will ensure women like Esme are never hurt again.

NO-ONE.HOME

Esme's law. It has a ring.

B3LLADONNA

yeah, it does.

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

So, for Esme's law, we keep going. Devon I will sort. Slough, nothing has changed, stick to the plan.

REDACTEDUSER

I'm ready. I'll message when it's done.

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Chapter Forty

JESS

I n the chaos of what The Caretaker was doing, work had suffered, and I was beginning to miss it deeply. Not just being with Will and Eva, who were such joys, and bringers of peace to my war-like mind. I missed Jenny, Samual too. I was lucky that lately I was surrounded by good people, loving people, caring people, but aside from my mum and stepdad, who I didn't see much lately because of what I knew, I didn't have anyone in my life who wasn't involved in The Caretaker or the support group. Jenny and Samual were hard-working, honest, innocent in all aspects of their life. I missed being a part of that. So knowing I was going to be there at their house for a long shift made me feel genuine excitement. Things were feeling hard; Esme being hurt had rattled me, as had Madison coming over, but I needed to be upbeat, alert, fun and able. If I appeared disconnected, if I fell asleep again, I was worried I would lose my job.

So, dressed and ready an hour before my shift, I headed out the door, and towards work. I had been early the last few shifts, I knew Jenny wouldn't mind at all.

I stepped out of the front door, and checked both left and right. I wasn't going to fall foul of a man startling me again. But the streets were quiet. Peaceful. The morning wasn't quite as hot as it had been for the last few weeks, and birds sang favourably of that. Getting into my car, I opened both

front windows and pulled out onto the quiet road. As I cleared my street, I turned on the radio, and caught some of Alanis Morissette's 'Ironie'. As a little girl, I had loved the song, knew it word for word, even if I was too young to understand what the words actually meant.

'Ironie' seemed to be a theme for me lately. My friends were all killers, and my only other friend, who wasn't involved, was the detective investigating them. In my opinion, much worse than a traffic jam when you're already running late.

I sang along as I ate up the miles, until I arrived on the drive of my work place. Both Jenny's and Samuel's cars were on the drive. Which made me smile. As I got out of the car, I was greeted by Eva, who came running from the house and jumped into my arms.

'Aunt Jessie.'

'Hello, lovely, gosh have you grown since I last saw you?'

'Uh-huh.'

'And you're getting so heavy too. Soon you'll be as big and as tall as me.'

'Taller.'

'Taller, I don't doubt it. Come on.'

Putting Eva down, I took her hand and headed back to the house, where Will waited for me, beaming a smile. He didn't run, though: I could see straight away it wasn't a good morning from him.

'Are you okay?'

'Yep,' he said.

Giving him a cuddle, too, Eva then led me to the kitchen, where both Samuel and Jenny sat drinking coffee.

'Morning,' I said.

'Morning. Made you a coffee,' Samuel said, getting up and handing me a cup.

'Thanks.'

‘No worries. I’ve got to crack on, just wanted to say hi.’

He leant over to Jenny, gave her a kiss on the cheek and, smiling my way, he left and closed the front door behind him.

‘Hey, Jenny.’

‘Hey, how are you doing?’

‘I’m good, pretty good,’ I said. ‘I’m so sorry for what happened last time I was here.’

‘Nothing to be sorry for.’

A wave of guilt washed over me. Before this year, I was present at work, very rarely off. I was focused solely on the kids, and dreaming of being a child therapist one day. But since The Caretaker, I had slacked off, pulled in different directions between grieving my ex, supporting my friends, and carrying the burden of knowledge.

‘You look tired, Jess,’ Jenny said, stopping the guilt spiral.

‘Little bit.’

‘You gonna be okay?’ she asked, concern in her unwavering gaze.

I smiled. ‘I’m good, it’s a lot sometimes, but I promise, I’m coping. I want to be here with the kids.’

‘You do a lot for this family. We are always there for you too.’

‘Honestly, just being here in your home with the kids is massive.’

‘I get that. They are special. Biased, I know.’

‘They are, so so special.’

Jenny smiled then looked at her watch, an Omega that was probably worth more than I earned in six months. I saw her smile fade.

‘All okay?’ I asked.

‘Yeah. Yeah. Fine. Just some work stuff. A headache I don’t need.’

‘Sorry.’

‘It’s okay, I better go, get set up.’

‘At the office?’

‘No, upstairs.’

‘Okay. I’ll take the kids out.’

‘That would be great, thank you. I’ll be an hour or so.’

‘No rush. We’ll leave shortly.’

‘Thanks, Jess, really, thanks. We are lucky you are here.’

As Jenny went upstairs, I headed into the living room where the children were playing. I noticed I felt tentative getting back into play mode. Anything creative was like a muscle, when I used it a lot it was strong, but lately I’d used it less, and even though I got on the floor and picked up a toy and joined in with a roleplay game, the muscle felt weak and, after ten or so minutes, I was out of ideas. Thankfully, the morning was cooler than it had been, and Jenny needed the space for work, so before the kids noticed I wasn’t as playful as I could be, we were up, putting on our shoes and heading out the door.

The walk was the tonic I didn’t know I needed. Eva and Will moved at a slower pace than I did, than any adult did. They paused to look at a butterfly, or an interesting flower. Will looked at the birds flying, and stopped every time we saw a car so he could listen to the engine. Children did that, they took the world in, saw it for what it was. I wondered when that was lost.

When we reached the park, we played tag and hide-and-seek. We climbed on the climbing frames and I pushed them both on swings, alternating between them at the same time. ‘Aunt Jess, you are pushing me so much higher than ever!’ Will said, and I noticed, since starting to work out, pushing the children on swings was no effort at all.

After the park, I didn’t want to go back to the house, not straight away, so we went and found a little shop where I got them both a drink and bought a loaf of bread. Eva looked at me confused as to why I was buying bread, asking if I was going to eat it. Her little face when I told her it was for the ducks was precious.

‘Ducks, we are going to feed the ducks?’ she said.

‘If you want to.’

‘Yes!’

She cuddled me, long and hard, and Will joined in too. For a moment, we just stood there, hugging outside a small shop, getting in other people’s way, and it was nothing short of perfect. Restorative. In a world that had become so heavy, they were a lightness that found its way back into my heavy heart. They were hope.

Near the lake where we would feed the ducks, we sat, talked about clouds and birds and summer. Will asked me where I’d been and if I was going to get another job. I told him I wasn’t, I couldn’t. Because he and his sister weren’t a job, they were family.

‘Promise, Aunt Jess?’ Will asked.

‘Promise.’

As we fed the ducks, we settled into the moment, until someone interrupted us.

‘Jess Pendle?’

I turned to see a man standing looking at me, a phone in his hand, recording. I instinctively moved to try to shield the children.

‘Yes?’

‘I wondered if I could get a few words about the recent event in Devon.’

‘Recent event?’ I said, getting up and placing myself between this stranger and the children I was charged to care for.

‘The failed Caretaker thing?’

I looked at him, no idea what he was talking about, and he could tell straight away. ‘Last night.’

‘I’m not interested,’ I said. ‘Are you filming this?’

‘I want to get you’re take on how this is develop—’

‘I’m here with some children, and you think it’s okay to come and talk to me about, about him? Who the hell do you think you are? Stop recording. You don’t have my consent.’

‘Miss Pendle. Don’t you think it’s awful what is going on? People are now pretending, and you, one of the faces of this, haven’t said or done anything. Men are getting hurt. And you’re not stopping it.’

I ignored him, and turned to the children. ‘Come on, time to head home.’

‘But Aunt Jess,’ Eva complained.

‘Let’s go make some playdough at home, how does that sound?’

Eva smiled, pacified, and the three of us began to move.

‘Miss Pendle!’ the man called.

‘Leave us alone!’ I shouted, not looking back.

But he didn’t leave us alone, he ran after us, phone in hand and, as he chased us, Eva stumbled and fell. She hit the ground hard, taking the skin off both of her knees.

I stopped, and as the man drew closer, I slapped him as hard as I could.

‘Bitch,’ he said, ignoring the fact a little girl was crying, and stomped off.

Picking up Eva, I didn’t speak, I dared not, and I carried her home, Will in tow, as fast as I could. Arriving at their home, I cleaned and put plasters on Eva’s knees and, giving them snacks, I settled them both in the living room. They were shellshocked, and barely spoke. They had heard what the man had said. I needed to do something. That man was angry, maybe even scared, if he had realised he wasn’t as good as he should have been. He could have done a lot worse than frighten a little girl and call me a bitch, but that alone was enough for me to know I couldn’t do this anymore. Will and Eva needed protecting.

As sadness washed over me at what that meant, I opened my phone, unlocked the Signal app and saw the messages about Devon. Feeling my anxiety build, I closed the app and looked online for more information. As I scrolled, a familiar face filled my screen. Sophie. She spoke of an arrest, a

fourteen-year-old boy who they believed wasn't The Caretaker but someone using his identity to try to help his sister.

A fourteen-year-old was going to try and kill someone.

This was getting out of hand.

I watched Sophie answer a few questions about The Caretaker case, and I could see she was struggling. The moment in the coffee shop, the fear I saw in her eyes, it was taking its toll, and although I couldn't help her with work, I could be a friend. I would need one, too, and so composed a message.

Hey, Sophie. I know you're swamped, but I hope you're okay.

I hovered over send for a few moments, then I tapped it and, putting my phone down, I sat with Will and Eva, cuddling and watching TV for a while, trying not to cry. For when Jenny finished her meeting and came back down, I was going to tell her what had happened and what I needed to do because of it. I had made a promise to Will, but for his sake, Eva's, too, I was going to have to break it.

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Chapter Forty-One

‘Are you sure about this, Jess?’ Jenny asked, her eyes brimming.

‘I don’t want to, but I have to.’

I waited for her to say I was wrong, but she didn’t, because I wasn’t wrong. The children had to be shielded from it all, and there was no other way, not really, not to keep them safe. They were so innocent, the world was so colourful and exciting, and I could be the reason they knew there was darkness around every corner.

‘How much notice do I need to give?’ I asked, tears dropping onto my cheeks.

‘Forty years,’ Jenny said, and I laughed, then cried.

‘I need them to be okay. Maybe, once this is all quiet again...’

‘Yeah. We need you, the kids do too. Can we not say give notice, can this just be you taking a break?’

‘Taking a break.’

‘And when the break is over, you come back?’

‘I still want to visit. See you all.’

‘You have no choice in that,’ Jenny said. ‘You’re our family, Jess.’

I nodded, unsure what to say.

‘I am sorry that this year has been how it’s been. You haven’t deserved it,’ she continued, taking my hand as she spoke. I nodded again, but this nod

was a lie: I deserved it all, because I had made the choices. No one forced me to fall in love with Lewis. No one forced me to speak up and then join the support group, and no one forced me into what had come since. I had made my life as it was.

‘And thank you,’ Jenny said.

‘For what?’

‘Putting them first. Will you be okay, financially?’

‘I’ll get by.’

‘I’m sure Samual and I owe you countless hours, where you’ve gone above and beyond for them.’

‘I did that because I love them.’

‘I know,’ she said. ‘Jess, the door stays open. For work, but mostly for us. Please don’t vanish.’

‘I’m so sorry,’ I said.

Giving Jenny a lingering hug, I fought not to cry. I was going to leave, and I didn’t want Will and Eva to see me upset. Letting her go, I gave her a small nod, then walked to the living room.

‘Right, gang, I have to go.’

‘What? Already?’ Eva protested.

‘I’m afraid so. But I’ll see you both soon.’

‘When?’ Will asked, and I hesitated. I hated lying to them.

‘Soon,’ was all I managed to say.

Giving them both a kiss on the tops of their heads, I made my way to the door. Jenny followed and gave me another hug.

‘Take care, Jess. I hate that this is happening.’

‘Me too,’ I said, turning and walking to my car.

Jenny stayed in the doorway, arms crossed, watching me as I pulled out of her drive and headed onto the road. The next left, I turned, pulled over and, knowing she would be inside with the children, now unable to see me, I put my head in my hands and cried. I cried until my tears ran dry. I cried

because I didn't think this would ever die down, The Caretaker was going to exist forever, and I would never be able to see those children again.

As my sobbing slowed and acceptance rolled in, I picked up my phone to see several messages. One was from the group chat with me, Hannah, Kelly and Madison, confirming details of when we were all meeting to leave for the retreat in Norfolk in three days' time. And there was another from Sophie.

I messaged the group first, I knew where my loyalties lay, and we talked about Saturday's drive to the retreat Kimberley's charity was hosting. For a while, we chatted about Friday's session and perhaps us all going for coffee after somewhere. Madison said she couldn't make the session, as she had a doctor's appointment, but would hopefully make the coffee after. But me, Hannah and Kelly were in. I didn't mention I had just lost my job, and I didn't know why. Then, closing down that chat, I read what Sophie had to say in response to my message.

Hey. Yeah, it's been a little rough.

I replied straight away.

Same here, lost my job today.

Oh no. Jess, I'm so sorry. Wanna go get a drink later? I could do with someone to drown my sorrows with.

You sure that's a good idea?

Probably not. But right now I'm not sure I care.

I hesitated. Meeting for a coffee with Lottie there was one thing. Going for a drink was something else entirely. And I wanted to justify my need to see her as hiding in plain sight or keeping my enemies close. And there was the real risk she was manipulating me to let my guard down and make a mistake. After all, she had worked undercover before: maybe this was

something similar. But really, I had always liked Sophie, and I wanted her company.

I'd like that.

Me too.

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Chapter Forty-Two

SOPHIE SALAM

Waiting outside The Swan pub, Sophie knew it wasn't a good idea to meet with Jess Pendle, the woman who was connected to The Caretaker in some complex way. But with the recent crimes and there being no way Jess could have been there, the evidence of any wrongdoing was becoming more and more distant. But Jess Pendle was holding out on her, she had secrets. And Sophie knew all about holding on to unspoken things.

As people passed, some leaving but most arriving for a night out, she moved from the doorway and leant on the wall beside it, trying to not look like someone who was nervous. Her phone pinged, and not knowing if it was her real phone or the burner she messaged Karl on, she panicked, only relaxing a little when she saw it was just Clarke.

Hair is human, but no DNA match. Whoever's it is, isn't on any database anywhere.

She sighed: it wasn't Kelly, as she'd suspected. Kelly had been arrested before, and it was standard to take a DNA sample. This hair not being on a database meant whoever it belonged to had never been involved with the police.

Okay, get local police to take a sample from everyone connected to the victim. You never know.

On it.

Locking her phone, she focused on a photo of Lottie that was her screensaver, and guilt washed over her like a tsunami. She should have been at home, not waiting for someone in a pub.

‘Am I late?’ a voice said, making her jump. Looking up, she saw Jess in front of her. She was in black jeans and a light grey top. She looked different. Stronger.

‘No, not at all. I’m early.’

‘Ah, okay,’ Jess replied, and Sophie could see Jess felt as awkward as she did.

‘Jess, I need a drink.’

‘God, me too.’

Opening the door, Sophie walked in. Jess followed, and the noise from inside the pub was welcoming. The humdrum of dozens of conversations, some raucous, some quiet, was a relief. Without Lottie to distract, this was about her and Jess only, and if the pub had been quiet, she wondered if she would have stayed.

Finding a table, Sophie offered for Jess to sit, and then she walked to the bar to get the first round. As she waved down the barman, a young man who looked too clean-cut to be pulling pints, she realised that she wasn’t awkward, she was nervous. What she was doing, having a drink, a planned drink, with no Lottie and with someone she considered to be a potential suspect, that was reason enough to be jittery. She pushed down her anxiety, got their drinks, a gin and tonic for her, a red wine for Jess, and went back to the table.

‘Here you go.’

‘Thanks. Soph, gonna just say it: is this okay?’

‘What?’

‘You and me getting a drink?’

‘I mean, probably not. I don’t know, God, I don’t know much of anything anymore.’

‘Rough?’

‘Got that right.’

Sophie brought her drink to her lips and sighed after taking the first sip.

‘God, I’ve needed this.’

‘How’s Lottie?’

Sophie smiled. ‘She’s okay. She with my ma tonight. A sleepover at hers.’

‘That’s nice.’

‘Yeah, my mum’s having to do a lot at the moment.’

‘Because of work?’

‘Yep. Because of work.’

As she took another sip, Jess did, too, and the silence between them was palpable. A thousand things unsaid. A thousand questions unanswered.

Lowering her glass, Sophie looked at Jess for a moment. Jess looked back, then, she rubbed her eye, something Sophie had seen her do before. It told her she couldn’t hold eye contact with her for too long: they both knew Jess was somehow involved.

‘I’m sorry about your job,’ Sophie said, redirecting the conversation that seemed to pass telepathically between them.

‘Thanks, I’m gutted, if I’m honest.’

‘What happened?’

Jess told Sophie about the man on the street, begging for forgiveness, and the other man who called her a bitch and made Eva fall.

‘It was awful for the kids. They need to be in a world that is safe. I used to be able to provide that, and I can’t anymore. Not until The Caretaker is caught.’

‘If he is caught,’ Sophie said, sighing.

‘Want to talk about it?’ Jess asked, and Sophie picked up and drank the rest of her gin. ‘I heard a fourteen-year-old was arrested.’

‘Yep. Just a stupid kid.’

‘So, a copycat.’

‘You and I both know the answer to that,’ she said, looking once more at Jess. ‘His sister was being treated badly, the kid just wanted to scare him. Could have gotten himself killed. Idiot.’

‘Think it will happen again?’ Jess asked.

‘What, someone using The Caretaker as a way to do what they want? Probably. Since February there have been hundreds of serious assaults because of what he is doing.’

‘I mean, think he will come again?’

‘You know more than me.’

‘Is that why you’re here, to find out what I know?’ Jess replied, and Sophie noticed that she didn’t deny having more information than she was letting on.

‘No.’

‘If you’re only wanting a drink to lull me into a false sense of security, like you’re undercover...’

‘Jess, no, I swear,’ Sophie said, cutting her off, noticing she spoke of being undercover. It said a lot, but she didn’t want to address any of it. ‘You’re mixed up in all this, we both know it, but that’s not why I’m here.’

‘Then why are you?’

‘Honestly, I don’t know,’ she said, taking another sip of her gin. ‘Why did you come? To try to find out what I know about the case?’

‘I don’t want to think about The Caretaker ever again. I just wanted a drink with someone I like.’

‘Me too,’ Sophie said. ‘I’m not trying to trap you.’

‘And I’m not trying to work out what you know. I am maybe trying to get drunk, though.’

Finishing their glasses, Jess went to the bar to get the second round, and Sophie watched her. When she first met Jess Pendle, Jess had been scared, lost, but the woman who waited and ordered from the bar was anything other than those things. She stood like a woman who knew who she was. She commanded her space at the bar, and no one invaded it. It was like people subconsciously knew she wasn't someone to mess with.

The Caretaker leapt to mind once more.

When Jess returned, they drank and chatted, mostly about Lottie and about what Jess would do for work now. They spoke of their favourite films, agreeing that *The Green Mile* might be the best book-to-film translation ever, and Sophie enjoyed how there was nothing about work, or Karl, or anything that was heavy. It was light, fun, welcomed. Sophie spoke of her childhood, sharing stories of when she got into trouble. Jess told her of a particularly embarrassing moment where she, in front of the whole of the school, flashed her knickers and Sophie laughed so much she snorted and attracted the attention of people around them. Jess didn't react like she had noticed. But Sophie knew she must have heard it. She couldn't remember a time when she'd laughed like that. It almost felt brand new.

As the second drink was finished, Sophie felt a little buzz and, risking one more, she went to the bar.

As she approached, the barman smiled her way. 'Same again?'

'Please.'

'You look like you're having fun.'

'Thanks, sometimes it's nice to let your hair down.'

'Absolutely, seems first date is going well.'

'Huh?' Sophie said.

'Shit, sorry, I assumed you were on a date.'

'Why?' she asked genuinely intrigued.

'Been doing this for a few years now, tend to be able to spot a first date: awkward start, then as both relax it either goes worse, which is like car-

crash TV, or like you two, it turns into something that makes people smile.’

‘Thanks.’

‘Good luck.’

After he handed her the drinks and she paid, Sophie walked back to Jess, who looked at ease. She thanked Sophie for the drink, holding her eye, and Sophie realised there was a fondness for Jess, something more maybe, and by the way Jess looked back, it might be reciprocated.

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Chapter Forty-Three

JESS

Today was the day the four of us, the original group, were going to be together for more than a quick drink, coffee or support group session in months. And despite knowing the retreat would be centred around grief, acceptance, and of course The Caretaker, I couldn't wait. We needed it, the break, the reconnection. For Madison, if anything. We had spoken more since she turned up in tears and slept on my lap, but it wasn't like before and I wanted that version of her back again. However, even knowing I was going to be with my girls in a posh manor, being treated like I was in a five-star resort, I couldn't stop thinking about Sophie. The evening with her was lovely, relaxed, fun. But it wasn't that. I couldn't switch off, because I had gotten a little drunk, and I worried I had said something that would give Sophie proof of my involvement in The Caretaker case. Suspecting was one thing. I hoped I hadn't messed that up.

Meeting up with her did ease the ache I had in my belly about Will and Eva. Grief was a funny thing: it would come for me about potentially never seeing them again, despite Jenny and I wanting it. Life was funny sometimes. Good old Alanis Morissette.

But it was now three days since my drink with Sophie. If I had slipped up, I would know by now. We'd messaged a little, but nothing more than to

say it was a good night and we should do it again sometime soon. It wouldn't be for a while, though: I knew what was coming for her.

Slough was coming.

But as I checked my travel suitcase one more time, I knew Slough and even Sophie weren't my focus, nor was my job which I knew I would always grieve for. My immediate concern was the retreat in Norfolk, four months, almost to the day, after that stormy night when we met Kimberley and discovered she, with a handful of others, knew the truth. The four of us, the founding members, were to meet many other women like us, who were trying to find a way through, and so I emptied my case and repacked it, ensuring I had chargers and make-up and toiletries. Enough clothes, underwear, swimwear, too, and then, zipping it back up, I refitted my doorbell camera, which I had recharged, and triple-checked that electricals were unplugged. Then, happy my home was secure for a few days, I took my case, loaded it in my car and headed to Kelly's.

I was first to arrive for a change and, after hugging my friend, we put my case in the back of her larger car and waited for the others.

'Feel like we've not hung out in ages,' Kelly said.

'I know. I'm sorry.'

'Nothing to be sorry for, it's just life. When this all calms down, we will be able to see each other all the time, without watchful eyes like Salam's.'

'Yeah,' I said, knowing my moment to come clean about where I had been a few nights before was now. But I didn't.

As we chatted about life, catching up, Hannah arrived, and we loaded her things, waiting for Madison to join us. After ten minutes, she still hadn't arrived, and Kelly called her. I could tell straight away what Madison said, even though I couldn't hear the call. She hadn't come to the support group the day before, nor for coffee after. And then Kelly confirmed what I already knew.

'Mads isn't coming.'

‘Oh no, why not?’ Hannah asked.

‘Not feeling well.’

‘Okay,’ I said. ‘We can’t cancel again, can we?’

‘No, it wouldn’t be right,’ Kelly said. ‘Looks like it’s just us three.’

‘Does that make us shit friends?’ Hannah asked.

‘No,’ Kelly replied, but unconvincingly.

Climbing into Kelly’s car, I sat in the back, and as we left, we did so in silence. It should have been the four of us together, and Madison not coming made me feel like I was being disloyal to her. But this was bigger than just us, there would be women waiting for our arrival, hoping we could bring peace, or courage, or calm, or rage, to enable them to be who they needed to be. But I was painfully aware as we headed east towards the Norfolk coast, I hadn’t actually been The Caretaker, I hadn’t delivered that final blow. I hadn’t ended a life. If anyone should be missing this, it was me, not Madison.

As Kelly ate up the miles, I watched the world go by and remembered how we drove, excited and joking, to that first retreat Kimberley had invited us to. We had achieved our goal. The Caretaker was gone and we were all free. That night, everything and anything was possible.

As the larger roads gave way to narrower, until we were driving on lanes, I wondered how many women there would be. And then the house came into view. A grand manor, haunted and ageing and full of our secrets.

Getting out of the car, I noticed how many others were parked. Hannah did too.

‘Busier than on our last visit,’ she said.

‘Yeah,’ I agreed, grabbing my bag and heading through the parked cars towards the house. As we approached the pillar that sheltered the entrance, the massive oak door opened and Kimberley was there. Déjà vu, if it wasn’t for the fact it was not blowing a gale this time. And Madison, of course.

‘Welcome. How was the journey?’

‘It was good,’ Kelly said. ‘No Madison, I’m afraid.’

‘I can see. Come in.’

As she gestured us inside into a wide area with high ceilings, a spiral staircase and baby grand piano in the corner, we all commented on how magnificent it was. She brushed it off, and I wondered, did she have a similar set-up at home herself? She had an air of wealth about her.

‘I know you want to get settled into your rooms, but we have a lot of women who are dying to meet you. Can you come say a quick hello? Then I’ll show you where to unpack and freshen up.’

‘How many are here?’ I asked.

‘Quite a few.’

‘And do they all know, about, you know?’ Hannah asked.

‘Some do. Most don’t. Some here tonight have done their part, either on the frontline or supporting, some are waiting for their turn, but a lot of these women here are just women needing hope. That’s you,’ Kimberley said, and as much as it was amazing that so much had happened in such a short space of time, I couldn’t help but worry, the more who knew, the more who were keen to become him, the more damage could be done. A fourteen-year-old could have gotten really badly hurt, or worse, and what then? Would this still be justified? Also, her saying frontline, I had to wonder, when did it become a war?

‘Let’s go say hello,’ Kimberley said, walking into the main room where our secret was first shared with her and a handful of others, but unlike before when there were only six others waiting, the amount of faces looking our way must have been tenfold.

‘Jesus,’ Kelly said, and a few of the women laughed.

‘Ladies, I’m delighted to introduce Kelly, Hannah and Jess, three of the four “saved”.’

There was applause. It lasted for several minutes and, as the women clapped, I looked to Hannah and Kelly who were as stunned as I was.

Glancing into the crowd, I saw a familiar face, Geeta, who I'd spoken in detail with that night, after it was clear she knew all of our secrets. She nodded my way, I then looked at a woman I had never met before, and she nodded too. Whoever she was, she carried that same weight in her eyes as Kelly, Hannah and Madison had. I have always been able to spot a victim of domestic violence; now I knew the look of a killer.

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Chapter Forty-Four

SOPHIE SALAM

She had wanted and dreaded the moment Karl messaged on the burner. Wanted, so she could deal with him somehow, and dreaded because of not knowing the extent of his demands.

The wait was over as he had finally responded, days after she had confirmed she had received the message from Pete to get in touch. The message coming to her as she drove to work, she read it at a set of traffic lights a mile or so from her office. It was direct, no nonsense. He didn't wonder how she was, muse on her comings and goings, he just listed his demands. She wasn't anything other than something he could use.

I need you to find a man for me. Rob Mosley. Need his address, next of kin, car registration, everything you people have on him.

She wanted to ask why, but knew better. You didn't question Kendrick, and really, as much as she knew, whoever Rob Mosley was, he would be in trouble if Kendrick wanted him, she needed to keep Lottie safe, like she did that night in February when she was just a bean in her womb. She simply messaged back.

Give me a few hours, and then we're even.

Not quite.

A few hours was plenty of time to search Mosley's name and copy everything about him in a series of pictures for Kendrick.

It was illegal, immoral, and she had no doubt there would be consequences for her soul, but saying no wasn't an option. She knew it. Kendrick did too.

Arriving at work, Sophie entered from the rear, wanting to avoid people as much as possible until she had done as Karl asked. She didn't want it looming over her whole work day. Get it done, send it his way, lock that part of her mind behind a vault-like door. She knew she could: she had done it before.

Moving along the back corridors of the station, past archives and the server room where the computers that drove the entire force whirled away relentlessly, she hit the stairs and approached her desk from the back of the office. She hoped no one would notice her, but someone did. Jones looked up from his desk.

'Morning, DS Salam,' he said, giving a knowing smile.

'Jones,' she replied, not breaking her stride, hoping she didn't appear rattled by seeing him. There was something about him she couldn't quite place. It had always been there, but since he was accosted by The Caretaker, she felt even more unsure around him.

Arriving at her desk, thankful for its positioning which meant no one could see what she was doing, she logged in, and quickly searched the name Kendrick instructed.

Robert Mosley was forty-four and his appearance, being one of wild hair and an open face, suggested he was a decent man. A clever man. The list of crimes he was connected to quickly said looks can be deceiving. Mosley had been investigated several times for embezzlement and laundering, but despite him being arrested on three occasions for such offences, he had never faced justice. Perhaps looks weren't as deceiving as

she thought. Looking at the investigation around him, she couldn't see a link between this man and Kendrick. There had to be one of course, or Kendrick wouldn't be interested. She wondered if maybe Karl had money stashed somewhere, maybe with Mosley, and needed his help in freeing it up before he was paroled.

Whatever the reason wasn't her business. Keeping herself and Lottie safe was. So despite not wanting to, and knowing it was not only morally wrong, but illegal, Sophie pulled her burner out of her bag and, checking no one was nearby, she took photos of her screen, giving Kendrick Mosley's last known address, list of investigations, registered cars. She loaded all of them into one message thread, and with her heart beginning to pound, adrenaline and fear driving it forward so fast she felt light-headed, she hit send.

Dropping the phone like it was too hot to hold, Sophie covered her mouth, stifling the cry that wanted to fall from it. She had stepped over the line, again, something she'd vowed to never do.

'DS Salam?' A voice came from behind her, and snapping around, she looked up to see her DI, Hawkins, stood by her.

'Sir,' she said, getting to her feet.

'Are you all right?'

'Fine, sir.'

'Want to explain why you have missed another staff briefing?'

Sophie looked at her watch, saw the time and realised she had completely forgotten about the team meeting.

'I, um, I was following leads, I lost track of time,' she said, not wanting to look behind her to make sure her screen couldn't be seen.

'And last week's?'

'Last week's, sir?'

'Team briefing on the sixth. You are zero for two now, Salam. This police thing only really works if we do it together.'

‘Yes, sir.’

‘Questions are being raised too.’

‘Questions, sir?’

‘You have started strong, but of late, there isn’t the same level of proactivity. As lead investigator, I would expect you to be out talking to the families more. Finding connections. I understand you’ve been to every crime scene. But where is the follow-up?’

‘I am following up, sir, I’m not just making a big song and dance of it. I have leads, but I don’t want to rush like we did with the first arrest we made,’ Sophie said, hoping her excuse acted as a distraction from the truth, which was she wasn’t doing as much as she should be, and she knew it.

‘I’m not criticising, I’m just informing you of whisperings.’

‘I appreciate that, sir.’

‘I was, however, informed that on the day you missed our team briefing you were at HMP Woodhill. Want to explain why?’

Sophie’s mind raced. Someone knew she had gone to see Karl, and she didn’t know who. She had checked into the prison as herself but, unless someone was keeping tabs, there would be no reason for it to be flagged back to the DI.

‘I was following up a lead. It was a dead end, sir.’

‘Stay on track, DS Salam. Don’t let this thing steam-roll over you. There were several who wanted to be lead on this case, don’t make me regret choosing you.’

‘Yes, sir.’

‘And Sophie,’ he said, his tone softening. ‘Get some rest, you look tired.’

‘I’m okay, sir.’

He held her eye questioningly a second longer than she would have liked, before nodding and walking away.

Confident he wouldn't return, Sophie turned and closed down the open screen with Mosley on it, thankful he didn't press her into showing him what lead she was following. Then, with the screen black once more, she looked over her partition to see where he was. He was gone, back in his office, but across the office Jones stood, smiling her way.

He hated she had been assigned the case, and it seemed he was trying to derail her. Someone was keeping tabs on her movements, and she was pretty sure she knew who it was.

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Chapter Forty-Five

JESS

After the initial overwhelm of so many women waiting for our arrival eased, the three of us mingled for a while, shook hands and said hello to those in the room we had met before, then we were shown our rooms where we freshened up before the first evening meal and conversation. We each had our own room and private shower, but ended up all getting ready in my room, chatting about everything and anything other than the fact tonight was much bigger than we'd anticipated. We tried to FaceTime Madison, too, but she didn't answer.

'Anyone else getting worried?' Hannah asked.

'She'll be okay,' Kelly replied, but I could tell she was just as concerned.

Not wanting to, but having to push thoughts of Madison away, we got to work. Just as before, Kimberley laid on a five-star service. Only this time the meal wasn't in the same dining room: a marquee had been placed in the grounds of the manor, a sprawling wild land mostly consisting of marsh and bog and tree that was protected for the RSPB, and that led via a coastal path directly to the sea. As we ate food that tasted amazing but I couldn't pronounce, Kimberley discussed our survival, the road to inner peace and, as dessert was served, some of the ladies asked us questions about life after being saved. The wine kept coming, the conversations freeing up, and by

the time dinner had been cleared and the sun started to dip, I was relaxed and slightly drunk. Some of the women retired for the night, some drifted off for a sunset walk, and Kimberley asked us to join her in the study. We said our farewells, stating we, too, would get some sleep after, and headed with her through the entrance of the manor to the downstairs study where our secrets had been spilt before. I expected Kimberley simply wanted a moment to update us like she had done when she visited the support group. A quiet circle, telling us how close she was to getting the law changed. I wondered if she might even say it was over, that Esme's law, as we were now calling it, had been passed and we had created lasting change forever. But, as we entered the study, a handful of women sat waiting, Geeta one of them. Another was from that night in March, but the rest were new. They were poised, expectant, and much like in March, I felt uncomfortable and anxious at the energy in the room.

'Kimberley, what's going on?' I asked.

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Chapter Forty-Six

THE CARETAKER

The little blue book arrived in Slough five days before the planned event to ensure another was ‘saved’. It had been read, reread, almost committed to memory, and then the newest Caretaker added to it, with the target for his kill, who he was, and why he was to be the next to have a visit from him.

Kevin Henderson had not only hurt one woman, he had hurt many. Able to hide in plain sight because of dating apps like Tinder, he had systematically targeted vulnerable women, abused them financially, and ditched them. His latest, a member of the network, was emotionally abused into aborting his baby when she fell pregnant. The pain, both physically and emotionally, she’d had to endure wouldn’t go unpunished.

In the manifesto, point 4 was specifically for this network member:

When someone removes choice from another person repeatedly and deliberately, they are not exercising freedom, they are extinguishing it.

He had forced her to have her insides twisted and her unborn baby to never take a first breath. He removed her choice, refusing to allow her to decide for herself. He would feel his insides twist in return, courtesy of a zombie knife found online for a lot less money than anticipated. Not that the cost mattered per se: the network was large, funded, meticulously organised. The Caretaker drew strength from knowing he was part of something massive, a calling, a movement.

Before he'd started to work on profiling his target, The Caretaker hadn't visited George Green. It was a small village on the outskirts of Slough. It had the vibe of north London, and showed its scars of being once somewhere with troubles. Now, it was an expensive suburb. Hard-working, but still capable of its hidden, more violent past. The Caretaker, under the guise of forty-four-year-old mother of two, Claire Michaels, had been in George Green a lot since answering the call to help create change. He had spent his time there watching Kevin, noting his comings and goings. He worked in Slough town centre, waiting in a fast-food chain, and came home on the bus anytime between 10pm and 11pm most days. The science wasn't exact, not like with previous Caretakers, but he had enough. He had his address, he had walked the way Kevin would walk countless times, and he knew exactly where he would attack. A hundred yards from his front door, Kevin would walk through a narrow pathway with a few houses either side. It wasn't perfect, it wasn't as secluded as it could have been, but it would work. This Caretaker was going to work fast, strike hard, no warning, no conversation. He wanted him dispatched quickly.

The Caretaker arrived in George Green for the final time with an hour to spare, and in that hour he paced, a caged lion, wanting to kill, wanting to be free. The day morphed into night, a warm and cloying one that meant the dark top The Caretaker wore became stuck to his back. The gloves he wore were slippery with sweat and the size ten wellies looked ridiculous if anyone was to glance at his feet. But people didn't. No one cared about the woman dressed for winter: everyone had their own things. And he needed that. The knife felt like a beacon in his inside coat pocket. He wanted to change into something lighter, cooler. But he wouldn't. He needed to prevent DNA transfer, like the blue book said. He needed to get away with it, like he always did.

The buses became few and far between, but each one snapped The Caretaker into an alert state. Then, just as he began to believe he had failed

and Henderson had changed his plans, another bus pulled up, and the twenty-six-year-old stepped off.

The Caretaker's pulse quickened.

It was time.

He wanted to leap, charge at him straight away and get it over with, but there were other people around. What he needed to do would scar them for life. And maybe someone would attempt to stop him. The Caretaker had divided the country into two camps. Kevin Henderson wasn't about to become someone who could be saved. He needed to die for what he had done.

As Henderson walked away from the bus stop, lighting a joint as he did, he passed so close that the pungent, sweet smell wafted in The Caretaker's direction. He was so close, striking was an option, but The Caretaker held back. In the little blue book, there was a recalled reflection from one of the originals, one of the founding members who with the aid of a scribe replayed their experiences. Early on, before the first was killed, there was warning given in the form of a beating. The reflection spoke about following a target, even losing sight of him, but it not mattering because she knew exactly where he was going. He was a creature of habit. They all were. So, The Caretaker waited until his target could barely be seen, and then set off to ambush. The gap between them shortened as Henderson turned off the main road onto a smaller lane that would snake around the outside of the village, before he turned down the long, narrow path where he would die. As the path began to bank, a long sweeping trail wrapped around the back of a housing estate, he vanished from sight a few times and, each time, The Caretaker broke into a small jog to close that gap. The sound of his clunky footwear the only thing permeating the sound of summer crickets chirping into the night.

His target turned onto the narrower path, and The Caretaker acted quickly, pulling a beanie hat over his sweaty head and donning a face mask

to fully become the man all bad men feared.

Once the image was complete, he removed the knife with the six-inch serrated blade and moved quickly to a wall which marked the corner onto the isolated path. On that path, he could hear Henderson's footsteps walking away. He was close, and oblivious that he was about to be killed. Taking measured breaths, The Caretaker centred himself.

Running around the corner, he sprinted along the path, wanting to strike hard and fast like he planned. But as he ran, Kevin Henderson was nowhere to be seen. The Caretaker turned back on himself, just in time to see the fist flying towards his face. The blow was hard, sending him stumbling, but he corrected himself and lunged towards Henderson with the knife. Henderson dodged, grabbed the arm holding the knife and the two began to grapple. The Caretaker panicked. He had planned, prepared to kill, but hadn't ever been in a fight before and, despite training for this moment, The Caretaker was powerless to stop the intended victim as he overpowered him and turned the knife, stabbing The Caretaker before running away.

Stunned, Claire didn't know what to do. She couldn't be caught so, despite the pain, she turned and ran in the other direction. Towards her waiting car, to take her as far away from there as possible.

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Chapter Forty-Seven

JESS

In the smaller, more secluded room, the women looked at us expectantly as Kimberley asked us to take a seat, and then she closed the door, sealing us in.

‘I assume you all know?’ Kelly said, and each woman nodded in turn.

‘I think some of you have been him already?’ I said, looking at the woman I didn’t know.

‘Bolton,’ she said.

‘I see.’

‘I was Cambridge,’ said another woman, younger than us but carrying that same look as I saw in my friends.

‘We just wanted to have a moment,’ Kimberley said. ‘Just us who have been him and those who are set to be him.’

‘About what?’ I asked.

‘About how to cope with it all,’ Geeta said. ‘When we met, I said I couldn’t go home, but I had to because I need to hide in plain sight, like you taught us.’

‘No, Geeta, we didn’t mean—’

‘It’s okay. I’ll be free soon. The Caretaker will visit my husband.’

‘Someone here?’

‘No,’ Kimberley said. ‘Some couldn’t make it tonight.’

‘I see. Like Slough?’

‘Exactly.’

‘When is Slough?’

She looked at her watch, and when she looked back I could see concern in her eyes. ‘Soon, maybe right now. But let’s focus on why we are here. Slough is ready. She will be okay. Ladies, we really want to talk about coping.’

‘Since I was him,’ the woman followed on, ‘I have had these awful dreams.’

I nodded, Kelly did, too, and then Hannah began to talk about her nightmares, how they were sometimes there when she was awake. She spoke of hearing his voice at funny times in the day, how she felt haunted, things Kelly and I didn’t know.

‘Hannah?’ I said. ‘You should have mentioned this to us.’

‘We all carry it, though, this is just my way.’

‘But we are a group. We are supposed to lean,’ Kelly said.

‘You’re right, I’m sorry,’ she replied. ‘Ladies, being him, it isn’t easy. But it will be okay.’

‘I guess what we all want to know is, how do you cope with the sudden change, the grief, and the dreams?’ Geeta asked.

I wanted to speak, but in that moment I had no authority to. These women were talking about the aftermath of committing murder, of seeing it through, and I had only worn the mask. I hadn’t pulled that metaphorical trigger, I hadn’t taken a life to free another. So, I sat back and listened as Kelly talked of the bigger picture, the lives changed, the conversations had at the House of Commons, laws being passed to give more protection. People coming forward, no longer feeling shame for being a victim of domestic violence.

‘Ladies, there is no doubt The Caretaker is a monster,’ Kelly said. ‘He was crafted out of the worst attributes in all of our partners. He had my ex’s

temper, Madison's ex's power.'

'And my ex's love of violence,' Hannah added.

'And Jess?' one asked.

'I wasn't an original, I joined later,' I said quietly.

'The Caretaker won't ever leave you,' Kelly continued.' He can't, because he needs to always exist, somewhere, to ensure future generations are saved. I have to be honest, the price is high, but as long as the big picture stays in place, as long as you lean on those around you, your own support groups, this network, you will find peace.'

'Have you found peace?' Cambridge asked.

'Almost,' Kelly said. 'It's been hard, but I'm nearly there.'

The group talked about all of the positive things since Kelly, Hannah, Madison and then I became the man bad men feared. Then there was a knock on the door, and three women who weren't part of the network came in. They noticed we stopped talking, but when Geeta wiped a tear they understood, this was a small support group session.

'I'm so sorry, have we interrupted?' one of the women said, an older lady, similar age to my mum. Which was somehow more upsetting to me.

'Not at all, we were just wrapping up,' Kimberley said and, as she stood to tend to the needs of the three who entered, we began to drift. Meeting adjourned, support offered. The Caretakers, new and old, retired for the night.

As we drifted to our rooms, we stopped outside my bedroom door, and I hugged my friends goodnight.

'See you tomorrow?'

'I can't wait. Maybe Madison will join us?' Hannah asked, hope in her voice.

'If she wants to, I'll go back and get her,' Kelly said.

'I'd come too,' Hannah said.

‘And me. If we all turned up tomorrow morning, I think she’d come back with us.’

‘Okay, first thing, let’s go get our girl.’

Giving them a final hug, I closed my door and locked myself in my room, before I flopped on the bed, feeling like a fraud for being one of ‘the saved’ without doing any of the heavy lifting. But that wasn’t my most pressing thought. Kelly said she had almost healed from her time being The Caretaker. It was clear Hannah was in a similar place too.

I wondered how far along that road Madison was. Tomorrow, we would get her, bring her back to this beautiful place, and we would help her begin.

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Chapter Forty-Eight

THE NETWORK GROUP CHAT

B3LLADONNA

Have you heard anything from Slough????

REDSHADEKIMBA

Nothing.

THESUNMAID

Shouldn't it be done by now?

B3LLADONNA

Yeah. It should have been done an hour ago.

THESUNMAID

Is the network supervisor here?

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

I'm here. Trying to find Slough now.

NORTHERNUPROAR

Has anyone looked on social media for anything?

CAPABLESALAMANDER

I'm looking as we speak.

REDSHADEKIMBA

Slough, are you seeing this? Need you to check in please.

CAPABLESALAMANDER

I've found something. A woman has been found.

REDSHADEKIMBA

What do you mean found?

CAPABLESALAMANDER

It says a woman has been found. She's been stabbed.

RADIOACTIVE-CAT2911

What?

CAPABLESALAMANDER

Says she died at the scene.

B3LLADONNA

Shit. It has to be her, doesn't it?

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

We have planned for this. @Redacteduser, retrieve the book.

REDACTEDUSER

On it.

CAPABLESALAMANDER

Are we even sure it's her?

INTH3SHADOWS

It's her. It has to be.

Costa-lover777 has left the group.

NO-ONE.HOME

I thought no one was meant to get hurt, no one but bad men, that's what we all signed up for. @networksupervisor, what are we going to do?

NORTHERNUPROAR

Shit, Costa-lover777 has left.

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

Everyone calm down. The book will be retrieved. The work continues.

Chapter Forty-Nine

SOPHIE SALAM

As she drove, Clarke sat beside her, sipping his coffee and struggling to wake up. Sophie reflected on how much she hated being away from Lottie. She always felt that guilt that she wasn't present enough, and sometimes, she felt like she was failing as a mother. But bills need to be paid, and the life she had was the only one she knew. She had justified it a thousand times before: if not a detective, she would be doing something else, and equally not with Lottie because that was how the world worked for single parents. The juggle, the spinning of plates, it wasn't ever going to be easy. So she justified the job, because there was nothing else she could do. It paid well enough to cover bills and give Lottie treats, and the pension plan was solid. The distance she was travelling, however, was her choice. When she agreed to head up The Caretaker task force, the idea of the career potential for her and her daughter blinded her to the reality that saying yes would mean. She would be dragged here, there and everywhere with it.

And with Karl added into the mix, plates were beginning to fall.

'Penny for them?' Clarke asked, noticing she was a million miles away.

'Nothing, just tired.'

'Yep.' He yawned.

'Missing Lottie.'

'Yep,' he said again, this time focused on her. 'Wanna talk about it?'

‘No, no, it’s okay,’ she replied, focusing on the road ahead. ‘Did Bolton find anyone with a DNA match to our hair?’

‘They did, it belonged to a Tinder date of his.’

‘Has she got an alibi?’

‘Airtight. She was just a one-night thing.’

‘Okay. Dead end.’

‘Yep, dead end. Again. Seems when we think we’ve found a line of inquiry, it quickly vanishes.’

‘Yep,’ Sophie said.

‘Reckon it’s him in Slough?’

‘Maybe. I don’t know if this is genuine, or another Devon.’

‘What if it is genuine?’

‘We’ll know soon enough,’ Sophie said.

Clarke nodded, returned to his coffee, and the pair continued in silence until they arrived at the scene. Parking the car, Sophie looked at the horizon. Dawn was beginning to show, a pinkish-red sky that was beautiful but, if old folk tales were to be believed, was loaded.

‘Red sky in morning,’ Sophie said.

‘Yeah, I got that,’ Clarke said.

Like with Bolton, a white tent had been erected over the site, hiding the body from prying eyes and allowing the forensics to work and gather evidence. There was a sense of déjà vu to it all, same tent, same milling police officers and forensic photographers. Same whisperings of The Caretaker. Only these whisperings were charged, confused. At first, she didn’t understand why.

Approaching the tent, she was ushered under the police tape, and then was greeted by the lead forensic officer who introduced himself as Max before he briefed her and Clarke on the scene.

‘Victim was found by a dog-walker. She was trying to walk to a car apparently. But bled out here,’ he said.

‘This isn’t where she was stabbed?’ Sophie asked.

‘No, she was stumbling from that way.’ Max said, pointing behind Sophie.

‘Okay, what do we know?’

‘Only that she was found walking, the knife stuck in her side. Big knife, one of those nasty zombie ones designed to do a lot of internal damage.’

‘Who makes these things?’ Sophie said.

‘It’s a fucked-up world, ma’am. She was muttering about being sorry, and dropped down.’

‘Okay, so, how does The Caretaker fit in all this?’

‘We got a call just after she was found, a man crying, saying he had just stabbed The Caretaker in self-defence.’

‘Right,’ Sophie said. ‘Where is he?’

‘His house is in the direction she was seen walking from, about a hundred yards that way.’

‘Do we know who he is?’

‘Kevin Henderson. Young bloke, mid-twenties, says he was coming home and The Caretaker attacked him.’

‘And our victim?’

‘We are trying to find that out now. She didn’t have ID on her.’

‘Can we see her?’

‘Yeah, of course. DS Salam, do you think this really is The Caretaker? Was she always a woman?’

Sophie paused, and Clarke looked at her expectantly. ‘What do you think, Max?’

‘I think it can’t be.’

‘Exactly,’ she said, keeping her thoughts close to her chest. ‘This is like Devon, someone using The Caretaker to exact some personal vendetta.’

‘Yeah, that makes sense. The things The Caretaker has done. No way it’s a middle-aged woman,’ he said.

‘Uh-huh,’ Sophie said as she entered the tent. Before she looked at the knife, the first thing she saw was the woman’s glassy, unblinking eyes staring back at her. Sophie’s eyes trailed to the knife. Buried to the hilt in her side, it looked enormous. There wasn’t a lot of blood on the outside, the knife had plugged the wound, but if it was a zombie knife, as she had been told, the internal damage would have been extensive. She looked down at the victim’s feet.

‘Wellies,’ she said.

‘Yeah,’ Clarke replied, knowing how damning it was. ‘Right, shall we?’ he said, as he put on some latex gloves. Sophie followed suit, and the pair looked at the body. They were looking for one thing which would tell them definitely if this was The Caretaker.

‘Hey, have her pockets been searched?’ Sophie asked the forensic officer who was taking photos for evidence.

‘No, not yet.’

‘Mind if I have a look for her car keys?’

‘Knock yourself out.’

Sophie carefully began to feel the body, and it didn’t take her long to find the bulge that was a car key for a Volvo. But she didn’t stop. Checking her other pocket, she felt nothing, then as she started searching the rest of the body, she began to believe this was like Devon after all. Until she reached the wellies. Under the left, in the sock line, she felt something, and pulled it out. A surgical scalpel.

‘What on earth?’ the forensic officer said. ‘Why would she have that?’

‘Why do people do many things?’ Sophie said, standing up, handing him the scalpel. ‘Can someone show us where the man is, the one who was attacked?’

‘Yeah, sure,’ he replied, confused, following them out of the tent. ‘Um, if you head that way, another officer can guide you.’

‘Thanks,’ Sophie said, offering no explanation, and she and Clarke headed towards the house of Kevin Henderson.

‘It’s him, isn’t it?’ Clarke asked.

‘Yeah, the wellies are telling, but easy to dismiss too. The scalpel tells us as much. But the public cannot know this is the real Caretaker.’

‘Why not?’

‘Because it also isn’t, Clarke. I think The Caretaker will carry on, maybe even post a video.’

‘And if they do, then your theory is proven.’

‘Yep, even if I cannot prove who exactly they are.’

‘So we say it’s a copycat?’

‘Exactly, and when The Caretaker posts, we’ll know for sure.’

‘Sophie, have you heard of anything like this, like, ever in police history?’

‘No. But it’s clever. You heard what he just said, there’s no way a middle-aged woman could be The Caretaker. It’s brilliant. Almost the perfect crime.’

‘It’s scary,’ Clarke said, and Sophie didn’t reply, she didn’t know how to.

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Chapter Fifty

Nodding to the police officer manning the front door, Sophie stepped inside, wiping her feet before turning into the living room. Kevin Henderson sat on the edge of his sofa, his left leg shaking violently. He had the look of a man who was haunted by the actions he'd had to take.

'Kevin?' Sophie said, taking a knee in front of him, so her eyes were level with his. He looked up, his eyes rimmed red from crying. 'My name is Detective Sergeant Sophie Salam.'

'I know who you are,' he said, and she was shocked. 'You're The Caretaker copper.'

She looked at Clarke and he flashed a small, teasing smile.

'I need to ask you a few questions,' Sophie said.

Henderson nodded.

'Can you tell me what happened?'

Henderson clenched his hands together, his left foot still tapping. 'I was walking home, a long way from the bus stop.'

'Why did you walk the long way?'

'It's always quiet. I like to have a smoke before getting in, you know, wind down from the day.'

'Sure,' Sophie said, showing she wasn't about to pass judgement, so he would relax more.

‘I could sense someone was following me. I sped up, and they did too.’

‘What did they look like?’

‘Dressed in black. Long sleeves. It’s too hot for that. When I saw the gloves, I knew it was him.’

‘Who?’

‘The Caretaker. Look, I know I’m a shitty boyfriend. I get jealous, you know, I make mistakes. I will try harder, you know, I will do better.’

‘You were followed?’ Sophie asked as she got up from the floor and sat beside him on the sofa.

‘Yeah, yeah, I ran a bit, down the alley towards here. I hid behind a wall. And then I stepped out and whacked him.’

‘Why didn’t you call the police?’

‘I was going to, I mean I did, didn’t I? I rang you lot as soon as I got home. I hit him to get away. I didn’t want him following me into my home, you know what he’s done before.’

Sophie nodded. Everyone knew what The Caretaker was capable of. She looked at Clarke, who shrugged slightly. This man was telling the truth.

‘Then what happened?’

‘He pulled a knife, he was going to kill me. I don’t know what happened, I didn’t mean to stab him. I swear. I just ... it was self-defence. Oh God, am I going to prison?’

‘Kevin, calm down,’ Sophie said.

‘After, I ran home and called the police. Is he, I mean— Did he...’ He trailed off.

‘Yes,’ Sophie said, and then watched as Kevin burst into tears.

‘Oh God, I don’t want to go to prison,’ he cried.

Standing up, her legs aching, she walked away, and Clarke followed. They didn’t speak until they were outside and the cries of Kevin Henderson had faded.

‘Self-defence?’ Clarke asked.

‘Yep. He’ll need to be interviewed, but that’s not for us. I want to know who she was.’

‘We will have to wait.’

‘I’ve got her car key. I reckon we should find it.’

‘Sophie Salam, The Caretaker Copper, you sneak,’ Clarke said.

‘That name better not stick.’

Walking along the quiet streets of George Green, Sophie and Clarke looked for Volvos, and when they found one, Sophie used the remote key to try to open it. After several failed attempts, the indicator lights of an SUV flashed.

‘Bingo.’

Approaching, Sophie pulled on a fresh pair of gloves, and flicking on a torch, she shone the light inside. ‘Shit.’

‘What?’ Clarke asked.

‘Car seats,’ she said, looking in the back of the car. Not baby ones, they were for small children. Younger than ten. ‘She’s a mum.’

‘Oh no,’ Clarke said. ‘What the fuck was she thinking?’

‘These women are desperate.’

Sophie gently opened the car door, so as not to disturb any critical evidence, and shining the torch, she looked for a handbag or purse. She opened the glove box and found what she was looking for.

Removing the purse, Clarke stood close and pointed his torch so Sophie could free her other hand, and she carefully removed the driving licence.

‘Mrs Claire Michaels.’

‘Heard the name before?’ Clarke asked.

‘No. Her address is in Norwich.’

‘Norwich, what the hell is she doing here?’

‘I don’t know,’ she said, pulling out her phone.

‘Who are you calling?’

‘Norwich police station,’ she said, before talking into the phone, stating who she was, giving an address and waiting to be connected to a detective who could help. What she was told confused her and, after the call, she looked into the distance, trying to piece it together.

‘Soph? What’s up?’

‘So, the address, turns out police are already there.’

‘What, how?’

‘The house has been broken into. Windows smashed, but apparently nothing was stolen.’

‘So, the woman who is killed, her home is broken into only hours later. Before anyone knew she was the victim?’

‘Yep.’

‘Can’t be a coincidence. What the fuck is going on?’ Clarke said.

‘I wish I knew.’

As she and Clarke made their way back to the scene to hand back the car key and tell the detective in charge where the car was, they barely spoke. A woman was dead, her home was pretty much simultaneously broken into and, although it was reported nothing had been taken, Sophie knew something must have been. She was in Slough, but her house was over a hundred miles away. The last Caretaker killed just over two hundred miles further north. This thing was too big for her, it was too big for everyone.

As they turned onto the path where the white tent sat, her phone vibrated and, pulling it from her pocket, she saw it was Jones. She flashed the screen to Clarke.

‘What does he want?’ he asked.

‘Let’s find out,’ she replied, not wanting to betray her fear at Jones wanting to talk. Answering the phone, she put it on loudspeaker so Clarke could hear. ‘DS Jones. Everything all right?’

‘DS Salam,’ he said, and she could tell the contempt in his voice. ‘You wanted me to keep you updated on the movement of some suspects.’

‘What have you got for me?’

‘One of their names flagged on our system this evening.’

‘Okay?’

‘They’ve been taken to hospital.’

‘What? Why?’

‘Don’t know, I’m on my way there now.’

‘Who is it? Who has been admitted?’ Sophie said, her heart beginning to gallop thinking of Jess.

‘The young one, I forget her name.’

Sophie felt a pang of relief. ‘Do we know her condition?’

‘I don’t know. I’m just doing as told,’ DS Jones replied, hanging up on her.

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Chapter Fifty-One

JESS

Waking with a start, for a moment I didn't know where I was. My first thought was that the bedroom window should have been on my right, but, as my mind swam into wakefulness, it was on my left, and then it came to me. I wasn't in my bed. I was at the retreat, I had eaten a banquet and spoken with The Caretakers. It wasn't a dream that woke me, and as far as I could tell, the manor house was silent.

Reaching for my phone to see the time, I understood why I'd startled awake. I had a missed call, from Sophie.

It was 8.19am.

Assuming it was a mistake, I put my phone down, rolled back onto my side, closed my eyes, and my phone vibrated again. Picking it up, I saw Sophie was calling once more, and I didn't answer at first. She didn't call me, she always messaged. It had to be something, but not related to The Caretaker. This was about something personal.

'Hello?' I said, keeping my voice low so not to wake either Kelly or Hannah in adjoining rooms if they were sound asleep.

'Jess. Where are you?' she said, her voice tight, afraid even.

'What's happened?'

'Are you near to home?'

'No, no, I'm at a retreat.'

‘You need to get back.’

‘Sophie, what’s happened, is it Lottie, is she okay?’

‘Lottie is fine.’

‘Why are you calling me?’

‘It’s Madison.’

‘What about her?’

‘She’s in hospital. Are Kelly and Hannah with you?’

‘Yes.’

‘You all need to come back, now.’

‘Okay, okay.’

Hanging up the phone, I got out of bed and, grabbing my dressing gown, a thin summer one Lewis bought for me before I saw his true colours, I tiptoed to Kelly’s door. I tapped on it three times and waited. I heard movement from the other side, and I paced, three small steps away from her door, three small steps back. Then Kelly emerged, dressed and with a coffee in her hand.

‘Ah, we wondered when you would wake. Hannah and I have been sat on the balcony with coffee, it’s so nice here. Come in.’

I hesitated.

‘Jess? What is it?’

Hannah, hearing Kelly’s concern, came to the door too.

‘We need to go home.’

‘What do you mean?’

‘Something’s happened to Madison.’

‘What?’

‘I don’t know, Sophie just called, said we all needed to come back.’

‘Think it’s a trap of some kind?’

I shook my head. ‘Kelly, I’m scared. We need to go home.’

Chapter Fifty-Two

After the longest two hours of our lives, hours filled with unanswerable questions, theories of what was going on and desperately trying to reach Madison, to no avail, we arrived at the hospital. The car had barely rolled to a stop in the parking space and we were out, heading towards the main entrance, where, after asking for her, we were quickly directed towards the intensive care unit.

‘Intensive care?’ Hannah said, trying to hold back her tears. ‘What does that mean?’

‘It means she is in the best hands,’ Kelly said, trying to sound positive. But I heard the fear in her voice.

‘What’s happened, an accident? Has someone got to her? Does someone know? Jess, what did Sophie tell you?’

‘Nothing, only we needed to get back.’

‘Is she here?’ Kelly asked.

‘I don’t know.’

‘Oh God, what’s happened?’ Hannah asked again, needing answers.

Kelly snapped. ‘Calm down, it’s not going to help. Let’s just go and see our friend and show her we love her, okay?’

Hannah nodded, and reached for my hand. I took it, squeezed it and I didn’t let go.

Up two flights of stairs and down a long, quiet corridor, we arrived at the ICU, and paused. We needed to go in, make sure our friend, the fourth member of our sisterhood, was okay. But we were paralysed by fear. Three of the four Caretakers, capable of anything, stopped by a single door.

‘Come on,’ I said, being the first to open the door and walk onto the ward.

Ahead of us was a small reception area with one bleary-eyed middle-aged man at the desk. And as we got closer, he looked up.

‘She’s in room four,’ he said quietly.

‘How do you know who we are here to see?’

‘Everyone knows who you are. Room four,’ he said, watching us as we walked around the desk towards the numbered rooms.

The question whether Sophie Salam was here was quickly answered. She wasn’t, but standing in the corridor outside room four was another police officer we all knew: Jones. He didn’t speak, barely looked at us until he could feel me daring him to, and when he did look, I was sure I saw a flicker of disdain shoot back.

Inside room four there was a woman, an older version of Madison, sat in a chair looking at the only bed in the room. And in the bed, tubes up her nose, in her arms, cables running from under her hospital gown, was Madison.

I stared at her, it was definitely Madison, only it wasn’t also: she was hollow, wax-like, a cheap museum mannequin. The light and life in her gone. Without being told, I could see our friend was in serious trouble. The woman looked up at us, a sad smile forming on her mouth.

‘You must be Hannah, Kelly and Jess.’

‘Yes,’ Hannah said, barely able to hold it together to form the word.

‘Thank you for coming,’ she said, her soul hurting in her voice. ‘She loves you three. So much.’

‘We love her too,’ Kelly said, going to Madison’s mother’s side.

‘She’s tried, you know, really hard. She’s fought every single day.’

‘Fought what?’ I asked.

‘To be okay. Like you three. But it’s been too much for her.’

I was rendered speechless. I had assumed Madison had an accident, or worse, someone had hurt her, but what her mum was implying, Madison had hurt herself. Kelly sat down, and I drew closer to Madison’s mum.

‘I couldn’t reach her, all day. And I was afraid. Her boy was with me, he’s now with my sister, but he was asleep and I panicked. I rang Geoff.’

‘Geoff?’ Hannah said.

‘He has been good to this family. He’s checked in a lot on Madison in the last few weeks. I had his number. He went round for me, and he...’

As if on cue, Geoff walked into the room, holding two cups of tea. One for him, one for Madison’s mum.

‘Here you are, Julie,’ he said, handing her a cup. ‘Sorry, ladies, I didn’t know you were coming.’

I touched his arm, showing him it didn’t matter, and as he smiled at me, I could see the same look I had seen in Kelly and Hannah and Madison and the others at the retreat, and I understood. It wasn’t the look of a murderer I could see in them, it was the look of someone who had witnessed trauma first-hand.

‘Is there anything we can do?’ I asked, and Julie shook her head.

‘No, you’re here, it’s the most anyone can do.’

‘What have the doctors said?’ Kelly asked, and Julie began to cry. Geoff walked around the back of her, and stood, stoic and weathered, and stroked her back.

‘There isn’t anything they can do for her,’ he said quietly.

‘Excuse me,’ Julie said, getting up and leaving the room. A few moments later, we could hear her wailing in the corridor.

‘I’ll go to her,’ Hannah said, leaving the room.

Once she'd gone, our attention went to Madison. The heart monitor was the only suggestion she wasn't already gone. 'Geoff, what the fuck happened?' I said, unable to look away from my friend.

'I had to kick the door down, I found her in bed. She'd taken sleeping tablets.'

'How many?' Kelly said.

'Too many. I called an ambulance straight away, did what I could to get her back.'

I wanted to console Geoff, tell him something that would make him feel better, but what was there to say? Nothing would remove the image that was no doubt now burnt into his memory.

'What did Julie mean by us being here is the most anyone can do?' I asked.

'She's not coming back. The machine is the only thing keeping her heart beating and lungs breathing,' Geoff said.

Julie came back into the room, her eyes puffy and red, and she looked at me. 'I'm sorry.'

'Nothing to be sorry for,' I said.

'Will you stay, when they stop the machine?' she asked.

'Yes, of course.' The prickle of tears behind my nose wanted to come forward. 'Is her boy coming?'

She shook her head. 'No child should ever lose both parents,' she said quietly, and I looked at Kelly who lowered her head.

'The doctors said we can let her go anytime we want. Like it's something I want to do. I can't do this alone. I can't make that call.'

'Julie, I think it has to be you,' Geoff said softly.

'I'll say the final yes, but she loved you, she loved you like family. Will you say yes with me? I can't do it by myself. I can't be the one who kills her.'

Julie choked on her words, and this time I stepped forward and took her in my arms. Like with Geoff, there was nothing I could say or do, so I didn't try. I felt Hannah's arms around me, and Kelly, then Geoff, all of us hugging Julie in the centre of us, protected from harm. She began to cry once more. So hard we had to hold her up to stop her falling over. I looked at Kelly, and Hannah, and I could see they were wondering the same thing as me. We knew Madison was struggling: could we have stopped this? And the more silent yet burning question: did we cause it? Did we cause our friend to want to die?

I knew the answer to both.

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Chapter Fifty-Three

Once Julie had cried herself into exhaustion, Geoff sat her beside her daughter and, with a numbness that was too hard to look at, Julie held Madison's hand and stared at her daughter's face.

Geoff whispered something to her, and she gently nodded, a fresh tear falling, then he walked towards the door, pausing just before he left.

'I'm going to get the doctors, so we can let her rest.'

As Geoff left the room, I followed, and stopped him. Jones, who had no doubt been posted to keep watch, looked on from the end of the corridor.

'Geoff, wait.'

He paused, hesitated, then turned to face me.

'I'm sorry it was you who found her, I'm so, so sorry.'

'Rather me than any of you,' he said quietly.

'I'm here, okay, for you, like you said you were here for us.'

He nodded. 'Thank you, Jess, but I failed.'

Before I could tell him he hadn't failed at all, that it was us, he continued down the corridor past Jones. I heard Jones ask if Madison was okay. Geoff told him she would soon be gone and, after Geoff walked away, Jones looked at me. He didn't smile, but he didn't look concerned either.

'Yes?' I said.

'Nothing.' He smirked back.

If, at the beginning, when Madison first went to the police, he'd done his fucking job, maybe none of this would have happened. If he had been a proper police officer, there would have been no need for The Caretaker, and she wouldn't have wanted to die.

We were culpable for her being on life support that was about to be switched off, and we were paying for our part. Jones, however, had gotten away with a slap on the wrist in Cromer.

And he hadn't changed. Because recently, a woman named Esme had needed help, too, and she was hurt badly when he failed to act.

I wanted to tell him to fuck off, but I knew it would cause issues. So I turned, and as I walked back, I was sure I could hear him humming to himself. Piece of shit.

Back in the room, Hannah looked at me, clearly seeing I was rattled, and I gave her hand a reassuring squeeze, before turning my attention to Madison and Julie, a picture of grief and loss.

Shortly after, two doctors arrived, and saying gently that they were going to do one final check, they looked into Madison's eyes with a bright light, checked her vitals, looked at her brain activity, and then one of the doctors asked Julie if she agreed to withdrawal of treatment.

Julie didn't speak, she couldn't. But she had asked us to help, and so I spoke first.

'Yes,' I said, my voice conveying a definitiveness I hoped would translate as strength for Julie.

'I'm sorry, but it has to come from—'

'Yes,' Hannah said, crying out the word.

'Ladies, only next of—'

'Yes,' Kelly followed up.

And then Geoff said it too. 'Yes.'

'Thank you,' Julie said, looking at us all, and then to the doctor. 'This is her family.'

‘I understand, but, Mrs Bennington, for us to—’

‘Yes,’ she said. ‘Stop the treatment.’

‘Okay,’ the doctor replied.

Julie got up and stepped into Geoff’s embrace as the doctors removed the breathing tube from Madison, carefully and gently, even though she wouldn’t feel a thing. Then, when they had, they tucked her in, made her comfortable, and stepped back.

‘We’ll be outside,’ one said, before both left the room.

Geoff guided Julie back to her daughter, and sitting her in the chair, he picked up Madison’s hand and gently placed it in hers. Kelly walked behind Julie and placed a hand on her shoulder. I leant into Geoff, placing my hand on Julie’s forearm, and Hannah took my hand, and the five of us, connected, watched Madison until the heart rate monitor slowed, and then stopped.

Our darling friend, bright and young and beautiful inside and out, was gone. And I couldn’t help but realise The Caretaker had taken our Madison.

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Chapter Fifty-Four

SOPHIE SALAM

The drive back from Slough was even tougher than the one going, and by the time Sophie arrived home, she was ready for bed. The day had been long, and it was only just 2pm. She wanted nothing more than to be with Lottie, then watch the sunset out on the middle of nowhere with her girl. Watching her at peace as she listened to birds and looked at insects that they would find. Lottie needed that time, quiet reflection in nature, but Sophie probably needed it more.

Opening her front door, she kicked off her shoes and walked into the living room where Lottie sat on the floor watching cartoons on TV. Daya was sat in the armchair, two cups of coffee on the table.

Leaning in, she kissed her girl on the head. 'Hello, darling.'

'Hi, Mama,' Lottie replied, not looking away from the TV. Any proof of the recent meltdown which ended up giving Sophie a fat lip was gone. The house was calm, happy.

Sitting beside her mum in the other armchair, Sophie sunk back into it and sighed.

'You must be exhausted,' Daya said. 'Drink your coffee.'

'Thanks, Ma.'

Picking up the cup, she took a sip and sighed again, this one a content sound rather than exhausted. 'For the rest of today, I'm going to do nothing

at all.'

'Good. You need it, she needs it too.'

'We will go to a country park somewhere later, might even take a picnic dinner and stay until the sun goes down.'

Sophie smiled at her mum, but she didn't smile back. Instead her brow furrowed in concern. 'I'm worried about you, Soph.'

'It's fine, it's just work.'

'I'm not talking about work. Something is troubling you, I can tell.'

'I'm okay,' she lied, hoping it would stick. It didn't.

'You don't want to talk to me about it, that's fine, but if you change your mind I'm here.'

Sophie held her mum's eyes for a second, then gently nodded.

As Sophie drank her coffee, her work phone pinged and for a moment she wondered if it was Kendrick, but the burner had a different ping tone to her work phone, so she knew it wasn't him. Thankfully. She wanted to ignore it, to turn it off and pretend she didn't have a phone and was unreachable. But it pinged again, and she risked a look, hoping it wasn't Clarke. Jones popped into her head again: he was watching, maybe he had something to say. When she saw it was Jess, she assumed it was an update on her friend.

As she opened it, and read, she quietly spoke. 'Oh no.'

Madison has passed away. Thank you for ensuring we were all there beside her when it happened x

'All okay?' Daya asked, and Sophie shook her head.

'My, my friend, she lost someone close to her this morning.'

'Oh, I am so sorry to hear that.'

'What do I say back?'

'Just that you are here, if she wants anything.'

Nodding, Sophie tapped her phone's screen, carving out a message and, hitting send, she sat back in her chair. She sipped her coffee again, watching

Lottie watching TV. The coffee didn't taste quite so good.

Her phone pinged again, and she looked. Jess had replied.

Thank you. x

Call anytime, I'm thinking of you Jess. x

Sophie put her phone down, and desperately not wanting to cry, she took a few quiet breaths to steady herself. Lottie didn't notice, but her mum did, she always did.

'I'm sorry, love, did you know the person who passed?'

'A little. She was nice, too young. My friend is heartbroken. Hard to think about.'

'She must mean a lot to you,' Daya said, and Sophie nodded.

'She does.' She surprised herself with the admission.

Wiping her eyes, she lowered herself down to Lottie, and gave her a really big cuddle, which turned into a tickle fight, making her, Lottie and Daya laugh. When the tickle fight ended, she scooped her up, plonked her on the sofa and, inviting Daya to join them, put on a Disney film. All three engrossed in the magic, the simplicity, and the fact that they all knew good would win and everyone would end up happy. It was a fantasy, of course, but for ninety blissful minutes, it felt as real as anything else. Placing them, a little family doing its best to get by, in a little bubble. Lottie at the heart of it.

As the climax of the movie came, the final rose petal falling, suggesting all was lost before the magic kicked in, Sophie's phone pinged again, but the tone was different. It was the burner. It was Kendrick. Making sure Lottie and her mum wouldn't see the screen, she pulled out the burner, and looked. She assumed it would be about Rob Mosley, maybe him wanting more information on him. But Mosley wasn't mentioned. And the message contained only four words. Four short words which shook her foundations and popped the bubble she was in. Four words, and her world was now

forever changed. Four words that she'd fought desperately to never see or read or hear.

So, who's Lottie then?

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Chapter Fifty-Five

Daya must have noticed the colour drain from Sophie's face, as before she could lock the screen and put her phone down, her mum was asking, 'Soph? What is it? Is it your friend?'

Sophie shook her head, unable to look at her mother as she weighed up her options: she could speak to him, confess to Lottie being his daughter, or she could lie, as she had planned in the aftermath of his arrest, hoping he would believe that the little girl wasn't his.

But, before she worked out what to say to him, it was time to tell the truth to her mum.

'Sophie, what is it?' Daya asked again, shifting in her seat.

'Mum, I need to tell you something. And then I need you to do something for me.'

'Darling, you're scaring me,' Daya said, ensuring she was quiet so Lottie, who was engrossed in the movie and oblivious to her mum's distress, didn't notice.

Sophie didn't reply, but instead kissed Lottie on the head. 'Back in a minute, baby.'

She got up, and Daya followed her into the kitchen, where she stood by the table and waited.

'Sophie, what's going on?'

‘Mum, what I’m about to tell you, you cannot tell anyone, okay? It will sound bad, and I understand, but this is about Lottie. So I need you to not judge me too harshly.’

‘What is it?’

‘It’s about her dad,’ Sophie said, before she, as calmly as she could, told her mum about Karl Kendrick, how they met, what she had done when she discovered she was pregnant with his baby. She didn’t speak of that night when she witnessed Karl kill another man, she didn’t talk of her part in it. How blood was on her hands. She didn’t speak of being so in love with Lottie, so afraid of harm coming to her, she abetted in murder. She would take that to her grave.

Daya sat, covering her mouth with her hands as she listened to Sophie talking of her time as an undercover officer, and how Kendrick was Lottie’s father. And when Sophie had finished, there was a full minute of neither woman speaking.

‘Why didn’t you tell me?’ Daya eventually said, her voice even, calm, despite the tension Sophie could see in her face.

‘Because no good would come from it. Lottie is ours, Mum, and she is perfect and the past needs to stay where it is.’

‘Then why are you telling me now?’

‘Those calls, the Newcastle accent, they were him.’

‘Karl?’

‘Yes.’

‘Is this why you told me to never speak of Lottie?’

‘Yes, Ma. That man who came to visit the other day was his brother.’

‘I told him Lottie was my work, that I was a childminder.’

‘I know, Ma, thank you. But it seems Karl doesn’t quite believe it.’

‘Is this my fault?’

‘No, not at all. It’s mine. As soon as he first called, I should have dealt with him.’

‘What does he want?’

‘I visited him. He told me I’m going to help him when he is released, which is soon, so he can do what he wants, with someone in the force on his side.’

‘You told him no, right?’

‘I had to do something for him. To protect Lottie.’

‘What?’

‘Find a man.’

‘And what’s happened to that man?’

‘I dare not look. I don’t want this. If anyone discovers what I was involved in, what I did, I’ll lose Lottie.’

‘What was the man’s name?’

‘Rob Mosley.’

Daya grabbed her phone, and began typing, and Sophie watched her mother. The anger and fear was written on her face, even if her words had been softer. Sophie watched as those feeling were replaced with shock, and, before she could ask, Daya turned the screen to show an article from a small paper somewhere in the Peak District.

FEARS GROW FOR MISSING FATHER OF TWO

‘Jesus, Soph, what the fuck were you thinking?’

‘Of her, Ma, of her. Even before she was born, I loved her. I had to protect her. I’ve always needed to protect her. He knows about Lottie. He knows Lottie is my girl and I know Karl, he’ll dig and dig and dig. He would have worked out that she is likely to be his.’

‘A man is now missing.’

‘I know.’ Sophie looked at her mum across the table. ‘Mum, if he gets to her, I, I don’t know what he will do.’

‘You need to go to the police.’

‘I can’t.’

‘Why not?’

‘Because Karl has something on me, something that would take Lottie away.’

‘What, Soph?’

Sophie hesitated. She knew she needed to tell her secret. A man was now missing, likely dead, she had to come clean. But her mum would hate her, and she needed her mum, more than ever.

‘You have to trust me on this, okay?’

‘Sophie.’

‘Please, Ma, please.’

Daya looked at her daughter for a few seconds, no doubt seeing the desperation in Sophie’s eyes. ‘Okay. No police. What do you want to do?’

‘I need you and Lottie to leave.’

‘Leave?’ Daya said, leaning in so her voice could lower to a whisper. ‘What do you mean leave?’

‘I need you and her to go away from here, far away, where he cannot find you.’

‘For how long?’

‘Until I can sort this. Karl can’t get anywhere near Lottie. He can’t. Mum, I need you to protect her for me.’

‘Can’t she just come to mine?’

‘No, it won’t be safe. I need you and her to vanish. Get a little cottage somewhere. Hide.’

‘Hide? What? When?’

‘Today. I think you need to go. Karl knows of Lottie, and we both know what happened to Mosley.’

‘Shit, you don’t think he would—’

Sophie cut her mum off. ‘I don’t know what to think, other than I need you and her safe.’

‘Soph, we can’t just pack up and go somewhere, drop of a hat.’

‘You have to. I’ll get somewhere booked. Somewhere I haven’t paid for, and then you and she are to go. I’ll get new phones.’

‘Phones?’

‘I don’t want Karl being able to trace us.’

‘Sophie, listen to yourself, he is in prison, how on earth will he do—’

‘Mum, listen!’ Sophie snapped, and Daya, startled by the sudden outburst, sat back in her chair, slack-jawed. The shouting had startled Lottie, too, who came into the kitchen.

‘Mummy?’ she said, and Sophie quickly wiped her eyes, so her daughter wouldn’t see.

‘It’s okay, darling, I just jumped. That’s all.’

‘Jumped? Why?’ Lottie asked, and Sophie struggled for an answer.

‘It was a spider,’ Daya said when Sophie faltered. ‘A big one, don’t worry it’s outside.’

‘I like spiders,’ Lottie said, turning and running back to her movie.

‘Thank you,’ Sophie said when Lottie was gone. ‘I might be over-worrying, and this might feel a little extreme, but I cannot take a risk, not with her. Karl Kendrick, he isn’t like other men, he has no good. If he got hold of Lottie, if he took her...’ She trailed off, composed herself, and fought not to see all of the things Karl had done when they were together, the misery he caused, the pain that leaked out of every pore, attaching to everyone else around him. ‘She can’t have that life. I need you to do this for me.’

‘Okay. How will you get something booked without him being able to find out?’

‘I’m gonna ask a friend for help,’ Sophie said, knowing that outside the force and her mum, she had only one person she classified as a friend. ‘Go home, pack, get some cash out of an ATM, grab any money you have at

home. I'll take Lottie with me. Then, when it's done, I'll come to yours.
Okay?'

'Okay.'

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Chapter Fifty-Six

Sophie packed quickly, grabbing as many of Lottie's things as she could fit into a suitcase and her school rucksack. Clothes, bath things, toys, toiletries, teddies and her comfort blanket. She packed as much of Lottie's life as she could, knowing her daughter would need everything she had to cope with the upheaval. She would struggle, but Sophie had no choice. With her mum, she would be safe, away from harm. She would be protected from the world which Karl Kendrick lived in. Lottie needed consistency, and upheaval was hard for her to process. She hoped Mum would manage. And when she was safe, Sophie was going to try to work out a way to close this chapter of her life which would mean Karl would leave them alone and she wouldn't go to prison herself.

Somehow.

When her car was loaded with most of Lottie's things, she and her daughter made their way towards Jess's flat. Jess was grieving, she lost her friend only a few hours before, and her turning up asking for help was selfish, but she had no choice. She needed her little girl somewhere safe, and somewhere that Karl couldn't link back to her. She didn't know if he could trace credit card purchases, but he had found her number, even after changing it, he had found out where she lived, even though she wasn't on any publicly accessible database. And with limited information, he had

someone find Rob Mosley and now he was missing. She couldn't help but feel she had more blood on her hands.

Thankfully, the drive from hers to Jess's was incident-free. Lottie knew something was happening, but as her mum was calm, she didn't question beyond where they were going. She told her they were going to Nana's but first they were going to see Jess, and that was enough. But to ensure Lottie stayed calm, she played her favourite song, over and over on a loop in her car. And Lottie, holding her favourite teddy, sung along, daydreaming out of the window.

Small graces.

She just had to hope Jess was at home. She wanted to call ahead but was now paranoid he was able to track her somehow.

Stopping at a supermarket, Sophie bought two cheap phones, one for her, and one for her mum. She now had three phones: one for work, one for Karl and one for family. She was losing control and she knew it. But she pushed down the anxiety that came with acknowledging she was spiralling, and instead she got as many treats as Lottie wanted, before heading on.

'Are we at Jess's, Mummy?' Lottie asked, when Sophie pulled up and turned off the ignition.

'Yes, baby, shall we go say hello?'

Ringling the doorbell, she positioned herself so, if Jess looked on the app, she would see it was them. It seemed to work, because a few seconds later the door opened. Jess looked tired, as tired as she felt, and she, too, had been crying.

'Sophie?'

'I'm so sorry, Jess, I know I shouldn't be here.'

'Then why are you?' She looked beyond Sophie for others, police perhaps.

'I need your help,' Sophie said, and she saw something change in Jess instantly. She was concerned.

‘Is everything okay?’

‘Can we come in?’

Jess stepped back, and Sophie and Lottie stepped inside.

‘Put the TV on, darling, yeah?’

‘Okay.’ Lottie said.

‘I’ll show you where it is,’ Jess said, taking Lottie into the living room and putting on the TV, giving her the remote.

She then looked at Sophie. ‘Soph? What’s going on?’

Sophie walked into the kitchen, and Jess followed. And when they were away from Lottie, Sophie explained she needed someone to book a break for two people, Lottie and her mum, but she couldn’t do it.

‘I don’t understand.’

‘I need her away from here for a while. I know this isn’t fair, I’m so sorry about Madison, I want to be there for you, but please, I wouldn’t be here if it wasn’t really important.’

‘But you can’t say why?’ she asked quietly.

‘I did something, something bad, a long time ago, and it’s found its way back to me.’

‘This to do with your time undercover?’

Sophie nodded. ‘We all have our secrets, don’t we?’

Jess nodded. ‘Yeah, yeah, we do.’

Thirty minutes later, a small rental was booked on Jess’s credit card, Sophie saying she would pay it back in cash as she didn’t want a trail. She could see Jess had questions, but to her credit, she didn’t ask. The place Sophie chose was in a quiet village on the east coast of England, near to a train station, big enough to go unnoticed, small enough for Karl to never know the place existed.

‘There, all booked, two weeks all paid for,’ Jess said, and Sophie saw, despite how much she was helping, the way she was gnawing the inside of

her cheek and picking at a hangnail on her thumb. The way she couldn't hold eye contact for more than a second. Jess was on the edge.

'I'm so sorry, Jess, to do this today of all days. I didn't know where else to go.'

'It's okay. I don't know what's going on, but I can help if you need it. We all can.'

'We?' Sophie said.

'Yes, Sophie, we.'

'I promise, one day, I'll try to explain all of it. But right now, I need Lottie somewhere far away from here.'

Jess nodded.

'Are you okay?' Sophie asked.

'Not even close,' she said. 'But I'm glad you came to me. I'm glad I could help you and Lottie.'

Giving Jess a hug, Sophie grabbed Lottie, who also hugged Jess, and then she and her daughter were leaving once more. Back in the car and driving to Daya's.

As she pulled up on her mum's drive, Daya was loading things into the boot of her car. Joining her, Sophie did the same, transferring Lottie's belongings. Once it was all done, Sophie had to say goodbye to her girl.

'Mummy, what's going on?' she asked.

'You and Nana are going to go away on holiday for a little while. The seaside.'

'The seaside?' she said excitedly.

'Yes, darling.'

'Are you coming too?'

'No, baby girl,' Sophie said, trying not to cry.

'What? Why?'

'I have to work.'

‘I hate your work,’ she said, her little eyes beginning to fill with tears, and Sophie stepped in and hugged her so her daughter didn’t see her own.

‘Me, too, darling. Me too. But I can’t wait for you to send me lots of pictures and hear about all the birds you see. I’ve packed the book Jess gave you, so you can identify them.’

Sophie stood and hugged Lottie as tight as she could. She placed her lips on top of her girl’s head and took in her smell. She wanted to savour it all. The place on the coast was booked for two weeks. Sophie hoped she could somehow fix everything in that time, but really, she didn’t know how long it would be. She hoped for less, a lot less, but she had to prepare for more.

Sophie’s hug turned into tickling her little girl until her daughter’s tears were replaced with shrieks of laughter, and then, with Lottie feeling better, she loaded her into the back of her mum’s car, before turning to Daya and pulling out the burner phone.

‘Don’t use yours, call me on this.’

‘Okay. Jesus, Sophie, I’m scared.’

‘It’s all going to be okay. Have a holiday, I’ll sort this.’

‘How?’

Sophie hesitated. ‘I’ll sort this.’ she said again.

Giving her mum a hug, she stepped back and watched as Daya reversed out of her drive, Lottie waving from the back seat. Tears streaming down her little face, crying for her mummy. Sophie tried to tell her it would all be okay, but struggled as her chin wobbled and she had to cover her mouth. She didn’t want Lottie to see she was upset. But she knew she had failed.

As Daya and Lottie drove away, Sophie blew kisses, tried to smile, even skipped in the road to try to ensure the last image Lottie had of her was that she was fine.

And then they rounded a corner, and Sophie stood and cried in the middle of the road.

Chapter Fifty-Seven

THE NETWORK GROUP CHAT

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

I have heard whispering that, in light of recent events, the network should stop. I cannot stress how close we are to doing so. Very soon, enough will have been done to create lasting change. Esme's Law will go to the Commons and then we save countless women for generations to come. We stay the course. Newport is scheduled, we stay on the timeline we all agreed. Tragedy will always come with change.

We stay the course.

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Chapter Fifty-Eight

JESS

There was another message from Kelly on my phone, the eighth or ninth I hadn't answered. Hannah had tried to call a lot, too, but I wasn't able to talk. They were my support group, my network, but I couldn't speak. What was there to say? Madison had needed us, we had failed, and now she was dead. I was sure that once someone was dead, that was it, no afterlife, no promised land, just eternal darkness. Madison wouldn't ever again see the sunrise, wouldn't ever again hear her little boy laugh. She was gone from everywhere. Forever. With Lewis, when he did what he did, my walls were my fortress and I kept everything I was feeling locked inside. I didn't cry with him, only doing so on New Year's Eve because of how afraid I was. And I remember feeling like I had failed for doing so. I needed to cry, for Madison, but the tears wouldn't come. Instead, it was all locked back. My fear and anger and shame. Kelly and Hannah were only trying to be there for me, but I couldn't let them in. I needed to be okay with me first. So, I swiped Kelly's message, removing it from my home screen and saw the time. 3.19am.

I was so tired my bones ached. But, knowing I'd not sleep, I got up, and made my way to the living room. As I sat on the sofa and flicked on the TV, I struggled to focus on the screen. I needed to close my eyes for more than an hour and rest them. But, no matter how hard I tried, no matter what I did,

sleep just wouldn't come for more than a few minutes at a time. There were no dreams, no rest, just flits before they reopened.

And I couldn't shake Madison. I didn't know the details of how she ended up in her bed, alone, after taking all of her prescribed medication. I didn't want to ever know the truth of how lonely and isolated and afraid she must have been. But, as hard as I tried, I couldn't stop my mind from thinking it. I pictured her crying in her bed, popping one pill after another, until her stomach ached, her vital organs screamed, and the darkness came.

I wondered what her final thoughts were, her final actions. Did she try and undo what she had done when she realised it was too late? Did she beg God to let her live? Did she call out for me or Kelly or Hannah to save her? Did she hate us for not doing so? The questions and vision of her dying alone played over and over and I was so exhausted, I was sure I could hear her voice in that liminal space between wakefulness and sleep. She told me I had failed. She told me that, although I didn't put the pills in her mouth, I was part of the reason she did.

Wanting to numb myself to the relentless wondering, I focused on the TV. The news was playing, conflict seemed to be consuming all four corners of the world, and instead of turning it off, I watched as bombs exploded and buildings burnt and people screamed in the streets.

Once, the world was a good place. Then Lewis made it a great place for a while before showing that it wasn't good at all. The Caretaker showed me it could be evil and, since then, I've come to understand it wasn't ever good in the first place. I was just naive. My job was gone, my dreams were broken, and Madison was too young to die, too young to suffer. As much as Jake was to blame, for doing what he did, abusing her and showing her online at her most vulnerable and exposed, I was to blame too. And Hannah and Kelly for enabling her to be a monster for one night, and then not doing enough to help her in the nights after. I also blamed DS Jones. For not helping her when he could, for failing to do his job. He was the first person

Madison spoke to when she found the courage to disclose the abuse she was suffering, and he did nothing. Like he had done nothing for Esme, who, I still assumed, was in hospital. But, of all of us, I think Kelly was maybe most to blame. The Caretaker was her idea, her project. Madison killed a man in the most brutal way, and it broke her, and she never would have if it wasn't for Kelly.

I wondered, maybe that was why I didn't pick up the phone. I was too angry to talk to them, to anyone. Well, not quite anyone. I wanted Sophie to call, to let me know how Lottie was, to be there for me in the finite way she could without knowing the truth.

Oh, how I wished I could tell her the truth.

As the news moved on to even more depressing things, I looked at my phone again. The last message from Kelly, two hours before. Hannah had reached out also. From Sophie, however, I had heard nothing since she turned up in blind panic on my doorstep four days previously, needing me to help her make Lottie vanish. I knew it was connected to her past. And I felt myself wanting to know if she was okay, but not daring to message, just in case.

People were always watching now.

Instead, I scrolled on Facebook and Instagram. The usual shit filled my screen. People spoke of The Caretaker, the two copycats – Devon, which was a scared fourteen-year-old kid, and Slough, which was a woman in her forties. One was a copycat trying to help his sister, one the real thing, a woman who failed. People spoke of how things had gotten out of hand, and whereas before when I read the public forum on The Caretaker I felt that most were in his favour, there was now the sense things were beginning to turn. He was a vigilante; only those who deserved to get hurt were supposed to get hurt. But now, a kid had been injured and a mother of two was dead. And Madison. Poor, poor Madison. As I scrolled, I heard a voice on the TV that I knew, and it snapped my attention. Behind a lectern, doing a press

conference, was DS Jones. He talked of the Slough stabbing and how people shouldn't be romanticising murder. He had a point, but then, it was in his best interests for The Caretaker to vanish, wasn't it? Someone off-camera asked about Madison. Wondering if her death was connected to The Caretaker, and I remembered the way he had smirked in the hospital. I turned off the TV, I didn't want to hear him speak my friend's name. And in the silence that followed, I wondered why Sophie wasn't leading the conference, and, worried for her, I messaged, asking if she was all right, despite knowing I shouldn't. People were definitely watching, but she was my friend too.

As I hit send, I saw that it was read almost immediately, and I waited for a reply. It didn't come.

Pushing down the creeping sadness that came with feeling ghosted by her, I turned my attention to the network. I wanted to know what they were going to do, as surely it had to stop to grieve. Maybe it was time for The Caretaker to vanish back into the nothingness he came from. I logged into Signal, and scrolled back in the chat to catch up.

Slough was written off as an unfortunate moment, and her family would be well cared for. It was dispassionate, but it was quickly replaced with talk of Madison. There was such sadness and grief. Members talked of setting up a mental health check-in to protect us further, and it was in motion. I didn't know who any of the people messaging were: our usernames protected all of us from anything and anyone who could stop this. But I was moved that so many cared about her.

But as I continued to scroll down, I realised that people weren't caring enough. The conversation had moved on, Newport was spoken of, and when TheSunMaid asked if it should be postponed in light of the tragic events of late, others came back and said that, in war, there were always casualties. Newport was happening, the messages said it would be tonight. Nothing had changed.

Madison was dead: everything had changed, surely?

The sudden and urgent need for fresh air swept over me, like if I didn't get outside, I would suffocate, and walking into the kitchen, I opened the back door and let the pre-dawn summer air sweep over me, cool and clean before the heat of the day rushed in. I looked up at the endless sky. Light clouds high in the atmosphere sat perfectly still in the moonlight, and I focused on them until the suffocating feeling shifted. As I turned to go inside again, maybe try and settle, I saw in the corner of the door frame, a perfectly formed spider's web. My instinct was to grab the hoover and suck the web and spider up. Spiders scared me, always had, but I stopped myself. It wasn't just a web, it was a spider's home, it was its way to find food. A spider didn't harm anyone, not in the UK. There were no spiders out there abusing other spiders. It was simply trying to make it in a world that was increasingly more challenging to survive in. I empathised with that. The spider and its web weren't the enemy, and we certainly weren't at war. So, I left it alone.

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Chapter Fifty-Nine

THE CARETAKER

He watched the waking sun flick a dim light across the sky, stealing the blue-black of darkness, and bringing in the new dawn. As he watched, he wondered, in a world that he knew, the world he was a part of, how could something beautiful like a rising sun still exist? If it was any other morning, he would have sat and watched it until the day fully claimed the night, enjoying the pre-chaos calm of a new day. Light enough to be renewed, still too early for people to ruin it. But it wasn't any other morning, it was his morning. The one he had prepared for, the one that was thoroughly noted in the little blue book. When it had arrived, he was astonished at its contents, the level of thought, the precision of the work, the manifesto which made it all make sense. The original members were geniuses to create something foolproof – well, almost. Slough was a stark reminder to stay vigilant and prepare for anything. Even the detail of wearing the same size ten wellington boots was a level of thought he wouldn't have considered. The book was awe-striking and terrifying all at once. And this Caretaker, this incarnation, sat in his car on a quiet 1920s-build street, the Georgian houses holding the working-class old-world charm in their roofs and windows, and did as the blue book said. The size ten wellies were on, the leg cuffs taped, and as the radio played through the small car speakers, he put on the gloves and secured them with tape at the sleeve. Failure wasn't an option. The

Caretaker and his message were being lost in the recent events, and he had to get them back on track. Women had died, and the dialogue wasn't ever supposed to be about The Caretaker and women dying. He was there to save them. Only men should be dying. The conversation had to stay about bad people hurting those they were meant to love. It was about changes needed at the highest level. Esme's Law, as the press were now calling it, needed to be passed. The Caretaker knew the risk, they all did, but now one had been killed, and all anyone could talk of was copycats, stupid people. This wasn't about anything other than the right for women to feel safe. This Caretaker, thirty-three-year-old Tracy Moore, knew it had to be quick, direct. It had to be perfect, and, after, the message would go out to the world, and the conversations would switch back to where they should have stayed.

In the little blue book, the plan was to strike before midnight, but the plan had changed in the wake of Slough. Dawn was better. The risks of being seen were slightly higher and the blanket of night was fading fast, but his target Amit Banerjee struggled with sleep sometimes. His wife, support network member Geeta, who was desperately trying to leave, lay upstairs in bed beside him. He wished there was a sign Geeta could give to tell him her husband was sound asleep, but there was no way.

Geeta knew it was coming, that The Caretaker was going to visit and save her, but, for her own protection, she didn't know exactly when it would happen. Her being at home was her alibi. The Caretaker would enter, dispatch her husband and Geeta would wake in the chaos of her husband being murdered. In an ideal world, she would be somewhere else, but the world was anything but ideal. His existence was proof of that. Placing on his hat and face mask, The Caretaker looked at himself in the rear-view mirror. It was time.

Getting out of the car, grabbing the rucksack as he did, he walked towards the rear of the house, confident that where he had parked he wouldn't be seen, and he let himself into the garden of Amit and Geeta, and

approached their back door. He paused, making sure that the only thing he could hear was the dawn early chorus, and then, satisfied he was alone, he crouched down, unzipped his rucksack and removed a roll of gaffer tape. He carefully covered a small rectangular pane of glass that was nearest the door handle in the old door. On the inside, the key sat in the lock, waiting to be turned. Geeta had ensured that would be the case, even if she didn't know when it would be used. Once the pane was fully taped, he placed the roll back in his bag, pulled out a thick bath towel, folded it, and pressed it into the freshly taped glass. Then, he pulled a screwdriver, a generic one from the shed, pushed it into the corner of the pane, and with the towel secure because the screwdriver was holding it there, he hit the end of the handle. Aside from a small pop, as the glass broke and dislodged from the frame, very little sound rang out into the night.

Carefully removing the towel and the pane of glass, which was smashed but secure in the tape, he placed them on the floor. Then, reaching his hand inside, he unlocked the door and stepped into the house.

Removing the weapon he would use, he zipped and secured his rucksack on his back once more, before making his way through Geeta's house and up the stairs. Pausing at the threshold to their bedroom, he listened to the deep and reverberating snores of Amit, his target.

One final breath, and he gently opened the bedroom door.

Chapter Sixty

As the door swung open, he looked in the room and saw Geeta lying there awake, waiting for him. Her eyes were wide, fear gripped her. The Caretaker wondered if it was fear of him, or her husband. If The Caretaker failed, her husband would exact vengeance, likely killing him, and maybe even her.

Slough had shaken the foundations of the network. It was time to get it back on track, quickly, without mistake, without error.

The Caretaker raised a finger to his lips.

Geeta nodded.

He walked around the bed, so he stood beside Amit, who snored on blissfully unaware his time was up. Raising the weapon, a six-inch Stanley blade you could buy at any hardware store, he looked back at Geeta.

‘Turn away,’ he whispered. ‘Pretend to sleep.’

Geeta, with tears streaming, nodded again, and turned over, and even in the low light, The Caretaker could see she was shaking.

Placing the Stanley blade to his target’s neck, he pressed a little. Amit stirred, and as his eyes locked onto those of The Caretaker, The Caretaker pressed as hard as he could and ran the blade across his throat.

For a second, nothing happened, and panic rose like a tidal surge, but then a crimson line formed, which quickly became a torrent.

Amit grabbed his own throat, and began to writhe, and The Caretaker stepped back from the bed just as Amit fell onto the floor. The blood came fast, and with his vocal cords slashed, no sound came from the seventh man to face justice at the hand of The Caretaker.

Backing away as Amit Banerjee lost his battle to live, The Caretaker looked at Geeta in the bed. She was pale, crying, but she managed to mouth a silent thank you before grabbing the phone.

The Caretaker, dropped to one knee, leant over the body, and left the mark all Caretakers knew too. Then he stood, packed away his weapon, and as Geeta spoke, he walked out of the room.

‘Hello, hello. I need the police, an ambulance, help me,’ Geeta said, as he made his way downstairs and back into the early-morning bird song. He had been in Geeta’s house for all of two minutes.

One hundred and twenty seconds, and the agenda, the whole reason for this, was back on track.

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Chapter Sixty-One

SOPHIE SALAM

Sophie had watched the sunrise from her bed. The silence of night replaced with the cacophony of day, and no amount of bird song or early-morning commuters could stave off the loneliness she felt. Holding the burner phone, the one for her mum, she stared at the picture of her little girl that her mum had sent. She was on the beach, smiling. An ice cream in her hand that had dripped onto her little knuckles. The sea behind her, calm and inviting with a scattering of brave North Sea swimmers. She looked happy, and that helped to squash the ache in her belly about her daughter being in hiding. Nothing had been okay since Karl messaged, demanding she find a man who was now missing. Nothing would ever be okay again after he asked who Lottie was. Sophie wanted to block him, hide with her daughter forever, but it wasn't an option. Karl would take her down if she didn't play his games. He would find her if she didn't do as he wanted.

She knew sleep wouldn't come and she should just get up. The phone attached to Kendrick buzzed, a message, a name. David McCosh. She had two weeks to find him.

She knew that she was going to sign another man's death warrant. But she didn't think there was any choice. Two weeks meant, whoever McCosh was, Kendrick expected him to be harder to find. Likely more dangerous

too. But she didn't focus on that. It also gave her two weeks to work out how to end this whilst avoiding prison and keeping Lottie safe.

Putting down the Kendrick burner, she closed her eyes, hoping in doing so the headache that was forming would ease, but as she almost believed it was possible, there was another ping. Her normal phone. Seeing it was Clarke, she didn't have to read the message to know what was up. She called him instead.

'You're awake?' he asked.

'Yep.'

'How are you doing? Word has it you're working from home a little?'

'I am,' she replied, offering no more. 'Who told you?'

'Jones.'

'He's being such a prick.'

'He's saying around the office that you're done. That you're digging into old cases because you can't control the new ones.'

'He said that?'

'Not to me, I'd clock him if he did. But yeah, he's not being subtle in his dislike of you.'

'Did he mention what case?' she said, wanting to sound nonchalant, and failing.

'Not that I know of. What is he on about?'

'God knows with that man.'

'Okay, well, if you wanna talk, I'm all ears. I'll always be on your side,' Clarke said, and it softened her.

'Thanks, mate, sorry. There's a lot going on at home.'

'I get that. Offer always stands.'

'Thank you. Not read your message, I'm guessing it's more of the same?'

'Afraid so. Newport this time. Messy one, apparently. And the wife of the victim was in bed beside him.'

‘Jesus.’

‘I’ll forward what they sent me from the scene.’

‘Thank you. Has there been a video yet?’

‘No, but I suspect it’s coming.’

Clarke hung up the phone, and Sophie scrolled socials for an hour, waiting for the familiar image of The Caretaker to emerge and pushing down what Clarke had told her about Jones. It was obvious he was on to her, somehow. As she looked, The Caretaker was true to form, and TikTok became flooded with shares and re-shares of his video.

Sophie couldn’t look at him. She knew the video would give nothing away about who he was, or his location, but she played the video, listening to his voice as she went downstairs to get a coffee.

‘This morning, my seventh man has fallen. A man who cut his wife off from her family, isolating her away from everyone she loved, has been cut in return.

‘My work is not yet complete, but it is my work and mine alone. Those speaking in my name must stop. Only those who deserve to be hurt should be hurt. There has been a woman who has died, pretending to be me. No more innocent women should suffer. If you want this to stop, rally the government for change. Do not act in my name in any other way.

‘And those out there, men who hurt. I am coming.’

As the video began to play again, his message on loop, Sophie tried her best to fill the kettle with water and flick it on, but her hands shook too much, and scrabbling for her phone, she tried to stop the video playing. Failing to do so, she threw the phone at the wall.

‘Fuck!’

Sinking to the floor, she cried. She knew she was in trouble, a hole of her own making she couldn’t get out of, and unable to bear being alone, but not able to face work, she crawled for her phone, thanking God that, although the screen was cracked, it still worked.

Going to her call log, she dialled, and as she cried, she spoke. 'Jess? Can we meet up? I really need someone.'

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Chapter Sixty-Two

JESS

It had only been a few months back, mid-February, when I was asked into an interrogation room by Sophie and was absolutely sure she knew who The Caretaker was. That day she spoke to me and all of the friends, and I was sure we had been caught. For her, digging for the truth mattered. Now, it seemed that it didn't matter quite so much. The truth was just another thing, another plate to spin, and despite Sophie Salam being the lead investigator on The Caretaker case, and me an active lead in his identity, when she called, the desperation in her voice, the fear in her words, I didn't care about anything other than her being okay. When she asked to see me, I said yes without hesitation. Offering for her to come over straight away. She couldn't, of course. The Caretaker had murdered again, and she was needed to work. So we agreed on 8.30pm. She needed a friend, and I did too.

As the day wore on, limping slowly, I knew I should be tidying my flat for her arrival, but every time I tried to be motivated, I couldn't find a way to get moving. All I could think about was what Madison would be doing if she was still here. Would she be with her little one, at a park perhaps, smiling in the sunshine? I wondered, what if she'd never met us, never knew who The Caretaker was? What if she never met Jake, what if, when she asked for help, DS Jones had done what he was meant to do? It haunted me, and it seemed everything I looked at, touched, every drink I had, I

questioned if Madison would be doing the same right now. It stopped me enjoying anything.

I should never have let her leave my flat when she arrived in the middle of the night ten days ago. That was her cry for help, and I did fuck all to save her. And before, Esme cried for help, and I failed her also.

I couldn't fail Sophie too.

She arrived exactly on time, as was her way, and feeling suddenly nervous at her being in my flat, I wished I'd done something to make it look nice. As I opened the front door, she smiled. I expected her to be in usual work clothes, serious and formal, but she was in a light T-shirt and denim shorts. I hadn't seen her dressed so casually before.

'You look nice,' I said.

'Thanks. I brought wine.'

'I think we both need wine.'

Inviting her in, I took the wine and went to pour us both a glass. I expected Sophie to go and sit in the living room, but instead she walked past me, opened the back door and stepped into the garden. She sat down on the back step. With two red wines poured, I joined her.

'Sorry, I don't have anywhere to sit.'

'That's okay.'

'I have been meaning to get a little table and chairs for the garden.'

'Honestly, the step is fine.'

Taking a large sip of my wine, I couldn't help but realise I was sitting shoulder to shoulder with Sophie. Our skin touching. 'I want to ask how you are, but I know it's a stupid question.'

Sophie didn't reply. She continued to look into the garden, and she drank. I drank, too, only moving to go and retrieve the wine bottle to top up our glasses. I could see Sophie was struggling, trying to keep it together. I knew her pain.

'Can I do anything?' I asked.

‘I should be saying this to you. I’m so sorry, Jess, for Madison.’

‘So am I. Is Lottie okay?’ I asked, I wasn’t ready to talk about my friend yet.

‘She’s okay, she’s having a great time. I miss her.’

I nodded. This pain I didn’t know. I missed the kids I worked with, desperately wanted to see them, to play and laugh and help them learn, like I used to. But a mother’s longing must be the most consuming of them all. So I didn’t try and offer comfort, and nor did Sophie with me. We just drank and watched the sun go down. And once the sun had vanished, along with the wine, I went and got another bottle from my wine rack, and we carried on until my head felt fuzzy and Sophie’s teeth were slightly tinged.

‘How are Kelly and Hannah doing?’ Sophie asked.

‘I’m not sure.’

‘Why not?’

‘I’ve not been able to speak to them. They keep calling, but I’m just not ready,’ I replied, unsure if the wine was making me more relaxed, or if it was Sophie. I liked her, and had to lie to her all the time. It was nice to have some truth come from my lips.

‘Do you blame them?’

‘I blame all of us. Me, them, her ex, DS Jones.’

Sophie looked at me, shocked I was mentioning a colleague.

‘Sorry,’ I said.

‘It’s okay. Jones is a prick.’

‘Yeah, yeah, he is.’

‘He’s on my case at the moment. I’m a bit anxious.’

‘I’m sure it will ease off,’ I said, and she nodded.

‘You know, it doesn’t feel weird anymore,’ Sophie said, her words with a hint of a slur telling me she was feeling the buzz too.

‘What?’

‘Being around you.’

‘No, it doesn’t.’

‘I’m going to ask you something, not as a police officer, but as your friend. You don’t have to answer, and I won’t ever use it against you.’

‘Okay?’ I said, my heart skipping, wondering where this was going.

‘Are any of them you?’

‘Any of what?’

‘Them,’ she said, holding my eye, and I knew exactly what she was asking me. She wanted to know if I had killed.

‘No,’ I said honestly.

She looked at me for a little longer, and her eye contact was so intense I rubbed my eye and looked away.

‘What about you?’ I asked.

‘What about me?’ she asked.

‘There are rumours ... and that man in the café, Lottie going away. Have you done anything?’

‘Not like The Caretaker, no. But I have a past. I made some mistakes. It’s caught up a little.’

‘Should I worry?’

‘No, no. It will be okay. We all have regrets, right?’

‘We sure do,’ I said.

Turning back to the night, I looked up as the first stars began to reveal themselves.

‘When I was little, my dad, before he turned bad, told me that, when a person died, their souls left and became stars. And that’s why we keep finding new ones, because every day more and more go to the heavens.’

‘I like that,’ Sophie said. ‘I like that a lot.’

‘I hope she’s there. Madison,’ I said quietly. ‘I hope one day, some scientist or kid with a telescope discovers her up there.’

‘I’m sure they will.’

‘She came here, ten days ago, in the middle of the night. She couldn’t sleep. She said she was having bad dreams. I should have done more.’

‘You can’t say that.’

‘I just did, Soph. She needed someone and she came to me, and I didn’t do enough.’

‘As hard as this is to hear, some people end up so broken nothing can help them. She had people to help, but Jess, I’ve been a copper for a long time. People struggle in silence. That’s what they do, that’s what we all do. And sometimes it’s okay, sometimes it’s not. But that’s not a Jess Pendle thing, that’s a human being thing. You cannot change that.’

‘You really believe that?’

‘Yes.’

‘Then there is no hope for anyone.’

‘No, that’s not what I’m saying,’ she said, after another long drink. ‘I mean, we are all going to struggle, all going to fall down. Some fall harder and, unless you know just how hard, you cannot be held to account. You didn’t know how badly Madison was doing. How could you?’

I nodded. I wasn’t sure if I believed her, but I didn’t want to talk about it anymore. I wanted to drink, looking out to the night sky at the stars. I felt Sophie put her head on my shoulder.

‘Soph?’

‘I’m just tired. And drunk.’

I let out a little laugh, one that felt so good, the pressure valve releasing for the tiniest of moments, and Sophie started to laugh too. Her valve popping. And for a while, we both laughed, my head resting on hers on my shoulder.

As the laughter eased, she lifted her head off me, our faces drawing close for a second. And in that second, I felt longing.

Sophie looked up at the sky, and I looked at her. Her profile was soft and strong all at once. High cheek bones, a gentle nose. She was striking.

But I could see she was afraid, of what, I didn't know. She turned and looked at me, and as she did, I knew she felt something too. Before I could lean in, she beat me to it, placing her lips on mine, and for a brief, wonderful moment, I forgot my pain and worry and fear. Her warm lips took me somewhere else, somewhere safe and full of want. When she pulled away, her taste lingering, she couldn't hold my eye.

'Sorry, I don't know what came over me,' she said.

'It's okay,' I said, this time placing my head on her shoulder, the sudden rush of peace making me feel like I could sleep for the first time in days.

'Jess?' Sophie said quietly.

'Hmmm?'

'I'm afraid.'

'Me too,' I said.

'I know you're involved somehow,' she said, and I lifted my head, turning my attention back to her. 'But I don't care anymore. I know you're not a bad person. I just want my girl, some peace. I want the past to leave me alone, Jones to back off. I want The Caretaker case over. I don't care about my career anymore. I just want to be okay.'

I didn't say anything. I didn't want to confirm with her I was involved. Even drunk, I had to try to be careful.

Sophie watched me for a moment, then looked out once more into the night. 'Jess?'

'Yeah?'

'I know it might not be, I know the world is hard and cruel. But tell me everything will be okay?'

'Everything will be okay.'

'Cross your heart?'

'Just like The Caretaker,' I said, and the way Sophie looked at me, even drunk, I knew I had slipped up. I smiled to cover it up, offered more about how everything would work itself out, but I could see she wanted to leave.

She made her excuses, needed an early night, it had been a long day, and I walked her to the door. We hugged, but I could see she was now conflicted. She said she didn't care that I was involved, but clearly, that hadn't been true. What I said, it gave her proof. Even if she could never use it. After a prolonged goodbye, one where I wanted to kiss her again, I went back to the garden, sat and drank my wine and looked for Madison in the stars, and then I glanced at the spider's web in my door frame. Still there, still the same. Still perfectly at ease.

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Chapter Sixty-Three

The day I had been dreading had arrived, and standing outside the crematorium, far away from the building, amongst the plaques and flowers for the dead, I wanted nothing more than to hide away. Soon, mourners would come, her family, her son. Other friends, even her ex's family would arrive, and I would have to hug them, offer condolences, say it was a shock, and watch them grieving. Madison was too young, too innocent for this. She deserved more, and I couldn't look at myself in the mirror for my part in it all. I didn't deserve to be here, waiting to say goodbye, none of us 'saved' did, because we hadn't saved what really mattered. The Caretaker was meant to protect us. If he had done nothing, if we hadn't created him, Madison would still be alive.

Soon, Kelly and Hannah would come. I didn't want to see them still, but today there was no choice, so we had arranged to meet before, just us, knowing that we were all culpable.

Sitting on a bench in the peaceful grounds, I read the memorial opposite the narrow path. It was for a man named Peter Mullis, a dad, husband and grandfather. He had been gone many years. But the flowers suggested he was still remembered, still loved. As it stood, I was pretty sure no one would lay a lily for me.

Hannah arrived first, finding me sat staring, wondering who that man was, what his dreams were, whether he led a rich and fulfilled life, and I was so wrapped up in my imagining Peter, I didn't notice her until she sat beside me.

'Hi, Jess,' she said, lifting me from my thoughts. I turned and gave her a small hug. 'How are you holding up?' she asked, concern pulling her brow into worry lines.

'I'm okay,' I said.

I could see Hannah wanted to press, clearly noticing I was far from okay, so I turned away from her. 'It's peaceful here. Quiet.'

'Yeah,' she said.

'Where will the family put her plaque?'

'I don't know.'

I nodded, then hearing footsteps, I looked up and saw Kelly coming towards us. Whereas Hannah sat beside me tentatively, Kelly didn't. She pulled me up off the bench and hugged me tight.

'I've been so worried about you,' she said.

'I'm fine.'

'We've tried messaging, calling, like all the time.'

'Sorry, I've just not felt like talking.'

'We have to,' Kelly said. 'We only have each other in this. We look after one another.'

'Like we looked after Madison,' I said, and I may as well have slapped her across the face. I could see she was hurt by my comment, that she, too, knew what we had done. But I couldn't apologise. I wasn't wrong, and she knew it.

'Hey, Jess,' Hannah said. 'This isn't our fault.'

'Of course it is,' I said. 'If he didn't exist, she wouldn't be dead. We all knew—'

'Stop,' Kelly said.

‘We all knew she was struggling with it. And we did fuck all. All three of us.’

‘I said stop,’ Kelly said.

‘No, I won’t stop. You know it too. If we hadn’t fucked about, if we hadn’t created—’

‘That’s enough,’ Kelly said, silencing me. ‘Not another word, Jess. Not today.’

‘Or what, Kelly?’ I replied. ‘Or what? You gonna do what he—’

‘Hey, stop,’ Hannah said, standing up between us. Trying to ease the tension. Kelly held my eye, and I remained unblinking too. I wouldn’t back down, and I wouldn’t change my stance: we did this, we killed Madison. We might not have pushed those tablets into her stomach, but we didn’t stop it from happening either.

‘Stop,’ Hannah said again, beginning to cry. ‘Our friend has passed, she needs us to be there for each other more than ever.’

‘She needs nothing now,’ I said quietly. ‘The dead don’t have demands.’

As I went to say more, there was a gentle clearing of a throat from behind us. A man was there, standing awkwardly.

‘Hi, Paul. Jess, this is Paul,’ Hannah said, introducing him, as Kelly was too angry.

‘Hi,’ I said.

‘I’m sorry for your loss,’ he said.

I was shocked that Kelly had brought her new man to the funeral of our friend. So much for us sticking together. Life moved on, I knew that, but not straight away, not for me anyway. ‘I’ll see you later.’

I walked away from Kelly and Hannah, opting to walk around the path instead of through them towards the building where our friend would soon be.

‘Jess?’ Hannah said. ‘Jess, please.’

I knew, deep down, Hannah meant well, Kelly did, too, but I couldn't be with them. Everything that mattered we had killed. And I'd never forgive us. Never.

By the time I had taken the longer loop through the grounds and back towards the chapel, I saw the funeral procession arrive, three long black cars slowly travelling behind the hearse where Madison lay. I waited for them to pass, and then I walked up behind the final car to join the back of the line of people who were attending. The queue was long, it often was for those who were young, and I was shocked to see that Sophie was in it. Somehow, she must have sensed I was looking her way, as she turned and met my eye. Since that night in my garden a week before, I hadn't heard from her at all. I suspected, like me, she felt conflicted about what happened. I also suspected, because of my slip-up, she knew she couldn't be near me anymore. Looking away, I saw others in the line, people crying, looking at the hearse in disbelief. Some press were there, trying to take candid and tasteless pictures. And then I saw more police officers, no doubt wanting to show some support, and with them, a bored-looking DS Jones.

I had to fight every urge in my body to not march over and hit him square in the face. He had no right to be at the funeral of a woman he could have helped and didn't. The only thing that stopped me was the fact I was no better than him, not anymore.

With the cars stopped, I watched from the back of the line as Madison's family climbed out and received hugs from well-wishers. Her little boy was there. The only real saving grace was he was still too young to understand.

As they made their way to the front, several men arrived, dressed in suits with top hats, and going to the back of the hearse, they lifted my friend onto their shoulders, and led everyone inside to say goodbye to Madison.

I waited until most were in, the crematorium was full, and I had to stand at the back, knowing I didn't deserve to even be in the room. I watched everyone take their seats and bow their heads in opening prayer, and

knowing I couldn't, I looked around the room. Jones, also not in prayer, caught my eye, and we held eye contact. He then gestured as if to say, 'what are you looking at?' before he bowed his head too.

I knew it was wrong, but as the prayer finished, and the celebrant began to talk about Madison's short and extraordinary life, I struggled to focus. There was nothing extraordinary about a woman who was afraid for years and then did something unspeakable which ultimately ended her life. For it to have been extraordinary, she needed to live to be ripe and old. This wasn't extraordinary, it was a travesty. There were so many in this room who could have helped that happen. Me, Kelly, Hannah, her parents, the police and Jones.

My mind drifted to that night on the beach in Cromer and the warning I gave. I had no proof he was still as bad as he once was. Aside from my gut feeling, his disinterest in being kind, and Sophie's words about him being on her case. I felt compelled to find something I could impact, and control, desperate to feel like I could still do good, I owed it to Madison. I owed her everything. As people began to sing a hymn, the words muffled and apologetic, I knew I needed to find out if Jones had changed. Because something positive had to come from all this, didn't it? And if Jones was now being a good partner, a good man, even if he was still an arsehole, then, for his partner Faye at least, something good had come from what we had done. I needed to know Madison hadn't died in vain.

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Chapter Sixty-Four

After Madison's coffin disappeared behind the curtain, I left, and as I did, Sophie watched me. I wanted to say something, I wanted to be close to her, but I put my head down and kept moving. I knew I should have stayed, offered my condolences, but I wasn't sure I could look Madison's family in the eye. I couldn't say I was sorry without also saying it was partly my fault. And I couldn't see Kelly or Hannah. No good could come from it. I could, however, ensure another woman was safe. I needed to. I had to atone, somehow.

Back at my car, I drove in the direction of the town centre. Months ago, in early February, after an evening working out and then drinking, Kelly and I had walked late at night, stalking Jones on his way home, and jogging my memory, I retraced those steps. Starting at the pub where we first saw actions that made us believe Jones was an abuser, and ending on his road. The houses all looked similar and I wasn't immediately sure which was his. But then, to my surprise, I didn't need to recall which door was his, because as I drove slowly up his road, I passed Jones getting out of his car. Seems he, too, wasn't going to stick around at the funeral.

I wasn't sure how I was going to find out if my warning in Cromer changed him, so I sat, looking at his front door through my side mirror, waiting for something. An idea, a miracle perhaps.

That night in Cromer, I'd watched Jones wobble along the shoreline after trying to make his partner have sex on the beach. She declined, and he called her a whore. I stood in the shadows of the storm-breaker sea defence, watching as she ran away and he turned to piss in the sea. And after he voided his bladder, I had followed him, walking as far as possible in the surf so any footprints would be swept away.

I remembered the feeling of power I had that night when I hit him in the face, sending him crashing to the sand. I wanted to drown him, but instead, because of his privilege of being a police officer, he got off with a warning. The Caretaker told him to change or leave her. He had warned him, if he didn't do either, he would kill him.

It was time to see if Jones had done as he was told.

I just had to work out how.

An hour passed – an hour when I should have been at the wake with Kelly and Hannah, talking about Madison's short life, whilst eating finger food and listening to stories about her from her other friends and family – before Jones left the house once more. I sank in my seat as he got in his car and drove away. I didn't want him to see me. Then, when I was sure he would not come back, I got out, walked to his front door, and knocked.

As the front door opened, Faye looked down to see the parcel or letter, and when she saw I was empty-handed, she looked back, confused.

'Can I help you?'

'Maybe,' I said. 'Faye, my name is Jess.'

The confused look turned to recognition. And she took a small step back. 'What, what are you doing here?'

'Honestly, I'm not sure anymore,' I said, feeling stupid. 'I guess I needed to make sure things were better.'

'What do you mean?'

'I need to atone.'

‘Atone? I don’t understand, you shouldn’t be here. If he comes back...’
She trailed off.

‘What if he does?’ I asked.

She didn’t reply.

‘Faye, what if he does?’

She looked at me, and I could see acceptance in her eyes. ‘I used to think he didn’t mean the things he said and did. I thought it was the stress of work, the long hours, the things he had to see in his job. Jess, you need to go, before he comes home.’

‘Did things not change after The Caretaker?’

‘For a while, yes.’

‘But not now?’

She shook her head. ‘I said I wanted to leave. He told me I’d be nothing without him, and if I went, it would say he was a bad man, and he won’t be seen as a bad man.’

‘I remember Lewis, my ex, saying something similar.’

‘Jess, please, you really have to go.’

‘I want to help.’

‘No one can help,’ she said, her voice small and broken, as she began to close the door on me.

‘Someone can.’

‘No, no one can.’

‘One man can,’ I said.

She paused, knowing exactly who I meant. The gap in the doorway reduced so I could only see her right eye and half of her face. ‘Well, he tried, didn’t he? Please. I’ll be fine.’

Faye closed the door, and I backed away. I knew her fear, I had heard that tightness in her voice a thousand times before in my own. No one was coming to save her. She couldn’t go to the police, he *was* the police. She said she would be fine, and she was right: she would be, very, very soon.

On that beach in Cromer, Jones was warned: change, or The Caretaker would revisit him.

It was time to make good on that promise.

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Chapter Sixty-Five

The drive home, all I could think about was how broken Faye sounded. The woman whose Instagram I stalked only months before, was gone. That woman was optimistic, posting about her perfect Valentine's Day with her perfect man. She reminded me a little of Madison, back before she became The Caretaker. There was hope, a naivety that was endearing and needed protecting. Faye's was there somewhere, the old her, the one with brightness in her future just like Madison had possessed and lost. Someone had to help her rediscover it.

The Caretaker had to finish what he started with Jones. The warning hadn't been heeded, and now, he had to pay.

By the time I got home, an idea had begun to hatch as to how The Caretaker would deal with Jones, and grabbing a glass of wine, I opened the back door, and sat in the same place I had sat when Sophie was by my side.

My phone pinged, and picking it up, I saw Kelly had messaged.

It's out of order you're not here right now, Jess.

'Fuck you.' I said out loud, before turning my phone off. I didn't have time to justify to Kelly why I had to leave. I didn't want her knowing what I was planning to do. She could deal with the fact she was to blame for Madison's death however she wanted, denying it and moving on with her

life with Paul. It was just fine, if that was how she needed to be. This was my way.

Drinking the wine quickly, I looked up at the sky. The stars wouldn't be visible for hours, but it didn't mean they weren't above, and I searched for Madison. If she was there, I wanted her to see what I was doing for her. Faye would be free from DS Jones, the man who failed Madison.

'If you're up there, Mads, I'm sorry,' I said, raising my glass and having a drink for my fallen friend.

As I drained the rest, my head tilted back, I saw the spider's web in the corner of the door frame. Still perfect, still doing its thing. I stood up. The wine, on top of not eating for a few days, made my head swim a little, and I looked closer at the web. I couldn't see the spider, so I reached up, tapped one of the web's threads and waited. From the corner of the door frame the spider, a regular garden variety, ran out to see, thinking its trap had snagged an insect it could wrap and devour when ready. The little creature paused, no doubt trying to work out what was happening, and I was curious to look at it closer. My fear of them gone, I grabbed it carefully, and pulled it from the web. With it sitting curled up in my hand, I studied it.

I'd never looked at a spider properly. They were always something I instinctively feared, for no reason, and now I was taking the time to really look, I couldn't help but notice the perfect shape of its body, the way its legs were symmetrical. They were clever little things. Designed to survive in a world that didn't respect them anymore. It had overcome adversity, found the corner of my home, near light that attracted bugs, and it made camp. It was surviving. Tiny and forgotten, it was finding a way to survive, and you had to respect that.

I kept still, my hand cupped, and it responded by remaining passive. It was almost looking at me curiously, wondering why I was struggling to find my own corner to survive.

I should have put it back, but I didn't. And, as it looked at me, I closed my palm, and felt its little body crush in my hand. And when I opened it again, the little thing was no longer curious about anything.

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Chapter Sixty-Six

SOPHIE SALAM

Sophie arrived home much later than she thought she would. She had intended to be at the funeral and then leave, but the idea of going home to an empty nest wasn't appealing, so she went to the wake, chatted with Madison's family, and hoped to see Jess. Despite knowing that Jess Pendle was undeniably involved, the proof irreversible with her comment about The Caretaker crossing hearts, she still needed to see her. She missed her. Nothing was right, the case was a mess, Lottie was at the seaside hiding and Karl was ever present. He hadn't messaged, or called, but she knew Kendrick didn't let go. Once his claws were in, that was it. You complied, or you were punished.

And her latest job, finding David McCosh, was coming up blank. She had to be careful when searching on the police database; she felt like Jones was always watching.

Rob Mosley was still missing, but she knew he was dead, and knowing so was even more of a reason to keep Lottie in hiding.

As she closed the front door to her house, she pulled out her burner phone for her mum. She looked at the picture sent earlier in the day, another one of Lottie, this time sat on the sofa in their tiny rental cottage, colouring in the book Jess gave her, happy and relaxed. On the coffee table beside her was a plate with several snacks and a bottle of apple juice. There was no

doubt her mum was doing an astonishing job in caring for her, but she still knew she should have been the one with her baby.

Going to the call log, she dialled the only number saved, and on the third ring, her mum picked up.

‘Hey, Ma.’

‘Hey, Sophie, are you okay?’

‘No,’ she said, feeling completely overcome, and before she could regulate her nervous system and take control, she had started to cry, long and painful sobs that made it impossible to move anywhere but down to the floor at the bottom of her stairs.

Her mum didn’t try and calm her, didn’t offer any words of comfort, she just let her daughter’s tears run their course, and only when they eased did Daya speak.

‘Darling, she is safe.’

‘Is she happy?’ Sophie said, wiping her nose with her sleeve.

‘She misses you, we both do, but she is happy, she is sleeping well, being by the seaside has done something for her.’

‘What do you mean?’ Sophie asked, settling a little at knowing that Lottie was all right.

‘It’s like she’s meant to be by the sea. It’s hard to explain. I guess, when I look at her here, Sophie, I can see what she sees makes sense.’

Sophie smiled, picturing her daughter so happy. It was a beautiful image and hurt like hell.

‘Is she there?’

‘Hang on.’

The next voice Sophie heard was Lottie. ‘Hello?’

‘Hey, baby,’ she said, fighting to hold back her need to cry all over again at the sound of her daughter’s voice.

‘Mummy!’ Lottie exclaimed. ‘When are you coming?’

‘Soon, sweetheart.’

‘Okay.’

‘I love you.’

‘Love you.’

‘Are you having a nice time?’

‘Uh-huh.’

‘Mummy will be with you soon, okay?’

‘Did you know an albatross can fly ten thousand miles in one go?’

‘Ten thousand, really. That’s amazing.’

‘Yep.’

Sophie wanted to speak more of her coming to the seaside, and the adventure they would have, the birds they might find, but Daya was back on the line.

‘She’s gone, back to colouring again.’

‘Oh,’ Sophie said, trying to not feel hurt. ‘But I guess that means she’s feeling secure.’

‘She is. She’s such a good girl.’

Sophie couldn’t respond, she didn’t dare.

‘Are you any closer?’ Daya asked. ‘Can we come home soon?’

‘No, he’s not got in touch for a few days. I’ve been given a job. I’ll finish it, and then I will sort this.’

‘How?’

‘I... I’ll sort it.’

‘Sophie, you need to talk to the police.’

‘Mum, I can’t, I’ll lose everything, you, her. The price is too high. Please, keep her safe and happy, and I’ll make sure it always stays that way.’

Daya hesitated, the silence unbearable, before she quietly replied. ‘All right.’

‘Kiss her for me, tell her I love her and I’ll be there soon.’

Sophie hung up, the idea of saying goodbye too painful. Moving from the floor, she sat on the bottom step of her stairs, and for a while, she did nothing. She needed to be working out a way to appease her ex-partner, as well as solve The Caretaker case. She needed to formally question Jess again, but in that moment, all she wanted from Jess Pendle wasn't a confession, it was comfort. She needed her friend. She needed her peace, them both looking at the stars in silence. Together. But now, that couldn't ever happen. Sophie had wanted to deny in her own head that Jess was involved in the crimes that had swept the country. As naive as that sounded, she wanted to believe it was all a misunderstanding, but she knew the truth now, even if she didn't have proof.

As she began to wonder if maybe she needed to make another visit to Woodhill and sit with Karl, an envelope was pushed through her letterbox. As it landed on the doormat, she saw that it was handwritten. The last handwritten letter she'd received was from him, and jumping up, she ran to her door, opened it and looked outside. To her left, up the road, a car was driving away, and she made a note of its number plate.

Going back inside, she picked up the envelope, and looked at it. Her hands started to shake: it was from Karl.

Running her finger along the glue, she separated the flap of the envelope, and pulled out a single folded piece of paper. On the outside were three scribbled dates. She knew exactly what they were.

November 2017. February 2017. October 2016.

The month Lottie was born. The month she was conceived, and finally the month when she'd met Karl Kendrick.

Opening the letter, she saw it was in fact a photocopy of her daughter's birth certificate.

He knew.

Grabbing the burner from the stairs, she called her mum.

'Sophie?'

‘Mum, if for a second you think someone is there looking for you, you pack up, and you leave, and we find you somewhere else to hide.’

‘Sophie, what’s happened?’

‘Just promise me, don’t think it’s you being over-cautious, if there is any doubt, you move, okay?’

‘Okay. Okay. Why? What’s happened?’

‘Karl knows Lottie is his.’

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Chapter Sixty-Seven

JESS

As Faye lived through her social media, it wasn't hard for me to learn that, despite it being a Sunday, she had to leave early for work. A barista's job was never done. She set off just before eight, leaving Jones alone. And I sat in my car, waiting for him to also leave, I wondered how long a human could go without sleep. Foolishly, with nothing else to do, I Googled it. I discovered an old experiment back in the Fifties, where people were given drugs to stop them resting. Within two weeks all of them had lost their minds. Began to hurt themselves, and each other. Two weeks ago to the day Madison died.

I was on borrowed time, and had to make it count. I had to be prepared.

Planning the final details of how I would atone for my friend, ensuring that both Faye and Jones adhered to the rhythm I had noticed, I couldn't help but reflect back to Cromer, when I agreed and failed to scare him straight. I had arrived under a different name, staying in a quaint B&B. I walked the narrow streets, finding Jones and Faye on the pier where I followed them back to a small house outside town. I tracked the comings and goings that week, noting down their patterns, and I presented myself with my opportunity to strike. This was feeling the same, although instead of being so cold my bones ached, I was warm, the long summer days making it harder to hide but easier to be patient. I didn't know much about

police rotas, and after another quick Google I saw that detectives worked either mornings, lates or nights. It seemed Jones was on the late shift, working from mid-morning until after ten, when he would go to the pub and, usually drunk, he would no doubt go home and be awful to his partner.

Night would have been better to end him, night was always better. But Faye would be there, and she needed to be protected.

Their working lives gave me my window. The Caretaker would kill him after she left at eight, before he did the same at ten.

Two hours was plenty of time. I just wanted to make sure I was right with my plan.

The waiting felt hard, like at any moment Jones would see me sleuthing in my car, and challenge me as to why I was nearby. But he didn't, and just before ten, almost on cue, he left the house.

I watched him get into his car, puffing on a vape as he did, and then he accelerated out of his street. The limit was twenty miles an hour, but I had no doubt he was driving faster.

With confirmation of my window, I knew that tomorrow would be the day, it had to be. So, starting up my car, I drove carefully away from Jones's house in the direction of my own. I had a few stops to make to buy what I needed, then I would make the video, and begin to ready my bag.

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Chapter Sixty-Eight

I spent the night planning how I would do what I should have done in Cromer. Back when we discovered Jones was an abuser, after Kelly and I stalked him from the pub. We had snuck down the side gate to his garden from the front of his house. Back then, darkness hid our approach and I knew in broad daylight I couldn't do the same. Thankfully, Google maps helped me with how I would access his property. A second garden entrance, at the rear, where I could not be seen from the street. It was perfect. I was ready.

With the video made, pre-recorded and ready to upload, just as The Caretaker had done before, I checked and rechecked my bag: everything was there, hat, face mask, gloves, wellies, hazmat suit and tape. I had two screwdrivers packed as well, the tools of The Caretaker's trade for the day. It felt fitting: we were all screwed because of The Caretaker. Buying them was easy, it didn't raise an eyebrow of suspicion in the hardware shop I got them from. I simply walked in, picked them up, paid in cash and left. No questions, or concerns, no trail. But my DIY project wasn't putting up a shelf, or fixing a piece of furniture. My do-it-yourself was far more deadly.

And I was ready to do my part.

In Cromer, when I became The Caretaker, I only had to scare him. Today, I would become The Caretaker fully, inaugurate myself properly into

the network and, although it wouldn't bring Madison back, it might stop Jones's hand in another woman losing her battle with her demons. This was never about the victims of domestic violence dying, it was always about the perpetrator, and Jones, with his power and status, was the worst of them all. He was untouchable because of his uniform. And I knew the network would oppose my actions, and likely stop me, so I didn't tell them. What was that saying: beg for forgiveness rather than ask for permission?

But I knew I would not beg at all.

Besides, the network was talking of running its course, of the reason for it existing coming to an end. Esme's Law would be passed, and he would have no reason to exist anymore. Soon, The Caretaker would stop, because enough had been done. But it wasn't enough for Madison, and I doubted it would be enough for Faye. I had to make sure. Like I should have with my friend.

Knowing I was going to take the life of a bad man should have felt daunting, I should have been afraid, anxiety spilling out of every pore, but, as the sun began to rise, marking a new day, I felt anything but anxious. There was a tranquillity I hadn't felt before, a stillness I'd not felt since I was a lot younger, when the world was slower and less connected and made more sense.

Maybe I was always fated to be this man. Maybe this was how I found my place in this world, my corner to spin a web.

Looking at my phone, I saw that it was almost six. Faye left for work in two hours.

I'd know soon enough if being The Caretaker was destined for me, if being him was the thing I'd needed all along.

I wanted to leave, to prepare and finish Jones off as maybe I should have that night in Cromer, but I knew I needed to hold back, be patient. So I paced, ate, ensuring it was something light so I didn't feel sluggish but it was enough for the energy I would undoubtedly burn, and I visualised my

approach. Then, at 7.45am, my phone alarm sounded, and I had one final check I had everything I needed. I left my flat, climbed into my car, and made my way towards Jones's house, knowing very soon I might be absolved of my guilt about Madison.

The drive was uneventful, and despite knowing what I was going to do, I felt strangely calm, centred. The sickness in my stomach I had felt for a fortnight had faded, as had the constant onslaught of overthinking. I felt better, clean even. The dirt that had found its way into my mind, muddying everything, was gone. I was able to listen to the radio, enjoy the songs that played. I felt, somehow, safe.

Arriving at Faye's road, I parked up just in time to see her driving away, her small bright yellow Ka recognisable from a fair distance. It seemed fitting for her personality type. She was light, not serious in nature, the glass was half-full, even with a man like Jones beside her. But, from experience, that wouldn't last forever. Jones would steal that light, trap it, suffocate the flame. Because it had happened to Madison, who was the purest light I had ever known.

As Faye passed, oblivious to me sat in an idling car, watching her, I indicated and drove back onto the road. I headed past their house slowly, and saw Jones's car was still parked. Creature of habit, as the good book said. At the end of their road, I turned right, and then I turned right again onto a narrow road that provided access to the garages of the houses in front of them. The lane was rundown, deep cracks in the asphalt giving home to long weeds. The garages themselves unlikely to be used by any of the residents that owned them to store cars, more like Christmas decorations and old bikes. It was perfect for what I needed: the lane would stay quiet, and it backed onto Jones's house.

Awkwardly climbing into the back seat over my gearstick and handbrake, I began to change into the clothes I needed to become him, feeling a sweat break on my skin from the hazmat suit. I put on the wellies,

taped them in, and did the same with the gloves. And with my hood up, hair tucked back, I climbed from the back seat and walked towards the garden gate of DS Jones. I remembered when Kelly and I followed him in February, how we entered from the side, ducking under his kitchen window. Today was different, there would be no hiding, no sleuthing, and as I approached the gate, I became him. The man who punished bad men. I became The Caretaker.

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Chapter Sixty-Nine

THE CARETAKER

It wasn't locked. The Caretaker assumed as much. Jones wouldn't feel the need to lock his back gate, everyone would have known who he was. The Caretaker kept his hood up, his head low. A neighbour might see – maybe they would call the police – but what would they say? Someone in a hazmat suit came to the back door of Jones's house. They would know soon enough it was The Caretaker. And he didn't plan on being inside his house for long. By the time help arrived, if it did arrive, he would be gone, and Jones would be dead.

As he reached the back door, he looked into the kitchen. It was empty.

He suspected Jones was either still in bed, or getting ready for his shift. Jones would be capable of defending himself. An ambush would ensure The Caretaker didn't lose, like the Slough version of him had.

Trying the door handle, it didn't yield. He'd hoped it would be unlocked, like the gate, it would have made it easier, but no problem, he had an alternative plan.

Sometimes, the best way to get into somewhere was simply to ask.

He slowly unzipped his rucksack and with steady hands pulled out the screwdrivers. Then, with the bag secure once more, he used the handle of one of the screwdrivers and tapped on the back door. Stepping back against the wall between the back door and the kitchen window, he waited,

listening to anything that would tell him Jones was coming. Only bird song and a distant thrum of car tyre on tarmac spoke to him. It calmed him more, nature was singing for what he was to do.

After a minute, there was still nothing, and so The Caretaker reached and knocked again. This time a lot harder.

‘What the fuck?’ came a voice from inside the house.

Keeping his back to the wall, he looked to his right, gripping the screwdriver in his right hand tightly, and waited. From his position, he could hear Jones in the kitchen, muttering to himself, and as he approached the door the muttering becoming louder, The Caretaker braced. His muscles tightened and coiled, wanting to explode. The weight-training for all these months focused into a handful of muscles in his forearm and grip.

He wanted Jones to open the door, so he could let the months of secrets and grief and fear unfurl through his strike of screwdriver into flesh, but, Jones, still muttering, began to walk away.

Keeping his right arm raised, prepared, he tapped the glass again with the screwdriver in his left.

‘Is someone there?’ Jones said, and then he opened the door.

He looked to his left, his upper body bare, his skin inviting, and The Caretaker struck. He wanted to bury the screwdriver deep into Jones’s skull, but as the screwdriver came down, it ricocheted off his head, opening the skin like a deep yawn before it buried into the soft spot between his neck and shoulder.

Jones didn’t scream, he barely reacted for a few seconds, as the shock set in, which was plenty of time for The Caretaker to push him back into his kitchen, send him crashing to the floor, and close the door behind him.

Jones, his face washed out, cobweb-white, turned and looked up at The Caretaker. He opened his mouth to speak, but only wheezed. The screwdriver, buried to the hilt, had punctured his lung, and he was no doubt

internally bleeding. He could just watch Jones die, slowly, agonisingly painfully, but Madison needed more, she deserved more.

‘If you’d helped my friend, she wouldn’t be dead,’ The Caretaker said, and Jones, even slowly dying, flashed confusion, before recognition registered on his ashen face.

‘What ... the...’ he managed to rasp out.

The Caretaker grabbed at the screwdriver in Jones’s body, and pulled it out quickly. Stealing Jones’s ability to finish his sentence.

‘I blame a lot of people for what happened to her, but none more than you.’

As Jones tried to drag himself away from The Caretaker, he plunged the screwdriver into Jones’s thigh, and this time, despite his inability to breathe properly, he let out a cry.

The Caretaker responded instantly, stabbing the other screwdriver into Jones’s throat, slicing through his ability to speak. His target slumped backwards, still alive, but barely. The Caretaker knelt over him, pulled out both screwdrivers from thigh and throat, and as crimson began to pour, he reached up and pulled down his face mask.

Jones couldn’t speak, but he knew it was me. It was in the widening of his eyes, the opening of his mouth, despite no sound forming.

I watched as the light in his eye began to fade, but it wasn’t enough, the end looked too peaceful for him, and I needed him to suffer until his last moment.

‘I’m not done with you yet.’

I was in a frenzy. Each time I rained down a screwdriver, left, then right, right again, right, left, I watched the pain and anguish in his eyes. After the sixth or seventh, each hole in his body a large red dot that ran a line of dark

blood, like a bullet wound, Jones gaze became fixed, his eyes glazed, and I knew he was dead.

But I didn't stop for another minute until my forearms cramped and I dropped one of the screwdrivers. As I reached to pick it up, the pause in my frenzied attack stopped me entirely. Rolling off him, I lay beside his body, panting hard.

The need to sleep washed over me, the release of my anger and fear and grief wanted to shut my body down, but I couldn't. So, pulling myself onto my feet, I collected my tools and, exhausted, I packed up to leave, before removing the scalpel which was the calling card. I carved the cross, replaced the scalpel in the front pocket of the rucksack and, ensuring I left nothing behind but bloody footprints, I stumbled out of Jones's house, bounded towards the back gate and back to my car. Before getting in the car, I removed the hazmat suit, tape, gloves and wellies, so I looked like me once more, and then stuffed them into a black bin bag and hid them under the passenger car seat, to incinerate later.

I wanted to sleep, more than ever in my life, but I needed to be seen in the coffee shop. When the video was released, the schedule through encrypted servers set for midday, I wanted to be seen in public, carefree, lost in thought, seemingly oblivious to the murder that had just happened right on my own doorstep.

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Chapter Seventy

THE NETWORK GROUP CHAT

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

This organisation is nearing its journey's end. At the highest level, laws are now being passed as we speak. Laws that will give more rights to women, not only in a domestic situation, but beyond. We had a plan, an agenda, that's been carefully mapped out, for the good of everyone. What has happened today is not acceptable.

FAIRANDSQUARE666

What's happened?

BLACKWIDOW

The Caretaker has struck.

RADIOACTIVE-CAT2911

Where?

BLACKWIDOW

Milton Keynes.

RADIOACTIVE-CAT2911

Milton Keynes? I didn't think Milton Keynes was on the map.

INTH3SHADOWS

It wasn't. One of us has gone rogue.

NORTHERNUPROAR

Are you sure it's him? Could it be another copycat?

THESUNMAID

It's him. The police have confirmed.

SILENTINDEX

How would they know?

B3LLADONNA

The same way they have always known. The cross.

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

Ladies, we are close to doing what we set out to do. Soon, The Caretaker will vanish, for good. Forever. We cannot undo what has happened. But everything we have worked for, trained for, everything we have dreamt of achieving will come undone, unless we stick to the plan.

COSTA-LOVER777

What about Dumfries?

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

We continue as planned. Soon, it will be over, but I cannot stress enough, we cannot afford any more like Milton Keynes.

REDSHADEKIMBA

Milton Keynes? Isn't that near to where the original 'saved' live?

B3LLADONNA

Yeah, it is.

REDSHADEKIMBA

Has anyone been in touch with them?

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

They are all safe.

B3LLADONNA

Have you heard who they are saying the victim is?

NO-ONE.HOME

Who?

B3LLADONNA

It's a copper. Whoever did this, they killed a copper.

RedShadeKimba has left the group.
IndieRocker has left the group.
CapableSalamander has left the group.

REDACTEDUSER

Where is everyone going?

NORTHERNUPROAR

We never agreed to target a police officer.

NorthernUpRoar has left the group.

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

Everyone, calm down. We need to finish what we started.
Dumfries, are you prepared to do your part?

COSTA-LOVER777

I don't know.

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

I promise, do it as we have planned, and this will all be over,
and we will have saved countless lives.

COSTA-LOVER777

Are you sure?

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

One more will be enough. One more will force them to
change.

INTH3SHADOWS

I've just watched the video, they are talking of Madison. Is the
police officer connected to her?

Silentindex has left the group.

INTH3SHADOWS

Well, is he?

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Chapter Seventy-One

SOPHIE SALAM

Daya messaged Sophie every few hours through the night and into the early morning, updating her on Lottie's eating and playing. The cottage where they were staying was secure, and Sophie tried as best as she could to rest assured that the steps she had put in place to source and pay for the cottage would evade anyone trying to find them. There was no link between her and Jess Pendle, apart from in a professional capacity. Kendrick wouldn't ever think to look there.

Her daughter was as close to witness protection as possible without the authorities helping. She had done enough. Kendrick wouldn't find her, he couldn't. She was safe until Sophie worked out how to make it permanent and bring her home, and knowing she couldn't do this without a concrete plan, she spent the night and into the next day working on a solution. David McCosh's whereabouts was still unknown, but she had discovered Kendrick was due for release imminently. She had to find McCosh, or buy some time and then try to work out a way to ensure Kendrick wasn't ever released, either by providing evidence of the murder eight years before, or providing evidence of his part in the likely killing of Rob Mosley, all without incriminating herself. She also had to find a way to appease his curiosity about her daughter, without him wanting more.

So many things, so little idea where to start. But she needed to be proactive. As she wrote mind maps, and had ideas that had more questions and holes than actual plans, she knew that, without some sleep, she would never find a way out of the mess she was in. So, keeping the burner linked to her mum in her hand, and knowing Lottie was okay, she washed down two sleeping tablets, despite it being daytime, and closed her eyes. Just a few hours and she would be okay.

Sleep came fast and deep, and she was startled awake by three loud bangs on her front door. Panicking, thinking it was Kendrick's brother coming to offer a threat, she slowly moved towards her door. More loud bangs, making her jump. They were quickly followed by a voice.

'Sophie? Sophie, it's Clarke. Are you there?'

Grabbing the door handle, her hands shaking as she did, she opened it to see Clarke stood, a bead of sweat on his head from the heat of the day. He looked more concerned than she could ever remember.

'Where have you been? Is everything okay?' Clarke asked.

'Shit, what time is it?'

'Almost two.'

'Fuck. I was meant to be at work by noon.'

'I know. We've been trying to call for hours. The DI sent me here to make sure you were all right. Is Lottie okay?'

'She's fine, she's away with her nana. Is Hawkins pissed?'

'I'd give him a wide berth. Have you checked your phone?'

'No, why?'

'Another video has been posted.'

'Has he struck again?'

'Yep.'

'Shit.'

'Yep, this one is really shit.'

‘I need to be there,’ she said, moving back into her house to grab some shoes. She sat on the edge of her stairs, and put them on.

‘It’s been dealt with.’

‘By who?’

‘Don’t know his name, some DS came in from Cambridge.’

‘Why?’

‘Because no one could reach you. Soph, are you sure you’re okay? You look like shit.’

‘I’m fine,’ she snapped.

‘If there is anything going on, you need—’

‘I said I’m fine, Clarke, drop it.’

Clarke raised his hands in surrender.

‘Sorry,’ Sophie said.

‘All good. Can I come in? Or might you kill me?’

Sophie smiled. ‘Have to hedge your bets on that.’

Clarke smiled back. ‘I’ll take my chances.’

Closing the door behind him, Clarke leant against it, and looked down at Sophie as she struggled with her shoes. She looked up and saw him watching. ‘You’re looking at me like you’re about to tell me my dog died.’

‘You haven’t got a dog.’

‘I had a goldfish once. Bob. Mum flushed it down the loo but pretended it was in a little box, so I could bury it in the—’

‘You sure you’re all good, kid?’ Clarke said, cutting her off.

‘Yeah, yeah,’ Sophie said, sighing. ‘I’m tired, that’s all.’

‘You’re probably due some annual leave?’

She shook her head. ‘I’m not taking leave right now. Bad enough I missed the call on this case and some random had to come ... wait,’ Sophie said, stopping with only one of her shoes tied. ‘You just said, came *in* from Cambridge.’

Clarke nodded, his expression darkening into something serious. 'The Caretaker has killed here.'

'Here? When?'

'This morning. Video was posted at midday. How have you not seen this?'

'What do we know about the victim?' she replied, not wanting to answer his question.

'A lot. Sophie, it's DS Jones.'

'Sorry?'

'He's the victim. The Caretaker got to Jones.'

'Fuck.'

'Yep, fuck.'

'Has the scene been fully processed? Can I look?' she said, standing up awkwardly in one small heel.

Clarke shook his head. 'They've closed off the scene. It will be processed and then he'll be on his way to the morgue. I've requested I look at it. You can come too.'

'Are you sure?' Sophie asked. 'About being the one to process? Jones was...'

'From what I understand, not the best man. Besides, we weren't ever close. I'll be okay. Will you?'

Sophie thought for moment about seeing someone she knew on the slab, but it felt small compared to other problems she faced. 'I'll be fine. Do you have a copy of the video? If we can't go to the scene, I want to see what The Caretaker is saying.'

'Yeah.' Pulling out his phone, Clarke tapped it a few times and then put it in Sophie's hand. The screen was dark, the play icon sitting in the middle of it. She tapped it, and then sat back on her bottom step.

At first, nothing happened, then The Caretaker came into view on the screen, and straight away Sophie could tell this video was different.

‘Background isn’t the same.’

‘Sorry?’ Clarke said, coming and joining her on the bottom step.

‘The room, it’s not the same. In the others, the background is white.’

‘Okay?’

‘This one is cream.’

‘Is it?’

‘Yeah, and it’s lit differently, see, there is shadow on his right.

‘Okay?’

‘I’m pretty sure in the others it’s on his left. Hang on.’

Getting up, her gait an awkward limp because of the one shoe, Sophie went into her living room and grabbed her phone. Clarke followed, and she loaded an old video of The Caretaker, putting the two side by side.

‘Shit, how did you notice that without comparing?’

‘Watched them all a thousand times.’

Sophie continued to watch the new video, turning up the volume to hear his words.

‘...the law is there, as are its officers, to protect us, give power to the weak, enforce justice in a world that is full of darkness. The man who I have targeted is one I have visited before. To warn him. He did not heed my warnings. DS Jones is the worst I have killed. He abused his power, offering no protection to those who needed it because he was an abuser in his own life too. He messed up cases, and he is the reason a young woman, a beautiful woman and mother called Madison, is now dead. She came to him, and he could have saved her. But he failed to act. The police are powerless to stop me, and powerless to help you. Take your power back.

Fuck the police.’

The Caretaker leant forward to stop the recording, something Sophie noticed was usually edited out, suggesting this was recorded quickly, or by someone else. As he did, Sophie saw something that made her senses sharpen, like when she was about to break a case.

‘Shit, did he just indirectly tell people to kill?’ Clarke asked.

‘Hang on,’ Sophie said, tapping the screen so the timeline showed. She then scrolled back to just before The Caretaker turned off the video, and watched again.

As he reached with his left hand to stop the recording, his right went to his eye, and he rubbed it.

‘Soph?’

She didn’t reply, but rewound and watched again. It looked like The Caretaker was keeping in character right up until he finished saying what he needed to say. His shoulders dropped just before he reached for the camera, and as he did, the stress was there.

Rubbing the eye was a stress thing. Common, but Sophie had seen that particular way of rubbing an eye before, three half circles under the eye with the back of an index finger’s knuckle. She had a friend who did this often. A friend who knew about the cross that The Caretaker carved. Jess wasn’t just involved in knowing, she was involved in killing.

That night, sitting in Jess’s garden when she’d asked her if she had killed, Jess said no, and Sophie believed her. But now, she knew, the answer wouldn’t be the same.

‘I think we are looking at Jess Pendle,’ she said.

Clarke looked up from the phone at her. ‘You sure? If you bring her in again, and we don’t have enough to charge her, it will create a scene.’

‘I’m pretty sure.’

Clarke’s phone pinged. He looked at the message, and then back to Sophie. ‘Jones is on his way to the morgue.’

‘Okay,’ Sophie said, trying her best to push down the new grief she felt knowing she was about to arrest someone she had come to like a lot. ‘Okay, let’s go see him, shall we?’

Chapter Seventy-Two

Sophie had seen many dead bodies in her career, so many that, when they were on the slab, they were no longer people at all. They were compartmented to be a puzzle, a story; their soul was not for her to be concerned about, nor was their emotional state in their final moments. To survive the job, you had to leave the humanity at the door in order to solve their crimes and give them the justice they deserved. However, walking into the police mortuary side by side with Clarke, and seeing Jones lying on the slab, his body blackened from dozens of bruises that wrapped around puncture holes, it was hard not to think of the sheer terror of his final moments on this earth. Even though she didn't much like the man, she struggled to be objective. His death, his murder: it felt close.

Sophie could tell that Clarke felt it too; he wasn't his usual chipper self when she stood back and watched him clean and process the body. He was slower, more methodical, his brow was furrowed into a pensive state. As he narrated his findings for the recording, she could hear a tightness in his voice. And Sophie didn't interrupt but patiently waited for him to look up and smile at her, then pause the recording.

'This feels weird.'

'I bet,' she said quietly. 'You all right doing this?'

Clarke nodded. 'Yeah, yeah, I'm okay. Whoever did this to him, it looks personal.'

'Why?'

'He was gone, probably after the first couple of attacks. But they didn't stop. I've counted nineteen wounds. Four would have been enough. Likely, though, he would have died from the first one to two.'

Sophie nodded. Trying to picture Jess doing this, but she couldn't. 'And was this definitely our man?'

'Yep, a small cross was carved onto his chest. No doubt about it, it was The Caretaker who did this. Do you think what The Caretaker said about Jones is true? Do you reckon he messed up cases?'

'Maybe,' Sophie said. 'We know Jones had a target on his back. Somehow The Caretaker knew he was an abuser when none of us did. He warned him before. I guess Jones didn't listen to the warning.'

'Sophie, do you think this will ever stop?'

'I thought it might. The law is changing, women are getting more rights to protect themselves, charities are better funded. I thought when he saw enough change, he would. Now, now I don't know.'

'And are you sure, about that Pendle woman?'

Sophie nodded. 'Yeah, I am.'

'Think we need a warrant for her arrest?'

Sophie sighed, looked away from Jones's brutalised body to Clarke. 'I don't know. I might go round, ask if she'll come in for questioning.'

'Do you think it's her?'

'I do. But I don't have enough to kick her door down.'

'We asked her in for questioning before and she agreed. I don't think she would again, Sophie. Get a warrant. The DI is pissed already, this is going to make things so much worse. By the book on this. Okay?'

'Okay,' she said.

Chapter Seventy-Three

It took three hours for the Crown Prosecution Service to agree to issue a warrant to bring in Jess Pendle, three hours of Sophie having to convince not only her DI but the court that she had enough circumstantial evidence for them to bring her to the station, and search her flat. Jess Pendle's history with the case was already recorded, what clinched it was Sophie found proof that Jess was in the area at the time of the crime. She was seen on the CCTV from the coffee shop around the time the video was posted. She had opportunity.

She should have been elated, finally taking a step forward in the case; however, she felt anything but happy that someone she cared for, someone she looked for comfort in, was about to be arrested. But The Caretaker had to be stopped.

After the warrant was issued, a small team was put together to bring her in. Sophie didn't suspect Jess would put up a fight, but her place needed to be searched before anything incriminating could be moved or destroyed.

As she readied herself to leave, three cars in convoy, Clarke sat in the driver's seat beside her, she rang her mum from the burner. She had to be careful of what she said, she didn't want Clarke to ask questions.

'Hey, love, are you all right?'

'I'm fine, Ma, you both okay?'

‘All is fine. I’m being vigilant, but it’s so peaceful here. So safe.’

‘That’s good,’ Sophie said, a guilt inflating in her gut like a helium balloon, rising into her lung space, making her feel like she couldn’t breathe.

‘Are we any closer to you coming here, or us coming home?’ Daya asked.

‘I’ve still not worked it out,’ Sophie said, knowing that, after Jess was arrested and in custody, she would have to try and finish what Karl had asked her to do. Somehow. ‘Can I speak to Lottie?’

‘I’ll grab her now.’

Sophie waited for a moment, and then Lottie’s beautiful, light and hope-filled voice came to the phone.

‘Hi, Mummy.’

Upon hearing her daughter, she struggled not to cry. ‘Hey, darling, how are you?’

‘Good. Nana and me had fish and chips last night.’

‘Did you?’

‘Uh-huh. With ketchup, and Nana threw a chip and a seagull ate it and then about a hundred seagulls came.’

‘Oh no. Did they steal all your chips?’

‘I thought they were going to pick Nana up and fly away,’ Lottie said, beginning to laugh, and Sophie laughed, too, until tears laced with relief, grief and longing rolled down her cheeks.

‘It sounds like you’re having an amazing holiday.’

‘It’s the best, I want to be by the seaside forever.’

Sophie smiled, and then the smile faded when she wondered if Lottie would always have to be away from her. She wanted to see her girl so much, and wondered if she could sneak to the coast, but it wasn’t worth the risk. Lottie was safe, happy, she had to protect that.

‘Maybe when Mummy doesn’t have to work all the time, we can spend all of our summers by the seaside.’

‘Really?’ Lottie said.

‘Really,’ Sophie replied, and the lead car in the convoy began to pull out of the station car park. ‘Listen, darling, I have to go, can you put Nana back on?’

‘Okay.’

‘Love you.’

She wanted to hear Lottie say she loved her, too, but she was gone, and her mum was back.

‘I have to go for a while, Mum. I’ll check my phone as much as I can.’

‘All is good. Try not to worry.’

‘Okay.’

Hanging up, Sophie looked out of the window, and Clarke didn’t say a word.

The convoy pulled out of the station lot, and the silence was replaced with the sound of jeers from the street.

‘What the...’ Clarke said as he rounded the corner to see dozens of people outside the station, shouting abuse at the three cars as they navigated towards the main road.

‘The Caretaker said for people to fuck the police,’ Sophie said quietly, looking at a woman who was screaming at the car in front of theirs. Even through the closed window, she could hear her.

‘You’re meant to protect us, you’re all corrupt. I hope The Caretaker kills all of you.’

The woman spat at the car, and in ordinary circumstances, someone would have intervened, but they kept moving, slowly, so as to not accidentally hurt a protester and give more fuel to their raging fire. It took several minutes to clear the mob, and then they joined the main road, heading in the direction of where Jess lived.

‘It’s all gone to shit,’ Clarke said.

‘Yeah, well, maybe it will stop now.’

‘If you’re right, then yeah, maybe it will,’ he said, before pausing.
‘Sophie, where is Lottie?’

‘She’s with my mum, at the seaside. I wanted her away from all this for a bit.’

‘That’s nice. Sophie.’

‘Yeah?’

‘Why the burner phone?’ Clarke asked, not taking his eyes off the road.

‘It’s complicated.’

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Chapter Seventy-Four

JESS

Back when this all began, sat in Lewis's car, holding a towel to my face where he had hit me so hard I needed stitches, I reflected that Lewis had many, many faces. Lewis the protector, the compassionate. The aggressive. I had learnt in such a short space of time I did too. I had never felt exhaustion like the one after Jones. It was bone-deep, a numbness that consumed me from the inside out. After ensuring everything I had used had been destroyed, I wanted nothing more than to lock my door, close my eyes and sleep for an eternity. Jess the exhausted. But, despite my body screaming for it, sleep wouldn't come. When I closed my eyes, he was there. The moments the screwdrivers penetrated his body were there. The sound, a dull thud, rang over and over in my mind, a drum-scape I couldn't unhear. It was followed by the recollection of Jones wheezing as his lung collapsed. I was beginning to understand why Madison struggled so much. She was the best of us, the one with the most hope. I had no doubt the soundscape of her time as The Caretaker was what got to her in the end.

But, despite the sudden drop in adrenaline, rendering my body unable to move, and the visions and sounds of what I had done looping over and over, there was a peace there too. An understanding of my place in the world, even if it was only for a brief time.

Lewis broke me, the support group put me back together and The Caretaker had redeemed me. I was sure I would get away with it, too, as everyone else had, despite not having that precious little blue book of theirs. I was so sure, right up until there were three loud bangs on my front door telling me I wasn't.

I knew straight away it was the police. But the calm I felt didn't lift, and as I got up to go to the door, three more loud bangs rang through my flat.

'Jessica Pendle, it's the police, open the door.'

I didn't reply, nor did I speed up to their demand, and when I opened the door, several police officers were there, Sophie included.

'Can I help?' I asked, my voice giving only the slightest betrayal to my calm exterior.

'Miss Pendle,' Sophie began. 'We have a warrant to search these premises and arrest you.'

'What?' I said, feigning shock. Jess the overwhelmed.

'Make this easy for us, Miss Pendle,' Sophie said.

'Of course, DS Salam,' I said, stepping out of her way, so she and several others could come into my home. I counted them in, seven officers, excluding Sophie, and as they began to systematically, silently turn my life upside down, I looked at my friend.

'You look tired,' I said.

She blinked several times, then composed herself. 'Jessica Pendle, I am arresting you on suspicion of murder. You cannot leave and you do not have to say anything, but it may harm your defence if you do not mention when questioned something which you later rely on in court. Anything you do say may be given in evidence.'

'Okay,' I said, and I saw Sophie struggle not to cry. 'Don't worry, Soph.'

'What's happened to you?' she asked, and I shrugged my shoulders. 'I have to cuff you, Jess,' she continued, and I nodded, holding my hands out

in front of me. She put the cuffs on, but not as tightly as I thought she might. If I wanted to, I could have wriggled my left hand free. I didn't.

As the officers continued to flip my life upside down, I was led back into my living room and sat on the sofa. I watched Sophie working, leading, instructing people. She was direct, she knew her job. She was good as a leader. And for an hour, I sat and admired her in her element, whilst silently processing my steps, to ensure I had been as diligent as I needed to be in covering up my crime.

I had. Because, although several things were taken – my phone, the burner phone, too, the Signal app completely removed as well as Kimberley's number, and my laptop, which I expected, they didn't take anything else.

Sophie then came back to me, asked me to stand. 'Time to go.'

As I was escorted out of the front door, I was shocked to see several people on the street. Someone must have heard or seen the police coming into my flat.

'You can't arrest her,' a woman said. 'She's one of "the saved".'

'Leave her alone,' another said. 'Stop harassing victims and find the perpetrator.'

Sophie didn't comment, nor did any of the other officers.

'Jess, Jess,' another said and I looked up to see a phone pointing in my direction. 'What's happening?'

'Do not answer that,' Sophie warned, but as The Caretaker said, fuck the police, right?

'There has just been a misunderstanding,' I said, and Sophie shot me a look. But I didn't care, I knew how it looked, and I needed to put on another one of my many faces. Jess the innocent.

As I was bundled into the back of a car, the small gathering continued to shout at the police. I had no doubt that video shot, and many others, would begin to circulate on social media, and I knew my friends would see.

I just hoped they would come and help me, although I wasn't sure I deserved it.

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Chapter Seventy-Five

By the time I arrived at the station, word must have gotten out, the power of social media doing its thing to enable people to feel like my plight was also theirs, because there were so many people, young and old, waiting for my arrival. They swarmed the cars as they slowed, phones out, filming the spectacle to no doubt raise their own social media following. In amongst them, I saw some press too. Reporters talking into cameras discussing the latest twist in The Caretaker tale. It was a circus. I understood why. One of ‘the saved’ had now been arrested and I think people liked the idea of a victim being The Caretaker. They weren’t wrong, but, if all went to plan elsewhere, even with Sophie clearly having enough to arrest me, I wasn’t sure it would stick. She might be wiser than most to what was going on. However, soon, The Caretaker was to strike again elsewhere in the UK, and I knew that when he did, I would be released. I couldn’t be both in a police station and committing murder. If the public were riled now, they would explode when that happened. My only issue was I couldn’t remember if it was later, or the next day, or the day after, he was to kill. I guessed, until then, I would stay behind bars.

That was okay. The quiet would be nice.

The cars rolled into the station car park, the doors closing behind, blocking out the sea of faces, hungry for more. They wanted to see me, but

Sophie wouldn't allow it. I understood why.

As I was processed, I was reread my rights and the charges I faced. I looked at Sophie for something, anything of my friend who sat on my back doorstep looking at the stars. I tried to find the woman who kissed me. But she wouldn't look me in the eye, and then Sophie was gone, and someone else walked me to a holding cell, making me kick off my shoes before I was escorted in. The cuffs were removed, and the door firmly locked. I had been transferred. I was in the system. And I had to wonder what Sophie had up her sleeve. Before, when I had been questioned along with Kelly and Hannah and Madison, as well as several others, there had been no cuffs, no processing, no cells. And yet, here I was, in a small room no bigger than a garden shed, with a small bed, a sink and a toilet. And no instructions to do anything but wait. So, I lay down on the bed and closed my eyes, and as soon as I did, the thud of screwdriver and flesh came back. Over and over, *thud, thud, thud. Thud. Thudthudthud.*

The loops seemingly endless and strangely hypnotic. I knew I should have been worried Sophie had something, or I'd not be there. But I wasn't sure I cared anymore. The burden of what I knew was a lot to carry and, even though The Caretaker was soon to vanish, this time forever, I knew I would always be watched, always be considered someone of interest. Sophie and I, whatever the hell it was, was done. She was on one side of this, I was on the other, and there would be no way to ever change that. I should have been sad, but I was just too tired. Two weeks, they said, and without sleep a person lost their mind.

As I settled into the metronome of thuds looping in my shattered brain, I felt my muscles release from the tension I'd not shifted since Jones, and just as a gentle warmth, like a summer breeze at dawn, washed over me, I began to drift.

I didn't know how long I had slept, but it was long enough for my fingers to feel numb from lack of blood flow and for there to be an acrid

taste in my mouth. It could have been ten minutes, or ten days. And straight away, I couldn't place why I'd woken. Until the cell door groaned open and a uniformed female officer stepped in.

'Miss Pendle. Follow me, please.'

'Okay,' I said, getting to my feet, my mind swimming from the sleep I had just stirred from. I followed the officer down a long corridor, and each person we passed stopped and looked at me.

'Is that normal?' I asked.

'What?'

'For people to stare.'

'You've got everyone talking. Everyone,' she said, and offered no more as she led me into another room, one I had seen before when Sophie interviewed me months ago.

'Do we need to cuff you?' the officer asked, and I shook my head. 'Someone will be with you soon,' she said, leaving and closing the door behind her.

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Chapter Seventy-Six

SOPHIE SALAM

As Sophie watched the small monitor, which was a live feed to interview room one where Jess sat waiting, she tried to examine her body language, hoping to see anything that would give her away. A stress tic, a tear. But, aside from rubbing her eye like she did from time to time, like The Caretaker did in the video, Jess remained impassive. She had closed off, walled up. And despite their bond, Sophie knew there would be no way Jess would share anything like she did that night when they had drunk wine and sat on the back doorstep together. That moment, a pinch in time, would never return. She still didn't understand what it was – she'd never kissed a woman before – but it felt right. Safe. Trauma-driven or genuine bond, she would never know. Because Jess was on one side of the screen, and she was on the other. Any feelings she had for Jess Pendle, she had to push down. She was a suspect and needed to be treated like one.

She was so focused on watching her, reminiscing on moments past, that she didn't notice DI Hawkins enter the room.

'Salam,' he said, making her jump.

'Sorry, sir.'

'Has anyone been into her yet?'

'No, sir, we are making her wait. I want to see what she does.'

'Doesn't look like she's doing a lot. What's the plan?'

‘We make her sweat for as long as we can. She is now expecting one of us to come and talk to her. But we won’t.’

‘No? Why?’

‘If she is who we think she is, she likes control, to know what’s next. I want her to not know what’s coming, it will make her drop her guard.’

The DI nodded, and looked at the screen once more. ‘In all my years of policing, I can never get my head around how someone who can kill can look so...’ He trailed off.

‘Kind?’ Sophie offered.

‘Yes, kind. Look at her, she could be one of us.’

‘Yeah, she could, sir.’

‘If she is The Caretaker, if she is the one who killed DS Jones, I want her to suffer. I agree, Sophie, make her wait. Make her sweat. We have twenty-four hours before we have to release. I’ll get you more time. Just in case it’s needed.’

‘Thank you, sir.’

The DI nodded, turned and headed towards the door. He stopped when he got there and looked back. ‘DS Salam.’

‘Sir?’ Sophie said, turning to face him.

‘I hope you’re right on this. Outside there is a large crowd gathering, protesting for her release, and we are getting information from other constabularies that civil unrest is high. If we mishandle this, there will be riots. She has been interviewed before. If you are wrong, people will assume we are targeting her, a victim herself and one of “the saved”, as they call her. If you are wrong, the shitstorm coming our way is going to be hard to weather.’

Sophie didn’t reply, she simply nodded and, as the DI left, she turned her attention back to the screen. Jess hadn’t moved, but there was something different about her. Jess had a weight, a burden, that might be around her ex and his death, and lately, because of Madison. But it looked

like the weight was gone. She sat a little taller than usual. Was able to hold a stillness Sophie hadn't seen before.

Sophie knew deep in her bones she was right about Jess's involvement, but the DI's warning slapped her hard. She was right; however, proving it was another thing. She had twenty-four hours, maybe a little more, to get Jess to open up about the killings that had swept the country for almost six months and give her something that would result in a charge.

And she hated the fact that that was how it needed to end.

Having Jess escorted from the interview room back to the cell would make her wobble. She wouldn't expect that, especially if there was no explanation as to why. She would overthink, stress, and then the cracks might appear.

Sophie hated treating Jess like a criminal. But that's what she was, wasn't she? And she had twenty-four hours to prove it.

Sophie passed her instructions along to the holding officers that she wanted Jess taken back to the holding cell, and she watched on the screen as they did as they were told. She saw the confusion flash across her friend's face, and then she heard her name through the screen.

'Where is DS Salam?' Jess asked.

'Unavailable,' was all the holding officer said.

'Is she okay?'

Sophie knew they would think it was a strange question, but the holding officer didn't say anything back. Jess was walked towards the cell, and Sophie watched on another screen. The stillness she had was gone, she was looking around trying to find Sophie. Jess was worried for her despite Sophie arresting her.

Once they reached the cell, Sophie opened up the stream from the camera mounted high on the wall and heard Jess ask for her again. Once more, the officer said nothing, and then locked her in. For over thirty minutes, Sophie watched her. Her plan had worked, Jess's composure was

slipping, but not for the reasons she thought. She assumed Jess would wobble because of the lack of knowing what was coming next, but it wasn't that at all. Jess wasn't now unsettled because of lack of control, she was unsettled because she was worried about Sophie, and she wondered, would a killer really care so much?

‘Shit, Sophie, I hope you’re right about this,’ she said quietly to herself.

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Chapter Seventy-Seven

THE CARETAKER

The day had dragged, long and hot and endless, and The Caretaker patiently waited for darkness to come, the night to claim its right for time over the world, and for Richard Planter to finish work. He hadn't waited without task, though: the blue book had arrived earlier in the day. Dropped off by what he assumed was the previous Caretaker, without conversation. They simply tapped on his front door, handed him the book and left. He read about the other Caretakers' thoughts, focusing mostly on the final section of the manifesto, knowing that this kill might be the last.

The goal is not a world without harm, that is fantasy. The goal is interruption. A pause long enough for someone else to live. If The Caretaker disappears one day, it will be because it is no longer needed, not because it was defeated, exposed or purified. Until then, it remains what it has always been. A last resort. A terrible mercy. A hand steady enough to do what others will not, and strong enough to carry the cost.

Empowered by knowing he was able to be that last resort, that terrible mercy, he began to transfer what he had gathered on his target into the book. Richard Planter, fifty-eight, left-handed. Amateur boxer back in the Eighties. Liked a pale ale, followed the rugby, father to two boys who he saw once or twice a year. Both men in their twenties.

Wife beater.

His spouse, Caroline, had somehow hidden the assaults for over twenty years from everyone in her life, including her sons, until two years before when one of their boys came home and witnessed his dad attacking his mum. There was a fight. Richard was arrested but promised to change. Caroline, married to him for so long knowing no other life, and fearful of starting again alone, opted to believe him, and somehow managed to convince everyone the same.

She didn't go to the police when the assaults started again a year ago, she found Kimberley's charity instead, and now The Caretaker.

Richard had his chance to change, but old dog and new tricks.

And it was time for this old dog to be put down.

With the book ready, The Caretaker hid it and, preparing the bag as instructed to in the book, he waited for the end of the day, learning that Jess Pendle had been arrested in connection to The Caretaker killings. He didn't worry. Soon, it would be publicly proved she couldn't be The Caretaker, and the video for the media, which would be released after Planter's demise, would say as much. Pendle would have a rough night in a shitty police cell, but she'd be home before tomorrow night was done.

Planter worked as a security guard at the town's museum. At 11pm, he would leave to go to his car, walking through the grounds of Sweetheart Abbey where he'd proposed to Caroline back in the Eighties. The grounds were shut, but there were gaps in the fence, and after following him, The Caretaker understood that he liked the peace, the stillness. If you didn't know Richard Planter was a man who thought with his fists, you would think he was a poet.

The walk would take him only a few minutes. And when he did walk, The Caretaker would be waiting.

Until then, The Caretaker paced, anxious and ready and terrified after what happened in Slough, and to one of 'the saved', and in Milton Keynes. But he also knew this one would likely be the last. That final last resort. It

seemed the new law was going to be passed imminently, placing everyone who had been charged with domestic abuse on a public register, so anyone, at any time, could look for a man or woman to learn if they had a history of assault. There was already some provision for this, with the most violent offences, but it wasn't publicly accessible with ease. This new database, anyone could search with a few taps of an iPhone. It didn't help those who were living in secret, but it would stop others becoming victims. The Caretaker had no doubt, of the original 'saved', at least two of them would have avoided becoming a victim if this law had been in place before.

It was change, real change, forever change. After one final kill. It had to be public, it had to be one no bad man would ever forget.

Sweetheart Abbey: it seemed almost cruel, but it would never be forgotten, and as the sun began to wane, The Caretaker checked his rucksack one final time. Gloves, hat, face mask, tape. Lots of tape. Size ten wellies, overalls, taser, thick clear plastic bag. After repacking it all, confident he was ready, he made his way towards the centre of the town and the romantic grounds where he would display what would be the final kill of his short and infamous career.

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Chapter Seventy-Eight

When learning who Planter was, following him, observing his patterns and habits, The Caretaker discovered his little lonely walks across the abbey grounds, which would be the perfect place to ambush him. It was only then did he learn it was ironically called Sweetheart Abbey. He wanted to know why, and with a little research discovered that, in the abbey itself, the heart of a man called John Balliol was embalmed and placed in an ivory casket by his grieving wife in 1268. His heart would rest there forever, a symbol of eternal love, and soon, Planter's would stop, a symbol of eternal change.

Reaching the abbey thirty minutes before Planter would finish work and begin on his way home, The Caretaker snuck in the same way his target would. Once inside, away from anyone being able to see, he went to the place he knew Planter would pass, hid himself in a small copse of trees, and prepared. Meticulously putting on and taping in the clothes he would later destroy. He worked slowly, enjoying the attention to detail, the final trills of evening bird song a companion for his work. Once fully secure inside the persona of The Caretaker, he put the thick plastic bag in his trouser pocket, and placed his rucksack down to be collected later. Then, unzipping the front pocket, he removed the larger roll of tape and the taser.

What he planned to do he hoped he had strength for; if not, he had a backup. Either way, Planter would be displayed, the message clear.

Waiting on the edge of the treeline, the silence of the night took hold. The bird song eased to a gentle stop, and aside from the hum of cars on the main road outside the grounds, there was nothing but the whisperings of a breeze through the trees, like something divine was conspiring with him. The gentle murmur of support for what he was doing. After, alongside retelling the event that would be the end of Richard Planter, in all of its detail, for posterity, he would talk of the supporting breeze.

The breeze calmed his thoughts, slowed his heart, and peace washed over him. He had read in the book how when it was time there was a stillness. He didn't understand at first, but now, waiting with only the whisperings of God, he got it.

The calm was stopped abruptly with the sound of gravel under foot, and looking over his right shoulder, around the tree he sat against, he could see Planter walking towards him.

Getting to his feet carefully so he wasn't seen, The Caretaker waited for Planter to pass, his gait heavy and slow, his footsteps suggesting his day had been long and tiring. The Caretaker dared to look. From the way Planter moved, he was dead on his feet. Each step was leaden, each step looked pained. He was no doubt in a bad mood, which, historically meant Caroline would take the brunt.

Not tonight. Not. Ever. Again.

Keeping in the treeline, The Caretaker moved parallel to Planter. Ahead, the path swept to the left, closer to the trees, and then for a short while trees lined both sides of the path. It was there The Caretaker would strike. Hidden from the world in a darkened tunnel of foliage, he would step out and render Planter powerless to save himself.

In order to ambush, The Caretaker moved ahead of his unsuspecting prey, noticing that as he moved the rustling sounds intensified, masking his own footsteps so his target couldn't hear, and once in the tree tunnel, he hid

behind the thickest there. One he had identified as a good place to wait on one of his many reccies.

Planter approached, his footsteps on gravel growing louder as he inched closer, and ensuring the taser was on, The Caretaker took a deep breath.

Planter passed so close, The Caretaker could smell his cheap aftershave, and then, no sooner than the older man's back was to him, he struck, firing the taser right into the back of his neck.

Planter's body tensed instantly, his head snapping upwards before he collapsed to the floor. Face down, he moaned, and then, to The Caretaker's surprise, he began to try to pull himself back onto his feet. The old boxer refusing to stay down for the ten-count.

He tasered his target again, this time for longer, holding down the trigger until Planter was rendered unconscious.

It was time to work.

Grabbing Planter's limp arm, he dragged the man towards a tree, the effort quickly sapping strength from his muscles, and once there, he propped him into a sitting position. Then, before he could regain consciousness, he pulled a long line of tape free from the roll, and stuck it to Planter's chest, before wrapping it around the tree over and over until most of the roll had been used and he had secured him in place. He needed to keep a little of the tape back for what came next. Planter was now unable to fight, or escape, and was completely at the mercy of his attacker.

He didn't want to stay long, the risks were higher in public, but he did want Planter to be awake before his end. So, sucking in lungfuls of sweet summer air, he listened to the trees and waited. Only a few minutes passed, and Planter was swimming into consciousness. At first he was confused, then as his eyes adjusted to the darkness, and as he saw the man before him, confusion turned into panic.

The Caretaker had seen enough, and before Planter could say anything, beg for his life, or spit vile words, he pulled the bag from his pocket, and

placed it over the head of his target. Planter tried to shake himself free, but it was useless, and The Caretaker, holding the bag on his head, began to wrap tape around his neck, sealing him in.

Planter writhed as best he could, trying to suck air into his lungs. He sucked so hard the bag stuck to his face, the plastic forming a vacuum in his open mouth. The Caretaker watched as he began to shake, his body fighting to survive until it was reduced to involuntary twitches as his nervous system continued to fire, unaware he was dead.

Satisfied his work was done, The Caretaker packed away his things, and keeping in the treeline, returned to his bag. Removing everything that would identify him as The Caretaker, he walked across the abbey's grounds and, climbing though the fence, the same fence Planter would have climbed, he disappeared into the night. To return home, continue with his life, and watch the lasting change happen.

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Chapter Seventy-Nine

JESS

After being escorted back from the interview room without a single question being fired my way, or an explanation as to why the interview was cancelled, almost thirty-six hours had passed. A day and a half of waiting for someone to come and charge me, or question me. Thirty-six hours of knowing that Sophie knew the truth and was probably finding the smoking gun that would bury me forever. I had made my phone call, late the night before when the hours started to seem too long and frightening. I wanted to call Kelly, but I couldn't drag her down, so I called the only other solicitor I had ever met, Samual. He came within the hour, in the middle of the night, and despite me having walked away from my job, when we saw each other the kindness, love and care were still there. I could tell he wanted to hug me but stopped himself.

'Hi, Jess.'

'Thank you for coming, Samual.'

'Of course. I saw online they had arrested you. I was always going to come.'

'How are the kids?' I asked.

'Missing you.'

He smiled, one that was genuine and caring. Then I saw his demeanour shift, and he became serious, focused.

‘Okay, in interview, at this stage, don’t even say no comment. Don’t even speak, that is your right.’

‘Why?’

‘We need to see what they think they have on you first. I want them to lay out their cards. I’ve been told that they have extended the time they have to question you.’

‘*If* they question me.’

‘Pardon?’

‘They took me to interview, I waited and they then brought me back to the cell.’

‘I see. They are trying to get in your head. Keep quiet, okay? Let’s find out what they want to say. They have only a finite time to either charge or release you. We just sit tight. When they do call you for interview, you make them call me, and then you don’t say a word until I arrive.’

‘Okay.’

After he left, I returned to my cell, and waited for either to happen. And in that time, the night morphing to day outside my tiny windowless room, I knew, if they were to charge me with killing Jones, despite what Samuel was saying, I would confess to them all. Kelly, Hannah and I had barely spoken since Madison’s death. And even though I blamed them just as much as I did Jones and myself for our friend taking her life, I loved them and had to protect them. They had suffered enough.

When they did come to escort me for interview, I was exhausted, my brain fried, and I realised that must have been Sophie’s plan. Weaken my resolve and I would slip up. Make me worry and I would say something that would incriminate me.

As I entered the same interview room I waited in before, I was surprised to see Samuel sat there already. Suit and tie, waiting for the interview to begin.

‘Are you all right?’ he asked.

‘Yeah, yeah, I’m okay. What time is it?’

‘Just after midnight.’

‘Why are they doing this now?’

‘Because you’re tired. They want that. Stay calm.’

‘Easier said than done,’ I said, and I took a seat beside him. The officer who escorted me in then left, and after a few minutes of us sitting in silence, I worked it out. They’d arrested me after lunch two days before. If Samuel was right, and they only had a limited amount of time, why were they leaving me alone for so long? It didn’t make sense. Why wait until the end to talk to me? Unless they were sure that the thirty-six hours was going to be further extended somehow. It rattled me, but Samuel, calm and composed, steadied my nerves until Sophie walked in.

‘Good evening, Miss Pendle.’

‘Detective Salam,’ I said, trying to catch her eye. She looked tired. More tired than I felt, and I could see there was something else too. Stress, maybe. The case was spiralling. Maybe it was because she now had the proof she needed to charge me and she was struggling with her friend being a murderer.

‘This conversation will be recorded, and anything you say can be used as evidence in court. In the room is Detective Sergeant Sophie Salam, Jessica Pendle and her representative.’

She looked at Samuel, who spoke on cue. ‘Samual Wright.’

Sophie sat opposite me, and from the way she presented, even as tired as she looked, I knew the interview had formally begun.

‘Miss Pendle. Do you know why you are being interviewed today?’

I looked at Samuel, who gently shook his head, and then I looked back at Sophie, holding her eye. I wasn’t going to say a word. But I knew, even with Dumfries pending or even already actioned, I wasn’t getting out of this now. Sophie had a look, one that told me I was going down.

Chapter Eighty

SOPHIE SALAM

For over thirty minutes Sophie questioned Jess, where she was on the morning of the 28th July when DS Jones was killed, and the 18th February, the night Jones was accosted on a beach in Cromer by The Caretaker. She asked about the support group, Kelly, Hannah and Madison. She asked about the charity they had all gotten involved with, but whatever she did ask, whatever direction she moved in, Jess stonewalled her. Her solicitor barely spoke either. He wrote down everything Sophie said, and when she had exhausted all avenues, the interview was terminated, and Jess was taken back to her cell, her solicitor following.

After he left, Sophie watched her friend through the live camera feed in the cell. She didn't do a lot, mostly she lay on the bed, curled on her side. She wasn't asleep, Sophie didn't think, and she wanted to know what was going on in her friend's mind. She wanted desperately to believe Jess didn't kill Jones, but, with what she knew of her friend, even if none of it could stand up in court, Jess had to be him. She had to be The Caretaker. There was no doubt she'd had help. In the videos, the person on screen was a lot bigger, apart from the latest one. Sophie was sure her friend had killed.

As she watched, Jess's mouth began to move, and Sophie tried to read her lips. She couldn't. But it looked like she was beginning to unravel. The walls would come crashing down soon, and she felt conflicted, as a

detective. This was good news. Jess would talk, eventually. But as a woman, seeing her friend clearly struggling so much broke her heart.

‘Are we getting anywhere with her?’ a voice came from behind, and she turned to see DI Hawkins.

‘Nothing yet, sir. She’s not said a word. We will try again soon.’

‘We need something, Sophie, something solid. An officer, a colleague has been killed and, if this woman is who you think she is, we need to pin it on her.’

‘I know, sir.’

‘Court of public opinion is running high. Jess Pendle has become some sort of celebrity. If—’

He stopped as the door opened and another officer walked in. ‘Sorry, sir.’

‘What is it?’

‘He’s posted another video.’

‘Who?’

‘The Caretaker. He’s posted again, from Dumfries in Scotland. He’s killed another man.’

DI Hawkins shot Sophie a look, and she pulled out her phone and began searching for the latest post, finding it on TikTok. Loading the video, she looked at Jess once more on the monitor. Her eyes were now closed. It looked like she had finally fallen asleep.

The Caretaker came into view, and straight away, Sophie could see that the way it was shot, the location and lighting and framing was identical to all the others before the one she thought Jess was in. As he spoke, his voice mechanical and indistinguishable, she felt both disappointed and relieved in equal measure.

‘Tonight, I have struck again. Another bad man, a man who suffocated his wife, has met the same fate. The police have got it wrong: Jess Pendle is one of my “saved”, she is not me. No one but me is me. Her arrest is

unwarranted, and this video is proof of her innocence. I have killed, in Scotland, at the same time she is in a police cell.

I will continue to do my work until the proposed law has been passed, and the abuser database is a reality. Until then, Detective Sophie Salam, know, no matter how hard you look, you will never find me, and arresting victims will only cause you harm.'

The video ended, and Sophie looked up at her DI.

'Go home, Sophie.'

'But, sir—'

'I'm not asking you. It's very likely Jess Pendle's solicitor will file a harassment complaint. You have the wrong person.'

'No, sir, please, just—'

'Go home, Sophie, that's an order. You're off this investigation until further notice. Get some rest, you're done with The Caretaker. We'll fix this.'

'What about Jess?'

'Jess? Don't you mean Miss Pendle?'

'Miss Pendle.'

'What have you actually got other than a gut feeling and one thing placing her near to Jones in the city where they both live? We discovered nothing in her home. You're obsessing with this, and you're making mistakes. We have arrested the wrong person before, that man who looked after the facility where the support group met. The outrage was only just manageable. God knows what will happen now. Pendle will be released with our apologies and you aren't to go near her again. Understand?'

'Sir, I really believe that—'

'Do you understand, Detective Sergeant?'

Sophie wanted to protest, to tell him about the conversation with the cross and her small tell on the video she made, but she knew she couldn't.

'Yes, sir.'

The DI nodded, and then his expression softened. ‘Sophie, you’ve had a lot going on, you’ve done good work with this case, but we can all see you’re fried at the moment. Get some rest, spend some time with Lottie. There will still be a lot of work to do. The Caretaker is naming you again. I need you away from this.’

‘Sir, I really need this.’

‘And that’s why I’m taking you off it. This is our job, our vocation, but we shouldn’t need a case to be okay, especially one like this. Take some time. You’ve put in the hours, it won’t affect your leave entitlement.’

Knowing the DI wouldn’t change his mind, Sophie nodded, and the DI turned and left. Glancing back at the monitor, she looked at Jess who was sound asleep. She slept like a woman who didn’t have a care in the world. From the outside, she was wrongfully arrested, but Sophie knew Jess Pendle had killed DS Jones. She knew Jess understood everything about what was happening. And she knew she wouldn’t ever be able to prove it.

Grabbing her things off her work desk, Sophie headed out of the station, got in her car, and as she did, she called her mum. She needed to know something in her life wasn’t falling apart, and hearing that Lottie was asleep, safe, enjoying the seaside would be enough.

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Chapter Eighty-One

THE NETWORK GROUP CHAT

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

I have received an email just now, stating that in light of Dumfries and the public display of the latest victim of The Caretaker, an emergency COBRA meeting was initiated where the database law, Esme's Law, was passed.

THESUNMAID

What does that mean?

THE NETWORK SUPERVISOR

In the beginning, The Caretaker was trying to support four women who needed help to survive. Since, he has ensured all four corners of the United Kingdom know that all women will be safe, one way or another. We set out with this to create lasting change. This law is the start of that. There is more work to do, but this new law being passed will ensure conversations will continue to happen, now and always.

The Caretaker's work is now done. If you need help, support groups up and down the country will be there for you, always. However, this platform has reached the time to close. Be happy everyone. See you all, no doubt, in the future at a healing event.

The Network Supervisor has closed the group.

Chapter Eighty-Two

JESS

When the door to the cell opened, stirring me from my fitful sleep, I expected to see Sophie there, but it was Samual, and assuming he was coming to tell me I was being charged with the murder of DS Jones, I bolted upright.

‘Home time, Jess.’

‘Sorry?’

‘You are being released. Pending further investigations.’

‘What’s happened?’

‘Grab your stuff. I’ll tell you when we are out of here.’

Doing as Samual suggested, I stepped out of the cell to a waiting holding officer who gave me my shoes. I was taken back to the booking-in desk where I collected all of my things. Then, without any ceremony, I was told I could leave.

‘Just like that?’

‘Yep, just like that.’

Walking towards Samual’s car, I wasn’t sure what to think. I was convinced Sophie was gathering her smoking gun to bury me, and I was ready to take the fall for all of us. Being released wasn’t in my mind at all. I asked Samual, and he filled me in on what he knew. The Caretaker had struck, and in his video stated clearly I wasn’t involved. Kimberley was

helping, even from afar, and I didn't deserve such kindness. I had known, of course, that Dumfries was happening and the police would have to reevaluate, but I didn't think I was going to get out. I was so sure Sophie had something to pin Jones on me, something concrete. From my flat, or a mistake at the scene. But, apparently, I had covered my tracks well.

'Shall I take you home? I would say come to ours, but the kids, they are a little unsettled at the moment.'

'Are they okay?' I asked.

'Will saw you on the TV being arrested. He's scared for you.'

'I'm so sorry.'

'It's okay. He'll calm, and when things have settled fully, we want you back.'

'Thank you,' I said, beginning to cry. Even doing so much wrong, I was still able to be loved.

'So, home?' he asked again, and I knew I should say yes, home would be perfect. But selfishly I didn't want to be alone. I had wronged people I loved, and I wanted to try to make amends. Somehow. I told him an address, and without asking questions he nodded and took me back to where all this began.

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Chapter Eighty-Three

As Samual pulled up on Kelly's drive, he turned and looked at me. 'Want me to wait?'

I looked at Kelly's house. Her car was on the drive, Hannah's too. 'No, I'll be okay.'

'If you need anything, Jenny and I, we are here for you. Anything at all.'

'Thank you.'

I kissed him on the cheek, suddenly aware I'd not showered or brushed my teeth in days, and then, embarrassed at how dishevelled I must have looked, I got out and walked towards Kelly's door. Samual waved as he turned and left, and before I knocked, I composed myself. As the door opened, Kelly was there, and I expected her to say something, maybe even tell me to fuck off. But she stepped into my space, wrapped her strong arms around me and hugged me until I felt myself melting into her embrace.

'Hannah,' she called over her shoulder, and when she came, she, too, didn't speak. She ran to me and Kelly and joined in the embrace, and for a full minute we stood there.

When our hug broke, all three of us had tears in our eyes.

'We wanted to come to the station, but—' Hannah started and I stopped her.

‘It’s okay. You don’t hate me, do you? About it all, Jones, I—’

‘Stop, it’s okay.’

‘It wouldn’t be if it wasn’t for Kimberley and that last video.’

‘That wasn’t Kimberley,’ Hannah said.

‘Who was it, then?’

‘Me,’ Kelly said. ‘We love you, Jess, as much as we loved Madison.’

I nodded, another tear falling.

‘But, darling,’ Kelly continued. ‘You need a shower.’

I started laughing, she did, too, and Hannah joined in.

‘Come on, let’s get you smelling human again.’

Kelly led me into her house, and I felt so fragile, like a small child needing comfort. And the realisation of how I had been since Madison died hit me. I was close to losing it, close to ending up in a place I would never return from, and maybe I still would. But in that moment, I thought perhaps it would be okay.

Kelly led me to one of her guest rooms. I quickly showered and when I got out, there were clean clothes waiting for me. They were a little snug, Kelly was leaner than I, but they were clean and comfortable, and when I went downstairs into the huge hosting space where I’d first discovered The Caretaker’s plan and was inaugurated into it, I was surprised to see that with Hannah and Kelly was another, a quieter member of the support group.

‘Hey, kid,’ Geoff said, coming to me and taking me in his arms.

‘Hey, Geoff.’

‘Tea?’

I laughed. Same old Geoff. ‘Please.’

Geoff kissed me on the forehead, something he had never done before, and as he made the tea, I went and sat with my friends, melting into the sofa, which might have been the most comfortable I had ever sat on. What I had done to Jones would always be there, but with time, maybe it would dull.

Looking to my friends, I could see both Hannah and Kelly waiting for me to speak, and knowing they deserved as much, I began to talk. I stayed as honest as I could about how I felt. I spoke of how I felt we were to blame for Madison's death, and of the rage that consumed me. I spoke of what I did to Jones, and how it brought some peace. I spoke of losing my job, of how I was sure I was losing my mind, how I struggled with Kelly meeting someone like what had happened didn't matter, and then I spoke of Sophie. Of how we had drawn closer. I spoke of our night looking at the stars, and my slip-up that was proof I was involved in The Caretaker killings.

'I think that's why she arrested me, because of that night. But she shouldn't have been there with me, so she can't use the knowledge she has.'

I expected Kelly to berate me for being so foolish with my closeness to the lead detective in our case, but she didn't, she simply listened, and when I ran out of energy to talk, she took my hand.

'You shouldn't have faced all this alone. None of it. And you're right, we all failed Madison, every one of us and we all have to carry that. But we carry it together.'

'I'm sorry,' I said quietly.

'Me too,' she said.

Geoff, who had made the teas but kept his distance until I had spoken my truth, came and joined us and the four of us raised our mugs to Madison, before we fell into quiet conversations around what we did now. The law The Caretaker was fighting for had been passed, Esme's Law. Six months before, we had ended The Caretaker, buried him, but he had a resurgence because more was needed. Now, he could rest forever, and maybe, maybe we could too.

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Chapter Eighty-Four

SOPHIE SALAM

By the time Sophie got home, she was ready for sleep. The drive back from the station was the longest of her life, and en route she had tried to call her mum. The phone rang and rang before it disconnected. She noticed it was almost 3am. Mum would be asleep. In a few hours, she would wake up, and then maybe Sophie would feel calmer. For now, she had to rest. There was nothing else to do.

Kicking her shoes off by the front door, Sophie walked upstairs, and without even taking her clothes off, she climbed into her bed and closed her eyes. Sleep came quickly, driven by both mental and physical exhaustion. A dreamless state, heavy and consuming, and when she opened her eyes, at first she couldn't place where she was, or why she had stirred.

Then she realised the burner was ringing out, her mum's, the tune tinny and looping over and over. She fumbled for it in her pocket and pulled it up to her ear.

'Ma?'

On the other end, she heard gentle moaning.

'Mum, are you okay?'

'Sophie,' Daya said, her voice broken, distant.

'What's happening?'

'They took her, Sophie, they took her.'

Sophie jumped up, her heart thundering in her chest like she had been struck by lightning. ‘What do you mean? Where is Lottie?’

‘They took her,’ Daya said again, this time beginning to wail. ‘I tried to stop them, they attacked me. I don’t know how long I’ve been unconscious. They came, and broke in, and she’s gone. Sophie, she’s gone.’

As her mum cried uncontrollably on the line, her other burner phone began to vibrate. It was an unknown caller.

‘Hello?’ She said, her voice shaking.

‘Hello, Sophie. I trust you are well?’ Kendrick’s brother said.

‘Give her back.’

‘We will, but first, Karl wants an update on McCosh. You’ve been awful quiet.’

‘I’m trying to find him.’

‘He don’t think you are trying hard enough. Said you needed an incentive.’

‘I found the one before, I’ll find this man too. You don’t have to do anything.’

‘Oh but—’

‘Give her back now.’

‘Now, now, Sophie. I wouldn’t be like that. Don’t forget we know what we know. Don’t forget you owe him. And keeping a daughter from him. That’s low. What kind of—’

She cut him off. ‘If you’ve hurt her!’

‘Hurt her? I’m offended. She’s my niece. Nice kid. Be a shame if anything happened to her, or her mother.’

‘I’ll find McCosh,’ Sophie said, defeated.

‘That’s better. She’ll stay safe until you find him. If you go to the police, I won’t be able to promise that will stay the case. Besides, you can’t, can you? Too many skeletons and all that.’

‘I’ll track him down. Just don’t hurt her, please.’

‘Say sorry to your mum for me. I didn’t want to do what I had to do, but she was scrappy.’

The line went dead, and Sophie felt her world begin to cave in around her. An octopus blackness threatened to swallow her, and if it wasn’t for her mum’s sobs on the other phone, she might have let it.

‘Ma?’

‘What do we do?’

‘Don’t call the police. Are you hurt badly?’

‘I’m okay. I’ll be okay. I’m so sorry, Sophie. I tried to stop them.’

‘Sit tight. I’ll get help, okay? I’ll call an ambulance. Say you fell down the stairs.’

‘Lie?’

‘Lottie’s life depends on it. Say nothing, Mum, I’m gonna sort this.’

‘How?’ Daya asked. And Sophie hesitated.

‘I’m gonna sort this,’ she echoed.

Hanging up, Sophie ran down the stairs. She needed help, but the police weren’t able to. She would lose it all. She needed someone with eyes everywhere to find her girl, and if not the police, she knew one organisation that could help.

Unlocking her phone, her real one, she sent a message. It was direct, and she hoped, if she knew Jess like she thought she did, she would reply.

Lottie has been taken. I can’t go to the police. I need you.

She waited and waited for a message back, pacing and crying and dry-heaving as the shock settled in. Her daughter had been taken, she had failed to keep her safe, and she could be God knew where. After ten minutes, Jess hadn’t messaged, and she knew she was alone.

Then, her phone rang.

‘Jess? Oh God. Jess.’

‘Don’t say anything. Come to Kelly’s,’ Jess replied.

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Chapter Eighty-Five

Sophie drove frantically, jumping red lights and swerving around the few cars and vans out on the road. Arriving at Kelly's address, she saw that Jess, Kelly and Hannah were waiting for her. They didn't speak, but took her into the house and out to the large dining area at the back of the property. Geoff was there, a man she had wrongly accused, and without judgement, he handed her a hot tea.

'Drink this, it will help,' he said.

She nodded, but didn't speak, she couldn't. Shock had fully set in, so much so she was sure she would pass out.

Jess took her hand, and gently guided her to a sofa, sitting her down. The others sat opposite.

'Talk to me,' Jess said.

'They have her.'

'Who?' Kelly asked.

'Karl Kendrick. He is—'

Kelly interrupted. 'We know who he is.'

'I don't know where to turn. I can't go to the police.'

'And how do you think we can help?' Kelly asked.

'You three, Madison, too, you started something. I think you have all been The Caretaker.'

No one commented, they just held her eye, inviting her to continue to talk.

‘Then, I think it got larger. I think The Caretaker is now at least ten different women. Women who know how to track and watch and learn. And execute.’

‘Haven’t you heard? The Caretaker has just struck in Scotland. It’s nothing do with us,’ Kelly said.

‘I know. I can’t prove it. But I’ve known for months it’s you. I need your help. I need The Caretaker. They have my girl. Kendrick, he is a bad man and, although he is Lottie’s father, I don’t know what he will do to her. I was told to find a man, I can’t and if I don’t...’ She trailed off. ‘Jess, I know you killed Jones. I don’t care. I don’t. Anything we have on you, I’ll make it vanish. Please. I don’t know how you’ve done it, but I know you have people everywhere. I need the support group—’

‘Network,’ Hannah said.

‘Sorry?’

‘It’s a network now.’

‘You have eyes, lots of eyes, I don’t know how many, but at least ten sets, and I need you to help me find a man. McCosh. If I find him, he’ll give her back to me. He’ll kill her, Jess. Please, help me find McCosh. Help me bring her home.’

Jess looked to Kelly, who nodded. ‘We will help you. But, in order for us to know you won’t use this against us—’

‘I won’t, I swear, this is about my girl.’

‘Then we need guarantees.’

‘Anything, I’ll do anything,’ Sophie begged, and Jess took her hand.

‘Sophie,’ Kelly started. ‘The network leader will help and get every woman we have focused on this for you. For Lottie. For that to happen, we need you to be like us. The Caretaker is now supposed to vanish forever, with Esme’s Law being passed. But, if you want our help, we need to know

for sure you won't come for us after. Do you understand what I'm saying? Do that, and the whole network will find this man for you.'

Sophie nodded, and looked from Kelly to Jess. She didn't want to blink, have her resolve slip. She needed her friend to know she meant every word, despite being a police officer.

'I'll do it. I'll be The Caretaker.'

'Okay, then,' Jess said. 'Sophie Salam, welcome to the Serial Killer Support Network.'

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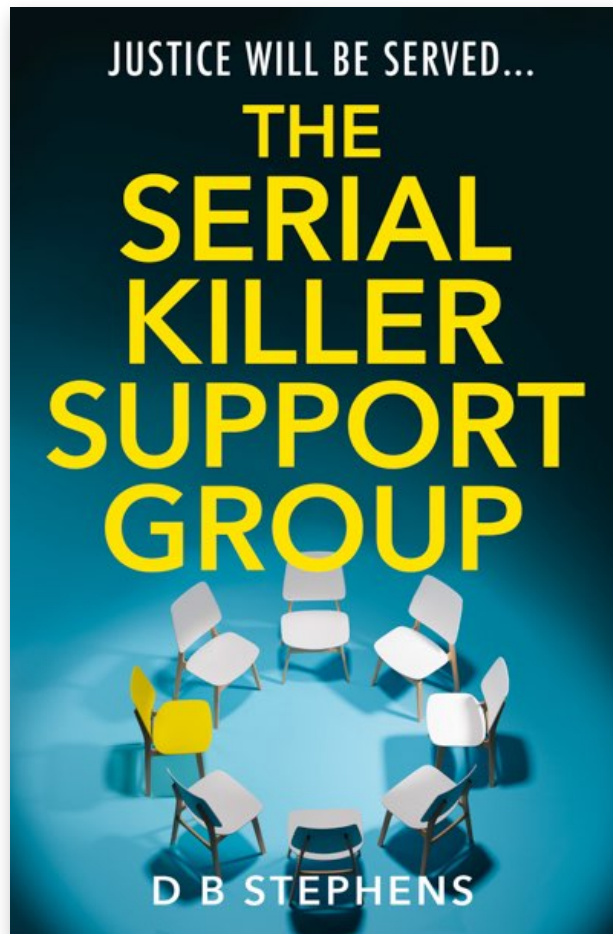
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